



CHAPTER ONE

The Early Years

LIFE WAS TOUGH for young Paan Singh, in Talasaalam village in Almora district, which rests in the shadow of the Kumaon hills of the Himalaya range.

Though there is now a bus that reaches the village in Uttaranchal state, back in 1964 (when it was part of Uttar Pradesh) there was no road to speak of and the only way to get there was on foot through rough and rocky terrain.

No wonder the tourist brochure claims the inhabitants of the land are ‘amazingly fit and strong with the ability to perform highly arduous tasks’. Paan inherited strong, healthy genes—which he passed on to his children.

Farming was a tough grind and unprofitable too and that is what drove the young Paan—armed with very little education but loads of determination—first to Lucknow in vain search of a job.

From there he crossed the country to Bokaro in Bihar where Hindustan Steel Limited was building a new steel plant, then finally to Ranchi where he landed a job with the Metallurgical and Engineering Consultants Ltd (or Mecon). Initially he was taken on as an unskilled worker on daily wages. He worked his way up and eventually retired as a work supervisor.

In 1969 he was married to Devki Devi, from Nainital. Their son, Mahendra Singh Dhoni, was born in Ranchi (then in Bihar, now Jharkhand) on 7 July 1981. He was preceded by his brother, Narendra, and his sister Jayanti, four years his senior.

Narendra till recently lived in Almora, where he looked after the property the family owned there, before moving back to Ranchi to work on projects connected to his brother's cricketing career. There is still a considerable family presence in Almora.

In his role as a pump operator it had been Paan Singh's task to supply water to the Shyamali colony where the DAV Jawahar Vidya Mandir School is located. It was here that Narendra, and Mahendra, whom everyone called 'Mahi', studied and where Jayanti now teaches (her husband Gautam Gupta too studied in the same school).

Paan's early connection with cricket was to ensure adequate water supply to the first proper turf wicket in Ranchi at the Mecon Stadium for the November 1984 Ranji Trophy match between Bihar and Orissa.

It was a time of water rationing and the turf would have withered away without the precious moisture. Things were made even more difficult as a curfew had been imposed due to the assassination of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi just days earlier.

Call it karma, or what you will, but it was at this stadium a few years later that his youngest child would first make a name for himself, raining sixes all over the ground—early steps on the steep ladder to international fame and fortune.

Mahi was a natural at sports, excelling at hockey, table tennis, badminton and as a football goal-keeper. After he had reached the top of the cricket world he was asked what he would have become if not a cricketer and he candidly replied he would probably have become a famous footballer, playing for one of the top Kolkata club sides.

It was while studying in Class VII that football's loss became cricket's gain. It was only due to the regular wicket-keeper being unavailable that Mahi was asked by sports instructor Keshab Ranjan Banerjee to try his hand at wicket-keeping.

The logic was that a football goal-keeper would find it easier to adapt to wicket-keeping.

It was his powerful batting that surprised everyone. He was neat, too, behind the stumps, though not a natural, and it took a year of hard training

before he got the hang of it. During this tough grind he did not play a single competitive match.

It was 1994 when he donned the 'keeper's gloves for the first time. And a decade later he would assume the same role for the nation.

Three years after that switch he became the school sensation, smashing a stunning unbeaten 213 from 150 balls with 26 boundaries and six sixes. He and opening partner Shabbir Hussain (117 not out from 116 balls) batted the whole day for 378 runs to lift the inter-school trophy.

Asked years later about his aggressive style, Dhoni explained: 'I used to hit balls right from the start. I loved the feeling. There was nothing else on my mind. When I started with tennis ball cricket, there was no leaving the ball and stuff like that. It was just scoring from each and every ball. (*Sportstar*, 3 December 2005).

Ranchi's clubs began to take notice and Dhoni turned out for Commando Cricket Club from 1995 to 1998.

Among his benefactors in his teenage days was Paramjit Singh, owner of a small sports shop, who persuaded a cricket equipment manufacturer in Ludhiana to supply bats and other gear free to the promising schoolboy.

Today Singh's *Prime Sports* sells, on an average, 80 bats a month, thanks to the small-town hero's success, another example of good karma in the amazing M.S. Dhoni story.

In 1998 Dhoni joined the Central Coalfields Limited (CCL) team where he got a monthly stipend of Rs 2,200. It was with this money that the eighteen-year-old bought a second-hand motorbike—the first of many, newer, grander ones to come.

Club cricket in Ranchi those days consisted mainly of 15-overs games and his number seven slot meant he had few opportunities to display his batting prowess. At CCL he gained a promotion in the batting line-up and began to flower.

Destiny lay before him but for the moment, like millions of schoolboys around the country, his studies took up a lot of his time, though cricket remained an integral part of those youthful days.

School at 7.30 a.m., back home at 1.30 p.m. for lunch, then off to 'nets', followed by studies from 6.30 to 9 p.m., as well as for one hour early in the morning.

Though so much of his time was spent out on the cricket field, his parents were proud that their youngest child was a bright student, invariably securing a first division. In his Class X board exams he scored a creditable 66 per cent.

Strong family genes and a youthful appetite for rice mixed with milk (and a love of chicken too) helped build up his strength as a youngster. They gave him the energy to play endless games of cricket.

That his childhood hero was Sachin Tendulkar comes as no surprise. During the 1992 World Cup in Australia, he would get up early to watch Tendulkar bat—and then go back to sleep when he was out. Tendulkar's memorable 'desert storm' display in Sharjah in 1998 was another abiding memory.

Of course, just a handful of schoolboys grow up to play alongside their youthful heroes, let alone captain them.

Dhoni's father was a strict disciplinarian and Mahi admits to being scared of him as a boy. His mother was more of a friend, protecting him and praying for his success. It was his mother more than his father who encouraged him to play cricket. (His father and brother had been keen footballers in their younger days.)

In 1999, Mahi passed out of Class XII, though it was a tough time shuttling between matches for CCL and sitting for his board exams.

After that he applied to Gossner College, a minority-affiliated institution under Ranchi University, as a B. Com (honours in accountancy) Part-I student for the 1999-2002 batch. He captained the college cricket team during his short stint there but never had the time to sit for his exams.

By then his first-class career was taking off. Studies would have to take a backseat.



CHAPTER TWO

First-Class Cricket

MAHI'S FIRST FULL-TIME job was in 2001, as a ticket-collector on the South-Eastern Railway's Kharagpur (West Bengal) division. It was in the grade nine category, the kind of job a lower-middle-class family in India would strive for, providing as it does the comfort of job security.

For the first time he had to move out of his beloved Ranchi and live in Kharagpur (two hours' drive from Kolkata) which boasts of having the world's longest railway platform.

Tennis ball cricket tournaments were all the rage in Kharagpur and Dhoni was hugely popular at these events, attracting up to 20,000 spectators to watch his exciting batting.

Many of the unique shots he plays he ascribes now to batting against the tennis ball on 18-yard pitches where yorkers were common. Particularly the one he has made most famous—digging the yorker out of the ground and whipping it to or over the mid-wicket boundary.

It is a shot requiring immense strength of the shoulders and forearms, and he claims he can pull it off—where others have suffered injuries while attempting it—due to the robustness he inherited from his ancestors.

It was around this time that he was called for trials for the Railways Ranji Trophy team at their home ground, the Karnail Singh Stadium in

New Delhi. It was the only time he briefly flirted with the idea of leaving his Bihar mates. But the trials turned out badly.

He kept for just three balls, batted briefly and was promptly rejected. He claims it did not bother him at the time. But when he was selected for the Duleep Trophy in early 2004, the Railways came calling again. This time it was his chance to turn them down.

‘I said, “No, no, I’m not coming,”’ he recalls. ‘Perhaps I was rude or whatever, but it had a big impact on me. The incident really pushed me to do better. I was neglected in a big way at that trial. I got more determined to be at a level where you are performing consistently and you are recognised by everyone’. (*Cricinfo*, 24 March 2008).

The rejection also forged in him a determination, once he became captain of India, that a class player must be given an extended run in the side even if he has struck a bad patch.

In that sense, perhaps, the Railways selectors unwittingly did a big favour to Indian cricket.

Life was tough in Kharagpur, away from his family, and in the tiny flat he shared with colleagues. By late 2004 he quit the Railways, and in May 2005 joined Indian Airlines as a manager.

By then, of course, he had made his ODI debut and had the luxury of turning down an offer from Jharkhand Chief Minister Arjun Munda of the post of deputy superintendent of police. He also declined a job offered by Tata Steel in Jamshedpur.

It took five hard seasons on the domestic circuit before he got his break in the Indian team. But all through those years he never wavered in his loyalty, sticking by the Bihar (later Jharkhand) state team, unfashionable though it was.

Dhoni claims he was happy playing Ranji Trophy, never feeling disappointed when he missed out in selections. His ability to stay positive came from the firm conviction that merit and performance would lead to higher things.

‘I believed in performance. I never picked up the newspapers to see if I was picked for the Duleep Trophy or Deodhar Trophy matches for East Zone. For me, it was more about playing cricket, enjoying cricket. I knew if I’m good enough I’ll get a chance and for that I have to be consistent. In my mind I was very clear that if they don’t give me a chance for Duleep or Deodhar Trophy, it doesn’t really matter—I’m happy playing for my state.

If I can play consistently well for my state, that's good enough for me because I love playing cricket more than anything else.' (*Cricinfo*, 28 March 2008).

Dhoni was among the first generation of small-town players from non-traditional cricket centres to rise to international heights.

Mohammed Kaif, Parthiv Patel and Yuvraj Singh had set the trend a few years before Dhoni, and now it has become well established, with the likes of Irfan Pathan, R.P. Singh, Joginder Sharma and Praveen Kumar rising from obscurity and sometimes impoverished backgrounds to reach the Indian team.

The days of dominance of players from the traditional metros, while not quite over, have certainly been eclipsed by the country boy cricketer and his burning hunger to succeed.

Jharkhand was carved out of Bihar as a separate state in November 2000, with Ranchi as its capital. But it was not till the 2004-05 season that its team competed in the Ranji Trophy under the Jharkhand banner, absorbing players from Bihar (which no longer competes as a separate state team). Till then, players from Jharkhand continued to represent Bihar.

Dhoni never led his state side, despite being offered the captaincy during his breakthrough 2004-05 season, preferring to stay and concentrate on honing his batting and wicket-keeping.

He had a taste of captaincy only very briefly in school and college. Even more remarkable, then, that he has taken to leading the national team like a duck to water.

The 1998-99 season was spent playing for Bihar in the Cooch Behar Under-19 tournament (three-day matches) and though he did not make any waves, Dhoni did enough with the bat (185 runs from eight innings, three not out with one 50) and gloves to retain his place in the next season.

Bihar made it to the final in 1999-00 and Dhoni also represented East Zone in the C.K. Nayudu Under-19 zonal one-day tournament that season.

Dhoni's form with the bat picked up in the second season of the Cooch Behar tournament and he had three half-centuries and three scores of 40-plus on the way to the final. But the Bihar boys were in for a rude shock when they faced Punjab in the four-day final at the Keenan Stadium in Jamshedpur in September 1999.

Winning the toss and electing to bat, Bihar would have been pleased with their total of 357. Dhoni was second top scorer with a typically robust 84 (12 fours and two sixes).

Then the Punjab batsmen took over, taking up nearly two and a half days in compiling a massive 839 for five wickets in 222 overs.

It was a severe test of Dhoni's stamina. It was also his first sight of the prodigious talent of Punjab captain Yuvraj Singh, who smashed an amazing 358, adding 207 for the second wicket with Ravneet Singh Ricky and 341 for the third with Vivek Mahajan.

The Bihar bowlers were clueless and Dhoni had to be satisfied with a lone stumping. But it was a lesson worth learning for the youngsters.

Though the C.K. Nayudu tournament was a flop for both East Zone (losing all four games) and their wicket-keeper (97 runs in four innings), Dhoni's first-class debut followed immediately after.

It came for Bihar against Assam in the Ranji Trophy at the Keenan Stadium on 12 January 2000. Bihar captain Sunil Kumar had kept wickets earlier in the season and was one of the side's leading batsmen as well. But it was felt the triple role was a burden, and so Dhoni was selected to wear the big gloves with Kumar playing as a specialist batsman.

The day before the same teams had met in the Ranji Trophy one-day tournament, Bihar winning by eight wickets. Dhoni took one catch but was not required to bat.

The first-class debut played over four days was something special though. He managed just one victim (Assam opener Parag Kumar Das stumped off Avinash Kumar in the second innings) but made an immediate impression with the bat.

Coming in at number seven in both innings, Dhoni struck a rapid 40 from 62 balls in Bihar's first innings of 258. Assam replied with 247 and when quick runs were needed in the second innings, Dhoni stayed unbeaten on 68 (striking eight boundaries in both knocks) from 89 balls as Assam were set a target of 355. They collapsed for 163 on the final day, handing Bihar a win by 191 runs.

At the end of the match, veteran left-arm spinner Avinash Kumar—ironically playing his last first-class game—told the young debutant: 'You have the talent to play for India.' It was a comment that struck Mahi then, and has stayed with him ever since.

Randhir Singh, the medium pacer who had played two ODIs in the '80s, was one of the state selectors who spotted him and was coach of the Bihar Ranji Trophy team at the time.

Looking back at those early struggles in a recent interview, Dhoni appeared bewildered by his own rise from anonymity to international fame.

‘To even to get into the Ranji Trophy side was a big thing,’ he reminisced. (*Cricinfo*, 28 March 2008). ‘Fortunately we had a selector (Randhir Singh) who believed in youngsters. We (Bihar) qualified for the Cooch Behar Under-19 that year and made it to the final, so there was a big change and all of a sudden we saw five youngsters getting into the Bihar Ranji squad. That was a start. Bihar was considered a small state and for you to be a part of the (East) zonal team, especially to get into the XI, it is tough. You had to perform consistently for that.’

With Bihar qualifying for the Ranji Trophy Super League as the second team in East Zone behind Orissa, Dhoni gained the experience of playing against leading sides from around the country.

Bihar’s campaign in the Super League was a disappointing one, failing to win a single of their four matches and Dhoni managing just 175 runs in eight innings.

It was a harsh welcome to the tough grind of Indian first-class cricket but an experience which would stand him in good stead over the next few seasons.

He finished the season with 283 runs from 10 innings (five matches) with one not out and one half-century at an average of 31.44. He also claimed 12 catches and three stumpings. It was hardly an outstanding performance but the promise was obvious.

A quick learner, Dhoni absorbed the lessons of his first season and by 2000-01 he was beginning to look more polished both in front of and behind the stumps.

In the Ranji Trophy one-day match against Tripura that season, he recorded his highest score in senior cricket to date, 84 runs from 73 balls with 10 fours and four sixes, the sort of rollicking batting that would earn him fame and fortune in the years to come.

The match was held at the tiny Calcutta Cricket and Football Club ground in the south of the city, and the short boundaries were easily cleared by his strong blows.

He had been promoted to opener in the tournament and finished with scores of 4, 84, 43 and 1 in the four East Zone league matches.

That season he also represented East Zone for the first time in the Deodhar Trophy one-day tournament, playing a match against South Zone in Kanpur.

Then came the big breakthrough on the national level and that, too, on the big stage of the imposing Eden Gardens in Kolkata.

It was in January 2001 that Bihar faced Bengal in their final league match of the season. Dhoni had behind him a string of low scores in the four-day Ranji games and may have been feeling the heat to retain his place in the playing XI.

Batting first, Bengal amassed a huge 608 for five declared with centuries by Nikhil Haldipur, Alokendu Lahiri and Rohan Gavaskar.

Bihar's aim was to avoid the follow-on. They failed to do so but they discovered a new star in M.S. Dhoni. He reached his maiden first-class century, 114 not out, on 5 January to take Bihar to 323 in their first innings. Following on, Bihar reached 302 for three to earn a creditable draw.

Dhoni's was a fighting knock. He batted for over four hours and faced 206 balls and though the innings contained its liberal share of boundaries (17 fours and one six), it was the way the 19-year-old shielded the tail-enders that impressed onlookers.

In fact there were three distinct phases to his century. Coming in with the total reading 228 at the fall of the fifth wicket, he started with a flurry of boundaries. But as wickets began to fall around him, he dropped anchor.

Once he realised he might run out of partners and miss out on his maiden ton, he let loose again. He found an able partner in number 11 Dhiraj Kumar who contributed just nine runs in a last wicket stand worth 55.

Dhoni reached three figures in flamboyant style, smashing left-arm spinner Shibsagar Singh for a soaring six over long-off.

Sadly, the day was marred by a shocking display of petulance from another teenager, all-rounder Laxmi Ratan Shukla, who had played three ODIs a couple of years earlier.

Shukla's first over with the second new ball went for 16 runs, Dhoni cracking three boundaries. Shukla responded with a beamer and a mouthful of abuse. Dhoni complained to the umpires after the over but

things only got worse. Shukla was eventually sent packing from the field by his captain and did not take the field the next day.

Nothing, though, could ruffle Dhoni's feathers. While one teenage prodigy was beginning to disintegrate beneath the public gaze, another was just beginning to make his mark.

The drawn match ended a miserable season for Bihar, which finished fourth in the East Zone league and failed to qualify for the next stage. Dhoni's figures for the season read four matches, six innings, one not out, 195 runs, highest score 114 not out, average 39.00. He also claimed six catches and one stumping.

With no more matches for Bihar, some of the momentum was lost for Dhoni, and this may have been one cause for the drastic drop in form the next season. In fact, 2001-02 was an unmitigated disaster for both Dhoni and his team.

Having made the breakthrough with his maiden century in the previous season, he was expected to carry on from where he had left off. Instead, he went through the season with just one half-century (96 against Orissa) in four Ranji four-day games and four Ranji one-day matches as Bihar finished a dismal fourth in their zone in both tournaments.

It was a tough time all round. Usually down at number six, Dhoni was often called upon to save the follow-on, a difficult task for someone who loved to play his strokes. All that combined to leave him, after three seasons of first-class cricket, with a sense of disappointment. Dhoni now found himself bombarded with advice to soften his aggressive style of batting and also switch to a higher-profile state team. But he stuck to his guns, determined not to tamper with the methods that had got him this far on the first-class scene. And he also refused to ditch his team.

It was a wise decision, one that paid rich dividends the very next season in which he reeled off eight half centuries.

The Plate and Elite group system was introduced for the first time in the Ranji Trophy in 2002-03 and Bihar had another poor season, finishing bottom of group B in the Plate section, losing all four of their completed matches.

They did better in the Ranji one-day tournament with two wins, a tie and a loss, and Dhoni had scores of 10, 74, 88 and 74 as Bihar finished second to Bengal in the East Zone rankings.

After missing out on the Deodhar Trophy the previous season, Dhoni was back for East Zone and added another two 50s in three games.

Cumulatively, it was his best season by far. In the four-day and one-day matches—in which he was now regularly opening—his combined figures for the season read 682 runs from 15 innings (one not out) for the healthy average of 48.71.

The crisis of the previous season had been overcome by the only method Dhoni knew—bold, attacking cricket. The die had been cast.

The momentum was maintained and by the end of 2003-04 he was beginning to catch the eye of the national selectors. Everything was finally falling into place.

The innings that shot him to national prominence was in the Deodhar Trophy match against Central Zone on 27 January 2004, a virtual final before his adoring fans at Jamshedpur.

East Zone needed to win the match to claim the title in the round-robin tournament and they did so in fine style, crushing their opponents by 142 runs. It was the first time East Zone had won the Deodhar Trophy since 1996-97 and Dhoni was a star in his own backyard.

Opening with Nikhil Haldipur, he smashed 114 runs from 124 balls with 12 fours and three sixes, as East ran up a formidable 324 for four wickets from their 50 overs. It was a no-contest after that. This was his second century of the season, following 128 against Assam in the Ranji one-day game.

Raju Mukherjee and Prakash Poddar, two former Bengal cricketers, were the talent research development officers appointed by the board for the Deodhar Trophy. They passed on information about Dhoni to Dilip Vengsarkar, chairman of the Talent Research Development Wing at the National Cricket Academy.

Mukherjee told me they had mentioned Dhoni's name as a 'match-winning hard hitter' in their reports. 'I also mentioned that his wicket-keeping did not impress me. Dilip took the initiative to nurture and develop Dhoni's raw talent. I, of course, cannot take any credit for Dhoni's success.'

Incidentally, he was not keeping wickets in the Deodhar Trophy, that role being handled by Bengal's Deep Dasgupta who had played Test matches by then. Dhoni's batting prowess thus saw him play the role as a specialist opener in one-day games.

A month later, he was selected for the East Zone team for the Duleep Trophy, making his debut in the elite zonal tournament against the visiting England 'A' side, the first foreign team to be invited to play in the tournament. Once again, he opened the batting with Dasgupta holding down the 'keeper's slot.

The match in Amritsar was the second for East in their group, and they had to win to reach the final. Dhoni had missed the first match against South Zone but now he made people sit up and take notice with another forceful batting display.

There were four current or future international players in the England squad, including Kevin Pietersen and opening bowler Sajid Mahmood, both touring for the first time.

This was my first sighting of the player whose name had been increasingly appearing in the media.

I introduced myself to Dhoni and we chatted for a few minutes, between innings, on the boundary edge. I recall his face lighting up when I told him that I had spent a year in his beloved Ranchi back in 1973. We briefly exchanged yarns about Ranchi and our respective schools. Though the meeting was brief, I found him friendly, polite and articulate.

It was the first time Dhoni was playing against an international side, but that hardly fazed him as he clouted 12 boundaries in his first innings of 52.

It was certainly an eye-catching performance and there was a buzz round the ground as he added 93 for the opening wicket with Shiv Sundar Das. In the second knock he struck four boundaries in another quick 24 as East won by 93 runs to reach the final against North Zone in Mohali.

Dasgupta was dropped for the final and Dhoni opened the batting, also keeping wickets. Set a stiff target of 409 to win in the fourth innings, Ashish Nehra and the other North bowlers must have wondered what hit them as Dhoni raced to 60 from 47 balls with eight fours and a six. But the momentum could not be maintained and East lost by 59 runs. Dhoni also picked up five catches behind the stumps to complete what had been another outstanding season.

It now appeared only a matter of time before he graduated to India colours.



CHAPTER THREE

Playing for India

THE PERIOD FROM 2000 to 2005 saw a bizarre game of musical chairs when it came to selecting a wicket-keeper for the national side.

By the time Dhoni made his ODI debut in December 2004, he was the 12th wicket-keeper to play Tests or ODIs in five years, starting with the 1999-00 tour of Australia in which MSK Prasad kept wickets in the Test series and Sameer Dighe in the ODI tri-series.

After Nayan Mongia was injured in the 1999 World Cup in England, it was Rahul Dravid who was forced to take on the gloves, a role he retained right through the 2003 World Cup and into part of 2004 as well.

In 2000 Syed Saba Karim also briefly held the position before suffering a serious eye injury in Dhaka. In between Mongia was back briefly in 2001, followed the same year by Deep Dasgupta.

Vijay Dahiya had a short stint in both Tests and ODIs while Ajay Ratra was impressive in the West Indies in 2002. The same year, Ratra too suffered an injury on the tour of England, and the young Parthiv Patel took over.

Patel held his place till a series of blunders made in Australia in 2003-04, and then in the home series against the same side a few months later, saw him make way for Dinesh Karthik.

Dasgupta, very much in the Patel mould in that he was more a batsman than a wicket-keeper, commented around this time that the only way for a 'keeper in domestic cricket to catch the eye of the national selectors was through his batting.

It was Karthik's selection for the ODI side playing in England in September 2004 that gave Dhoni a lucky break. The Tamil Nadu stumper/batsman was the first choice for the India 'A' tour of Zimbabwe and Kenya, while Dhoni went as the reserve keeper.

But when Karthik was called away to England after playing in the first four matches of the Zimbabwe tour, Dhoni stepped into the breach.

In fact, they both played in the second game against Zimbabwe Select XI in Harare, a four-day encounter starting on 29 July 2004 but finishing in three days as India 'A' won by 10 wickets. The quality of the opposition in Zimbabwe was obviously sub-standard.

Karthik played as a specialist batsman while Dhoni donned the 'keeper's gloves. It was the first time he wore India colours (even though this was not a full international match) and he made an immediate impact.

In fact, he equalled the record for an Indian wicket-keeper (shared with two others) with 11 victims in the match, seven catches and four stumpings and also smacked a rapid 45 from 48 balls. The world record stands at 13 victims in a match.

Karthik may already have been looking over his shoulder.

Karthik was back again behind the wickets for the next match, a one-dayer in which Dhoni opened the batting and was out for 1. In the fourth and final match of the tour, Karthik kept again, while Dhoni was omitted.

But that would be Karthik's last match for India 'A' on the twin tour as he was called away to England for higher honours. Dhoni resumed the 'keeper's duties on the Kenya leg that followed Zimbabwe.

The focus was now even more on wicket-keepers who could bat rather than the other way round, with Dravid increasingly reluctant to carry the double burden in ODIs. That opened the door for the likes of Karthik and Dhoni.

The one-day tri-nation tournament in Kenya involving India 'A', the hosts and Pakistan 'A' was the final stepping stone for Dhoni on his way to full national recognition.

India, under the captaincy of Sairaj Bahatule, began on a bad note when they lost the opening tie to Kenya by 20 runs, Dhoni, as opener,

contributing only eight.

But they came back strongly the very next day as they beat Pakistan by four wickets with Dhoni top-scoring with 70. It earned him his first international Man of the Match award.

Playing their third match in three days, India crushed Kenya in the return tie by 10 wickets, with Dhoni not required to bat. He played his part behind the stumps, though, with four catches and a stumping.

India's winning streak was extended against Pakistan in the return match on 16 August 2004, which marked Dhoni's first international century.

He smashed 120 from 122 balls (10 fours and two sixes) and with opener Gautam Gambhir also striking a century, the two put on 208 runs for the second wicket from just 192 balls.

India's huge total of 330 for 6 from 50 overs proved too much for Pakistan who collapsed to 209 all out.

With each side playing each other three times in the preliminary league, India beat Kenya the next day by six wickets, Dhoni contributing 30 runs.

This ensured India's place in the final, but just to rub it in, they routed Pakistan again in their third and final league match by eight wickets.

It was another century for Dhoni and another Man of the Match award. He was now the talk of the Gymkhana Club ground in Nairobi with local Indians flocking to watch his big-hitting exploits. This time his 119 not out contained nine fours and five sixes, overshadowing Pakistan captain Misbah-ul-Haq's 106.

Fate would bring the two together again, just three years later, in the World Twenty20 final in Johannesburg.

The Indians were on a roll now and the final against Pakistan was a cake-walk, winning by six wickets though Dhoni could only contribute 15.

India ended the tour with a drawn three-day game against Kenya, dominated by Dheeraj Jadhav's 260 not out. Dhoni also made his presence felt with 78.

He was the find of the tour, with 362 runs (average 72.40) in the one-day tri-series and word had reached back home that here was an exceptional talent worth encouraging. Besides, he had been pretty safe—and occasionally spectacular—behind the stumps as well.

Dhoni himself was sure he would soon get a chance to fulfil his dream of playing for India. He said as much in an interview to *Sportstar* (29 April 2006): 'It [the Nairobi tournament] was a big breakthrough for me. I was projected as a batsman who could hit hard and also keep wickets. I managed to play my natural game against Kenya and Pakistan. The tournament provided me the platform to raise my hopes for a place in the Indian team. After that tournament, I was sure I would get an opportunity.'

In the same interview he was asked what he learnt from that tournament:

'A lot. It was my first opportunity to play against foreign teams. Pakistan was a very competitive side, with some capped and some fringe players. It was good exposure for me. It helped boost my morale and confidence. I learnt about cricket outside India. The ball moved a lot, there was swing and bounce. It was a great experience. There was this pressure, too, of scoring. I wondered what would happen if I failed. It was one great opportunity and I am glad I grabbed it.'

All the chopping and changing must have seemed rather perplexing to Karthik. He replaced Dravid as wicket-keeper for the third and final match of the NatWest Bank Challenge ODI series against England and the opening match of the 2004 Champions Trophy in England, only for Dravid to take over the task once again for the rest of the tournament.

Karthik made his Test debut in the fourth and final Test against Australia in Mumbai in November 2004, after Patel's atrocious technique over the past one year could not be tolerated any longer by the selectors.

The selectors had a good look at Dhoni at home when he represented Board President's XI in Jaipur against the touring South Africans who followed the Australian's visit. He did his chances no harm by keeping neatly and scoring 39 in the only innings in which he batted.

But while Karthik kept competently in his debut Test, the two home Tests against South Africa that followed, and the two Tests in Bangladesh, he found himself replaced in the December 2004 ODI series in Bangladesh by Dhoni. This may have been due to Karthik's lack of form with the bat rather than the gloves. But it gave Dhoni his big break.

After romping home by an innings within four days in both the Tests in Bangladesh, the ODI series provided an unexpected challenge for the Indians.

Dhoni's ODI debut came at the M.A. Aziz Stadium in Chittagong on 23 December 2004.

India decided to experiment and go in with a number of changes from the Test team for the ODI series, perhaps not quite taking their opponents seriously enough. The idea was to test the team's bench strength. In the light of Bangladesh's past record, this was understandable.

India won the opening match by 11 runs, a small margin in the end, although they were never seriously threatened.

Medium pacer Joginder Sharma was the other debutant but, like Dhoni, he made little impact.

India's 245 for 8 was built round 50s by Mohammad Kaif, the Man of the Match, and Rahul Dravid. India were wobbling at 45 for three before the two repaired the early damage with a stand worth 128 runs.

Dhoni, coming in at the fall of S. Sriram's wicket at 180 for 5 in the 42nd over, in his anxiety to get off the mark was run out for a duck after facing just one ball.

Despite half-centuries by captain Habibul Bashar and wicket-keeper Khaled Mashud, India were never seriously threatened at any stage, in the words of captain Sourav Ganguly, as Bangladesh mustered 234 for eight.

Dhoni must have been disappointed not to have taken a catch, nor a stumping, on his ODI debut, but at least he did not concede a bye.

India made more changes for the second match at Dhaka on Boxing Day, resting Rahul Dravid, Harbhajan Singh, Irfan Pathan and Sachin Tendulkar.

It may have been a fatal mistake. Even as news was filtering in of the devastating tsunami that had struck South-East Asia, the Indians found themselves slipping to their first defeat at the hands of international cricket's favourite whipping boys.

Batting first, the home side reached a respectable though not threatening 229 for 9 with Aftab Ahmed top-scoring with 67.

Despite another good innings from Kaif (49) and Sriram's 57, there was no recovery this time around, after the quick fall of the first three wickets.

Dhoni claimed his first ODI catch when he accounted for opener Nafees Iqbal off Ajit Agarkar's bowling.

With the bat he started off confidently, striking two boundaries and adding 25 runs with Kaif for the sixth wicket before he fell for 12, caught

by Bashir at mid-wicket off medium pacer Mashrafe Motaza at 157 for 6.

The Bangladeshis were tigerish in the field and this was the difference between the two teams as they recorded their first ODI win (in their 100th match) on home soil by 15 runs on a day of immense tragedy.

It was India's 16th ODI defeat of 2004, a massive slump in form after the high of reaching the World Cup final the year before.

There was no further talk of experimentation or testing of bench strength for the decider the next day. India were back with their strongest side. Stung by the Dhaka defeat, they came roaring back to win the third and final game by 91 runs to make it 2-1 in the series.

Dhoni faced just two balls in India's huge total of 348 for five, to remain unbeaten on seven. This, incidentally, included his first six in international cricket, a huge hit over long on. It was a sign of things to come.

With three catches and two stumpings, he did well behind the stumps and earned the approval of his captain. Ganguly made it clear that he would like to persist with Dhoni in ODIs.

With Pakistan touring in March 2005, the Challenger one-day series was seen as a test between Dhoni, Karthik and Patel. Dhoni certainly came out the winner even though his side, India Seniors, lost to India 'A' in the final in Mumbai.

Dhoni raced to 102 not out from 96 balls as they beat India B by eight wickets in a preliminary game. With Ganguly captaining the Seniors, his views on Dhoni, established a couple of months earlier in Bangladesh, were now cemented.

Karthik would, however, keep his slot in the Test team against the Pakistanis.

In between, there were domestic commitments for East Zone, and Jharkhand, who were making their debut in the Ranji Trophy.

Dhoni made an impact in the Deodhar Trophy with 101 against West Zone and 87 against Central, even though East finished at the bottom of the points table.

Jharkhand, playing in the Ranji Trophy Plate championship, effectively the second division, performed creditably, finishing joint second with Orissa in Group 'A', and losing in the semifinals to Haryana. In the Ranji one-day tournament they finished third in the East Zone league.

The 2004-05 season turned out to be the best till date for Dhoni as he scored 97 against Kerala, 128 against Orissa and 109 in a losing cause in the semifinals to finish with 397 runs (average 79.40) from four matches in which he also took 21 catches.

Ironically, the Plate semifinal against Haryana at Chandigarh in March 2005 would be Dhoni's last first-class match for Jharkhand till date. The packed international calendar would leave him with little time for the domestic circuit.



CHAPTER FOUR

Hitting the Headlines

THE PAKISTAN TOUR of India in early 2005 was to be coach John Wright's final assignment with the Indian team.

Having won a Test and ODI series for the first time on Pakistan soil the year before, hopes were high that Wright, the popular New Zealander would go out on a winning note.

The tourists, captained by Inzamam-ul-Haq, were dismissed as the weakest Pakistan side to ever visit India. It would prove to be a fatal underestimation.

After allowing the visitors to wriggle out of a tight spot in the first Test at Mohali, the Indians then won the second at Kolkata by 195 runs, with Rahul Dravid scoring a century in both innings.

Dinesh Karthik's batting had been a let-down since his debut, but in Kolkata, he made sure of keeping his place in the Test side by scoring 93 in the second innings.

Having started as overwhelming favourites, it was a big disappointment when Pakistan won the third and final Test at Bangalore to square the series. Worse was to follow for India in the ODI series.

India looked set to take a stranglehold on the six-match series by romping home in the first ODI at Kochi and the second at Visakhapatnam. Dhoni exploded on to international consciousness and made world cricket

headlines with a sensational 148 in the second match played in the Andhra port city.

He had come into the Indian team with the reputation of a big hitter, but had failed to make an impact in his previous four ODIs, since making his debut three months earlier in Bangladesh. All that would change dramatically on 5 April 2005.

Out for just three at Kochi, Dhoni then became the first Indian wicket-keeper after Dravid—and the first regular 'keeper—to score an ODI century. It was also the highest ODI score for an Indian against Pakistan. And it came in grand style.

Behind the breakthrough innings was Ganguly, promoting Dhoni to number three in the batting order when he had been slotted at number seven in his previous four games.

It was a surprise move and gamble and it certainly paid off. The reason, though, was more likely to have been to protect the captain himself, as he had been going through a horrid run with the bat, rather than any tactical genius.

The wicket was a typical Indian featherbed, ideal for batting and the home side made sure to cash in.

When Sachin Tendulkar was out with the total reading 26, the crowd was surprised to see the unfamiliar burly figure of Dhoni rush to the wicket in his characteristic hurried manner. He met the first ball with a slapped straight drive to the boundary. That set the tone.

What followed was batting mayhem as Dhoni and Virender Sehwag put the Pakistani bowling to the sword.

The opener smashed 74 runs from just 40 balls and even Dhoni was put in the shade during their stand worth 96 from 62 deliveries.

In stark contrast, Ganguly scratched around after Sehwag's dismissal and the innings began to lose some momentum, till the arrival of Rahul Dravid at 140 for three in the 20th over.

It was fascinating to watch the old guard and the new face of Indian cricket take on the bowling in contrasting style. Dravid scored at almost a run a ball but had only three boundaries in his 52.

Dhoni on the other hand was in murderous form and it was brute strength and hitting that had the crowd enthralled. His long hair, with red tints peeping out from under the helmet and glinting under the sun, gave a

macho, rock-star-like aura to his batting. This innings was the first giant step in his elevation to cult hero status and favourite of the masses.

One report of the match was headlined: 'A Man Possessed', and indeed, Dhoni appeared unstoppable on the day.

Dravid and Dhoni raced to 149 runs from 134 balls to power India to 356 for nine, their highest total against Pakistan and third highest of all time.

His first 50 took 49 balls, the second 39 and there was no sign of nerves as he approached his maiden international century.

By the time he was out at 289 for four in 41.2 overs—lofting off-spinner Mohammed Hafeez into the hands of Shoaib Malik at mid-wicket—the wicket-keeper had slammed 148 runs from 123 balls with 12 fours and four sixes.

Showing tremendous stamina in the energy-sapping humidity of Vizag, Dhoni then put up a neat display of wicket-keeping for the 44.1 overs of Pakistan's innings, not conceding a bye as they were dismissed for 298. There could only be one candidate for the Man of the Match award.

Dhoni admitted the conditions were ideal, with a small ground and flat track just waiting to be exploited. It was the heat and humidity which he said were the toughest parts.

Chandrabhas Choudhury summed up the exultant mood well in *Cricinfo*: 'It felt as if something had changed violently within the well-settled and familiar order that is the Indian batting lineup, as if an explosion had gone off that would ring in the ears for very long.'

That it certainly would. But the immediate task was to wrap up the ODI series.

Unfortunately for the Indians, the wheels rapidly came off their campaign after that as Pakistan stormed to victory in the next four games in a row.

It was a shattering blow, especially since captain Ganguly received a ban—not for the first time—for the team's slow overrate after the fourth match at Ahmedabad, and had to sit out the last two at Kanpur and Delhi with Dravid taking charge in his absence.

The third match was played at Jamshedpur, practically Dhoni's backyard. But he requested his family to stay away from the stadium. He

has done that ever since as he feels added pressure when they are watching from the stands.

It did not help much. The Keenan Stadium crowd had eyes only for their hero. But after cracking 28 from 24 balls to the cries of 'Dhoni, Dhoni', he tried one adventurous shot too many and the crowd was hushed.

Pakistan won by a crushing 106 runs and then levelled the series with a tense last-ball win in the next match at Ahmedabad. Dhoni's contribution here was a more sedate 47, adding 129 runs for the second wicket with his childhood hero Tendulkar's, whose 123 went in vain.

The team's spirit was broken by now and they went down tamely by five wickets at Kanpur and 159 runs at New Delhi.

It was a sad end to coach Wright's stint. Over the last five years he had done much, in conjunction with Ganguly, to build up a new steely resolve in the side. India's record away from home in this period was outstanding, second only to world champs Australia.

The players had a couple of months to lick their wounds before they were off to Sri Lanka for the Indian Oil tri-series also involving the West Indies.

Dhoni decided he needed match practice instead of rest and took advantage of the break to participate in a club tournament, the P. Sen Trophy, in Kolkata.

It was an unusual move for an international cricketer in India and his presence attracted what was probably a record crowd of 2,000 for the tournament final at the Eden Gardens. Smiling 394 runs from 227 deliveries in the tournament was probably as good a way as any to prepare for an ODI tournament.

Indian cricket is never short of drama and the interregnum was filled with plenty of off-field action.

Former Australian captain and batting legend Greg Chappell won the race to take over as coach of the Indian team on 20 May 2005, and formally took charge at Bangalore a month later.

Though Sunil Gavaskar, S. Venkataraghavan and Ravi Shastri were on the selection panel, it was Ganguly who strongly supported Chappell's candidature against Mohinder Amarnath, Desmond Haynes and Tom Moody, the others in the fray.

Ganguly had credited Chappell with helping him deal with the short stuff just before the tour to Australia in 2003-04, and the result was a

brilliant century in the first Test at Brisbane. But the irony in his support to Chappell would come back to haunt Ganguly and Indian cricket in the months ahead.

Ganguly's ban of six matches, following the Pakistan series, had been reduced to four on appeal and as a result he was back for the third match of the tri-series, though Dravid continued to lead the side in this tournament.

So the new season began for Indian cricket with a new coach and some new faces in the team, but in the old familiar surroundings of Sri Lanka, where they had been frequent visitors over the previous decade.

With Tendulkar nursing a shoulder injury, the Indian batting was minus its two stalwarts for the opening two matches at Dambulla against the hosts and the West Indies.

Dhoni was promoted to open the batting with Sehwag in the first match. But the tri-series proved to be a big setback both with the bat and the gauntlets for Indian cricket's latest hero.

'Flexibility' was to be the mantra with Chappell in charge, and the players got a taste of it in his first assignment. Sehwag found himself with three different opening partners in the first three matches while Dhoni was shunted down to number six for the second match.

In the third, he was up two slots, then back to number six for the fourth match and the final too, where India were beaten by Sri Lanka by 18 runs.

Not that it made much difference where Dhoni batted. He finished with scores of 2, 15 (not out), 20, 28 (not out) and 7. But what was of bigger concern was his keeping, which was dismal.

He dropped Sanath Jayasuriya off Irfan Pathan when he was on 19 in the final, and that probably cost India the trophy as the opener went on to score 67.

After being left out for the first three games, Anil Kumble was back for the last league match against West Indies and the final, and this added to Dhoni's woes.

It was the first time he was keeping to the leg-spinner and, not surprisingly, he found it a struggle. Kumble's pace and bounce has always been a challenge to wicket-keepers and Dhoni was candid enough to admit this:

‘Playing at the domestic level, you cannot prepare yourself for bowlers like Anil Kumble and Harbhajan Singh. The amount of bounce they generate, the pace they bowl at, no domestic bowler can match. The more you practise with them, the more you improve.’ (*Cricinfo* magazine, May 2006).

He also spoke of how one aspect of the game influenced the other. ‘At the international level it’s all about confidence. If you start getting runs, you start doing well in other aspects, like fielding and bowling.’

With Patel and Karthik hot on his heels, Dhoni knew the heat was on.

Fortunately for him, his form picked up when India moved to Zimbabwe for another tri-series, with New Zealand as the third side.

It was here, exactly a year earlier, that Dhoni had made his first tour and got a taste of international cricket while appearing for India ‘A’.

Considering the pathetic standard of cricket in Zimbabwe, an India/New Zealand final was a given. But India did experience a scare in their second league match against the home side, till Yuvraj Singh and Dhoni came to the rescue.

A miserable performance in the opening match against the Kiwis at Bulawayo was followed by a crushing win against Zimbabwe, with Dhoni cracking 56 from 46 balls. India then got the better of New Zealand in the return game thanks to 102 not out from Mohammad Kaif, and Dhoni helping to seal the win by six wickets with a rapid 37 not out from 27 deliveries.

But they were in deep trouble at Harare when they faced Zimbabwe for the second time, slipping to 36 for four (and 91 for five) after the bowlers had conceded 250 runs.

It was then that Yuvraj and Dhoni pulled the fat out of the fire and saved the side several occasions to blush.

Yuvraj was Man of the Match for his 120 while Dhoni’s 67 not out was again at better than a run a ball. It contained only one four this time but he hit three sixes as well.

But the final was another anti-climax for Indian fans, just like the final in Colombo the month before.

A total of 276 all out (Dhoni 11) after the second wicket had fallen at 155, was just not good enough and the Kiwis raced home by six wickets with nearly two overs to spare.

The Indian side's habit of losing in the finals thus continued unabated. Since 2000 they had reached 16 finals, winning just one with three no-results.

Karthik kept his place in the two Test series against Zimbabwe that followed, though he was skating on thin ice now, scoring just 1 in both the innings in which he batted. India expectedly won both Tests without raising a sweat.

Dhoni was perhaps thanking his lucky stars that he was back home after the tri-series and had thus avoided one of the most unpleasant and public spats in the history of Indian cricket.

With his batting form dipping disastrously, Ganguly had asked for Chappell's advice on the eve of the first Test at Bulawayo. The coach bluntly told him it would be best for him to step down from the team till he sorted out his form.

A shocked Ganguly reportedly threatened to pack his bags and leave, till he was persuaded to stay on. His subsequent painstaking century in the first Test then saw him spilling the beans about the confidential conversation to a TV channel at the end of the match, letting the bad blood between the two come out in the public domain.

Publicly, they patched up before the second Test at Harare. But the tensions were simmering just under the surface.

Shortly after the team's return, a 'private and confidential e-mail' (Chappell's words) to the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) president, in which the coach was scathing in his opinion of Ganguly, was leaked to the media and all hell broke loose.

The BCCI promptly constituted a review committee which met separately with the two protagonists and a shaky compromise was worked out.

With Ganguly nursing an elbow injury, the selectors on 13 October 2005 handed the captaincy of the ODI team to Dravid for the seven-match series against Sri Lanka, as well as the ODI series against South Africa that immediately followed. Dravid was later also appointed to lead in the Test series against Sri Lanka in December, thus ending Ganguly's eventful reign that had begun in 2000.



CHAPTER FIVE

World Record and Test Debut

THE CHALLENGER TRI-SERIES one-day tournament at Mohali was used as a trial and warm-up for the ODI series at home against Sri Lanka, who were visiting India for a full tour after eight years.

Dhoni, playing for India Seniors, found himself on the winning side as the team beat India 'B' in the final, though his batting did not click in any of the three matches. He did, however, pull off the unusual feat in the final of stumping the last three India 'B' batsmen, all from the bowling of left-arm spinner Murali Kartik.

Sri Lanka, ranked second in the world, were favourites for the ODI series starting in October 2005 as India's world ranking had slipped to an abysmal seventh. Furthermore, Sri Lanka had beaten India in five of their last six encounters.

But the home side were strengthened by the return of a newly energised Sachin Tendulkar. The tennis elbow he'd developed had kept him out of international cricket for six months, but the way he batted during the opening tie in Nagpur, it was as if he had not missed a day.

His dazzling 93 was well supported by Irfan Pathan's 83 in the pinch hitter's role assigned to him by the coach, and new captain Dravid's lightning-quick 85 not out.

Dhoni pummelled 38 from 33 balls before being brilliantly caught in the deep, and India's total of 350 for six was well beyond the Lankans who lost by 152 runs.

The second match, at Mohali, was even more one-sided. Put into bat, the visitors crashed to 122 all out and India coasted home by eight wickets with loads of overs in hand. Tendulkar was unstoppable once again but it was Irfan Pathan who took the Man of the Match award for his four wickets.

India thus went into the third game at Jaipur on 31 October with their confidence high. But at the back of their minds was the recent memory of losing the series 2-4 to Pakistan, after leading 2-0.

They could not avoid another such slip-up and, on the eve of the match, Dravid warned his team against complacency. There was some talk of resting Tendulkar but in the end he made the decision to play.

Indeed, the Indian bowlers appeared to have gone off the boil and Sri Lanka's total of 298 for four was by far their best of the series thus far and a challenging one for the Indians to chase down. It was powered by a brilliant innings of 138 not out by Sri Lankan opener and wicket-keeper Kumar Sangakkara, supported by Mahela Jayawardene's 71.

The target was stiff and a good start was vital. Tendulkar's dismissal in the first over of the innings was met with a hush around the ground.

That silence would not last for long. There is not much opposition bowlers can do when Sehwag and Dhoni are in the mood for mayhem, and this was another such occasion. In the first match of the series, Pathan had been promoted to number three and in the second, it was Jai P. Yadav—all part of Chappell's insistence on flexibility.

But with the target a tough one this time, it was decided to send up Dhoni to the same number three slot from which he had hit his previous ODI century six months earlier, against Pakistan at Jaipur.

There were other similarities, too, with that game. Tendulkar was out for two on both occasions and once again Dhoni was involved in a stand in the 90s with Sehwag.

Again, as at Jaipur, it was Dravid who joined Dhoni in another useful stand after Sehwag's (39) departure.

Chaminda Vaas had given the Lankans hope when he got rid of Tendulkar. But their celebrations did not last long. Twice, the left-arm pacer was smashed over extra-cover for six by Dhoni. There was nothing

wrong with the deliveries and Vaas could scarcely believe his eyes as the ball rocketed past him.

Master off-spinner Muthiah Muralitharan was confidently handled as well. Captain Marvan Atapattu decided to hold back the first Powerplay and bring on Murali in the 11th over in a bid to stem the flow of runs. Dhoni astutely used the gaps in the field to run singles and wait for the Powerplay to launch into his attack again.

The stand with Sehwag was worth 92 when the opener fell lbw to Murali. At 99 for two, the target was still a distant one.

The second Powerplay was applied from the 17th to the 21st over, soon after Dravid joined Dhoni. Dhoni now took charge and clouted 32 out of the 46 runs the Indians grabbed in those five overs.

Though Murali was the best of the bowlers, with two for 46 from his 10 overs, Upul Chandana's leg spin was taken apart as Dhoni twice swung him over square-leg for six.

Dhoni raced to three figures from only 85 balls, with 10 fours and five sixes. But the earlier effort of keeping wickets for 50 overs, and the heat and humidity, took their toll and he began to suffer cramps soon after reaching the landmark. The last 53 runs came with the help of a runner.

That did not slow Dhoni down. In fact, the third 50 of his innings was the quickest from 38 deliveries.

Dravid went for 28 at 185 for three and then it was Yuvraj's turn to watch from the other end as Dhoni continued to gallop to a world record for a wicket-keeper in ODIs.

The Lankan bowlers appeared helpless and put all their energy in to removing batsmen at the other end. Yuvraj went for 18 and though Venugopal Rao was jittery, with the victory target approaching, Dhoni was there till the end to guide India home after 46.1 overs.

There were four consecutive half-century partnerships after the fall of the first wicket, in which Dhoni dominated till the end, finishing on a monumental 183 not out from 145 balls with 15 boundaries and 10 sixes.

The match ended in fitting style with Dhoni dancing down the track and clouting Tillakaratne Dilshan for six over mid-wicket from the first ball of the 46th over.

His 120 runs from boundaries alone was a world record at the time (beaten a year later by Herschelle Gibbs) and the other records Dhoni set with his dazzling display seemed never-ending.

The most precious to Dhoni, undoubtedly, was the highest ODI score by a wicket-keeper since the previous mark of 173 not out was scored by his idol Adam Gilchrist the year before.

Other records included: the highest ODI score by a non-Test playing batsman; highest score by a wicket-keeper against Sri Lanka (Gilchrist being the previous record-holder here as well, with 155 not out); highest ODI score by a number three batsman; equalling the highest ODI score by any batsman against Sri Lanka (183 by Ganguly in the 1999 World Cup). Also, his total of 10 sixes in an innings was second only to Sanath Jayasuriya and Shahid Afridi (both with 11).

At the end of the match Dravid compared the innings to Sachin Tendulkar's 143 against Australia at Sharjah in 1998, arguably the greatest one-day century by an Indian.

'I have been privileged to see some great one-day innings by Sachin, Veeru (Sehwag) and Sourav,' said Dravid. 'But possibly, in a chase, this is pretty close to the 100 Sachin made against Australia in Sharjah. I watched that game on television because I wasn't part of the team, and this has to be one of the best knocks in a game that I have been part of.'

The way Dhoni was hitting the ball towards the end of the run chase, there was every chance he would go on to become the first to score a double-100 in ODIs. But that was never on his mind. 'The main thing was that I wanted to be there till the end,' he told the media. 'I wanted to be able to score the winning runs. It was when I reached 160 that I thought of Gilchrist's record. We were a little wary of Muralitharan. He is the best bowler in their squad, and Rahul and I decided to take singles against him, see him off and attack the other bowlers.'

In an interview to *The Sportstar* (3 December, 2005), Dhoni claimed he was just playing 'normal cricket'. The surprised journalist asked: 'Is a whirlwind unbeaten 183 "normal cricket" for you?'

His answer was confident, without being arrogant: 'Yes, that's my normal cricket. I just had to choose the right ball to hit. I went after the bowlers but knew which ball to hit and which to leave. That was my best innings, better than the 148 against Pakistan.'

He admitted that when the first ball of the match was bowled, he realised it was it was 'among the best tracks you can get. Even after the first innings was over, it looked a good placid batting track.'

‘Technically, it must be my power, the bat speed I generate, and the swing of the bat,’ he said when asked what was behind his ability to hit so many sixes. ‘These are the things that help me hit big sixes. I practise a lot for those sixes because I gain confidence. If you clear the field once, then most of the other times you are through. When you are confident, you can go for the sixes.’

India sealed the series by winning the fourth match at Pune by four wickets. It was a tense and close affair and Dhoni’s 45 not out was crucial in the end.

The Lankans were all out for 261 and India’s reply came in fits and starts.

The first hiccup came with Tendulkar and Yuvraj falling cheaply to make it 34 for two before Sehwag (48) and Dravid (63) pulled things back. Venugopal Rao contributed 38 and when he fell at 176 for 4 after 31 overs, India were still on course to reach their target.

But Rao’s wicket was followed immediately after by that of Dravid and Pathan and India found themselves in a tight spot at 180 for 6.

This was when Suresh Raina (39), playing his fifth ODI, and Dhoni (45) provided the decisive twist in a magnificent unbeaten stand worth 82 that took the team home with 4.2 overs to spare.

Dhoni’s unbeaten knock was in contrast to his blazing one at Jaipur. Initially cautious, he opened up only as the target came closer and finished with his usual strike rate of better than a run-a-ball.

The finish was spectacular. Sixteen runs were required when Russell Arnold came in to bowl the 46th over. Dhoni was on 29 from 39 balls.

It was all over four balls later. The first two, Dhoni ran a pair of twos.

The next two disappeared over the long on boundary and India were home in style.

Dhoni finished with 45 not out from 44 balls.

The Lankans pulled one back by winning the next match at Ahmedabad by five wickets despite centuries from Gautam Gambhir and Dravid. It was the only match of the series in which Dhoni failed as he was out for a first ball duck.

He was not required to bat at Rajkot as India coasted home by seven wickets, and then, in the seventh and final match at Vadodara, he was again at the forefront with a power-packed 80 from 73 balls inclusive of nine boundaries and three sixes.

Once again, though, the big hits came only in the latter half of his innings. He came in at 157 for four and, as at Pune, he started off with nudged singles, even caressing rather than bludgeoning the boundaries. It was a sign of his cricket acumen and growing maturity. India reached the winning target of 245 with a whopping 63 deliveries and five wickets to spare to make it 6-1 in the series, the most decisive ODI result the team had ever recorded.

The series was a personal triumph for Dravid who was leading the country on a full-time basis for the first time. He finished on top with an amazing average of 156.00.

It was Dhoni who was top scorer on either side with a total of 346 runs, second in the averages with 115.33 and a fantastic strike-rate of 119.31.

Now it was time for the South Africans.

While the Lankans proved to be pushovers, South Africa, ranked second in the world after Australia, were a much harder nut to crack. The 2-2 verdict with one washout was probably a fair indication of the two sides' strengths.

It was a disappointing series for Dhoni, however, especially after the highs of the previous one. He finished with scores of 17, 14 and 12.

Sri Lanka were back at the end of 2005 to play three Test matches and Dhoni's claims to a place in the Test side could no longer be ignored.

Karthik had been picked largely for his batting. But just one half-century in 10 Tests saw him make way for Dhoni in the first Test at Chennai in December.

The first three days of the Test were a complete wash-out and very little play was possible on the fourth and fifth. Most of the focus was on Ganguly's comeback to the team on the back of consistent batting on the domestic circuit.

The fifth day's play was only academic, but it did allow the visitors to score some brownie points as they first skittled out India for 167—their lowest total against Lanka—and then finished the match on 168 for four.

While Sehwag hit a typically brisk 36, Dravid pushed and prodded around for nearly two-and-a-half hours for his 32 and it was left to the debutant wicket-keeper to save the side from total disaster. Even Tendulkar was reduced to a crawl as Chaminda Vaas bowled an amazing 11 maiden overs on the trot.

Dhoni showed a lack of nerve in countering Murali on a sluggish track and used his feet to clear the field. In a matter of 54 deliveries he hit more boundaries than Dravid and Tendulkar managed in 231, and cleverly rotated the strike.

It was only a matter of 30 runs. But observers were left impressed with Dhoni's technique and temperament. To round off a satisfying debut, he claimed his first catch when he pounced opener Avishka Gunawardene in Pathan's first over of the innings.

He went one better in the next Test in New Delhi, recording his maiden half-century in the second innings—at a-run-a-ball for good measure—as India went one up in the series with a decisive win by 188 runs.

The opening day was dominated by Tendulkar who reached 100 at stumps to record his record-breaking 35th Test century, thus overtaking Sunil Gavaskar's world record.

The record had stood for 22 years and the final step to it was an agonizing one for Tendulkar and his countless fans.

With Murali at his best, India lost their last seven wickets for 45 runs on the second morning, Dhoni bowled by the master off-spinner's *doosra* for 5. Few batsmen would have had an answer to the delivery, pitching on leg stump and whizzing past the defensive prod to rattle the off stump. One reporter referred to it as a contender for ball of the year.

The total of 290 was a disappointing one, but the Indian bowlers were soon in the thick of things and with Anil Kumble picking up six wickets, the Indians managed a first innings lead of 60 runs.

With Sehwag unwell and missing the Test, Dravid opened in the first innings with Gambhir. In the second it was Pathan's turn to be promoted, and his batting set the innings off to a glorious start with an impressive 93.

India finished the third day on 237 for five, and quick runs were the order of the day on the fourth morning once Ganguly was out for 39.

With an ODI-like situation developing, Yuvraj and Dhoni were the ideal pair for the situation. Dravid was looking to set a target of 400-plus and wanted enough time on the fourth evening for his bowlers to pick up a few Lankan wickets.

That is just what transpired as the young pair raced to 105 runs in 119 deliveries for the unbroken seventh wicket, the declaration coming at 375 for 6. Yuvraj 77 not out, Dhoni unbeaten on 51.

Murali may have foxed him in the first innings, but it was Dhoni who took control this time around as he danced down the track and lofted him over mid-on for four.

Leg spinner Malinga Bandara was hit twice for six as Dhoni stepped on the accelerator after lunch to give Dravid plenty of breathing space.

By tea Sri Lanka had lost only one wicket but then Kumble struck and at stumps they had their backs to the wall at 123 for five, chasing a highly improbable 436.

It was all over the next day with Kumble finishing with 10 wickets in the match.

But instead of enjoying the fruits of their victory, the team was thrust into fresh turmoil when it was announced that Ganguly had been dropped for the third and final Test at Ahmedabad despite scoring 40 and 39 in New Delhi.

Sehwag was back for the third Test and Wasim Jaffer was recalled. Yuvraj cemented his place with his second innings knock and it was felt there would be no place for Ganguly in the playing XI.

That explanation did not prevent a storm of protest erupting in Kolkata with captain Dravid, coach Chappell and chief of selectors Kiran More the target of the fans' fury.

Ironically, Dravid fell ill on the eve of the Test and Sehwag led the side for the first time.

It made no difference to the outclassed tourists who caved in by 259 runs to give India a 2-0 verdict in the series.

The start, though, was anything but encouraging to the Indians. It was a topsy-turvy opening day's play with the first five Indian wickets crashing with just 97 on the board.

That they finished the day at 247 for six was largely due to the efforts of V.V.S. Laxman, Dhoni and Pathan.

The Indian batting certainly had a formidable look to it, with Dhoni coming in at number 7, to be followed by Pathan. And it was the wicket-keeper who gave Laxman just the support he needed.

Dhoni's positive attitude pushed the bowlers back for the first time in the innings. He was aggressive without taking risks and the tempo of his batting was illustrated by the way he overtook Laxman who had been on 23 when Dhoni arrived at the crease.

By the time he had reached 49, Laxman was on 50. But Dhoni was denied his second successive Test 50 when he was trapped in front by Murali.

The next day, Laxman went onto his century while Pathan scored 82, as India totalled 398 and then gained a first innings lead of 192 runs.

A second innings declaration at 316 for nine meant India had plenty of time to bowl out the opposition and seal the Test and the series.

The result meant India had now climbed to second spot in the International Cricket Council (ICC) Test rankings behind Australia, the first time they had reached that high since the rankings were introduced in 2001.

It was a good way to prepare for the tour of Pakistan that was to follow shortly. And Dhoni had certainly done enough with the bat and gloves to book his ticket.

Another who made the flight across the border was Ganguly and his inclusion would present a fresh dilemma to the captain of the first Test at Lahore.

The team management was under pressure from top BCCI officials to include the former captain in the playing XI. That created a shake-up in the batting, with specialist openers Jaffer and Gambhir sidelined. Dravid had little choice but to open as he did in the first innings of the Delhi Test against Lanka. It proved to be a masterstroke, at least this time around.

The flatness of the pitch at the Gaddafi Stadium in Lahore and the weather combined to consign the Test match to a dreary draw. But not before Dravid and Sehwag came within a boundary hit of one of the oldest world records in the books.

There were four centuries in Pakistan's huge 679 for seven declared, with Younis Khan becoming the first batsman in Test cricket to be run out on 199. Shahid Afridi, Mohammad Yousuf, at the start of a record-breaking year, and Kamran Akmal, also weighed in with tons.

The Indian response was a massive opening partnership of 410 runs, Sehwag scoring 254 and Dravid 128 not out. And that's where the Test ended.

The world opening partnership record of 413 had been set 50 years earlier by compatriots Pankaj Roy and Vinoo Mankad. Two years later it would be beaten by South Africa's Neil McKenzie and Graeme Smith.

The run rate of both sides at 4.93 per over set a world record for the highest scoring-rate in a Test match.

There would be no respite for the bowlers in the next Test at Faisalabad either.

This time India's bowlers were hammered to the tune of 588 as captain Inzamam-ul-Haq and Afridi made merry.

Dravid (103) and Laxman (90) held the top order together before five wickets fell in a heap for just 45 runs. At 281 for five, the Indians still needed more than 100 to avoid the follow-on. It was a nervy time for Dhoni to walk to the crease.

Ganguly was made to sit out as the team management had decided to go in with five specialist bowlers. One more wicket and the tail would have been exposed.

Akhtar was in the midst of a spell of terrifying speed with the second new ball, extracting steep bounce from the flat pitch. In

Dhoni's own words, 'I was definitely under a bit of pressure.'

He estimated the first six balls bowled to him were between 146 and 152 kph.

The second ball took a thick edge and ran away for four, more due to the bowler's pace than the batsman's skill.

'Ducking under the short ball was not easy because the bounce wasn't on the high side. It was a really tough first over,' according to the batsman. (*Cricinfo* magazine, March 2006).

He watched the next over from the non-striker's end and, back on strike against the fiery fast bowler, Dhoni considered his options.

'I could either hang in there and defend, or back myself and play my strokes. I was better at playing my strokes than defending. So it was a simple choice,' he told the magazine.

The first ball of that over was a screamer, heading straight for his temple. But in his mind the decision had already been made— on such choices are careers made or broken.

The ball was slapped over square-leg for six. There was a touch of Viv Richards-style arrogance to it. It made his intentions clear. This was one batsman who would not waste his time ducking and weaving.

'I wasn't even thinking of the consequences of getting out,' he said of that shot that rang out across the ground. 'It was just about the best way

to get runs and save the follow-on. I knew it would be only a three- or four-over spell.'

It was stirring stuff. Akhtar roared in, striving for more and more pace and losing out on accuracy. Dhoni grew in confidence and smacked a few more daring shots till the bowler conceded defeat and walked off, head bowed.

Afridi and Danish Kaneria tried to unsettle Dhoni and Pathan with a dose of verbal abuse. It had little effect on the young pair who were taking India out of the woods with confident strokes all round the ground.

The leg spinner was clouted outside Iqbal Stadium and there was a delay while the ball was retrieved. The next went soaring to the same spot and Dhoni had raced to his 50 from 34 balls.

He reached his maiden Test century from 93 balls, while Pathan was providing valuable support in a stand that took India to the relative safety of 441 for five by close of the third day; Dhoni batting on 116, Pathan on 49.

At the end of day's press conference Dravid described Dhoni's batting as 'one of the best counter-attacking innings' he had seen for a long time and claimed Dhoni could only get better. 'It was one of the best innings I have seen under pressure,' said Dravid. 'He had to face the new ball and he attacked the bowlers.' He emphasised that it was not a hell-for-leather sort of innings. After the blazing start, Dhoni settled down to ensure he did not lose his wicket before stumps.

'It was a sensible innings,' Dravid elaborated. 'He played his shots initially but later controlled the innings along with Irfan. It was a great innings and I am confident that he will play much better after this. He would have gained a lot of confidence.'

'Character', 'courage' and 'ability' were the words Dravid used in describing Dhoni, and he couldn't have said it better.

There was still some work to be done on the fourth day, and by extending their partnership to 210—a sixth wicket record for India against Pakistan—the overnight pair made things safe. India ended up with a lead of 15 runs.

Pathan fell 10 short of what would have been his maiden century while Dhoni fell two short of 150. In the morning he smacked 33 runs from 29 balls before being stumped off Kaneria while charging down the track. A round 100 of his runs had come from boundaries.

Despite centuries by Younis and Yousuf in the second innings, the match ended in another predictable draw. But it did give Dhoni the chance to bowl his first and so far only over in international cricket. He went for 13 runs.

Back in 1978 Kapil Dev had made his Test debut at this same ground. Over the years he captured the imagination of cricket fans around the world both for his bowling and bold batting. Perhaps the legendary all-rounder saw something of himself in the dashing wicket-keeper/batsman. Kapil sent a message from India that Dhoni had become his 'hero'. Despite all the praise from his captain, for a young man playing in only his fifth Test, it was the 'best message' Dhoni had got till then.

The bowlers on both sides had toiled on dead tracks for 10 days. But at Karachi, in the third Test, they finally got their revenge, especially the Pakistanis.

After matching the home side in every department, India let slip a golden opportunity following Pathan's historic first-over hat-trick which had reduced Pakistan to 39 for 6.

They rallied to 245 thanks to another century by Akmal, and then gained a slender lead of seven runs. The wicket-keeper was let off on 80 when Dhoni muffed a stumping off Kumble.

Aggressive batting in their second innings saw Pakistan declare on 599 for 7 and the Indian batting folded up dramatically on the fourth day to concede defeat by a whopping margin of 341 runs.

It was a disappointing end for Dravid and his men, who had failed to tackle the pace and swing of Mohammad Asif and Abdul Razzaq. But they would gain a measure of revenge in the ODI series that followed.

It was another decisive victory for the Indians. Following soon after the crushing 6-1 scoreline against Sri Lanka, this time it was Pakistan who were beaten 4-1 to send out a signal that the Dravid-Chappell combine was proving to be successful after all, despite the initial teething pains. The series was notable for outstanding performances by Yuvraj, the Man of the Series, and Dhoni, who was not far behind him.

Pakistan took the opener at Peshawar on the Duckworth-Lewis method after the game was curtailed due to bad light, with 18 runs needed from 18 balls and three wickets in hand. This, after India had rattled up 328 all out.

Tendulkar silenced his increasingly vocal critics with his first century in 10 months, and he received excellent support from Pathan (65) and Dhoni (68) who stepped up the scoring rate with a series of crunching cover drives.

And there was no looking back for India after that. At Rawalpindi, Pakistan's 265 was easily overtaken for the loss of just three wickets and with nearly seven overs to spare.

Then Dhoni took the bowling by the scruff of the neck in an audacious display to give his side the lead at Lahore.

At 190 for five in the 35th over (Tendulkar 95) in reply to Pakistan's 288 for eight, it could have gone either way.

Not for the first time, Yuvraj and Dhoni took command and their unbeaten stand worth 102 runs came from a mere 13 overs.

Yuvraj struck 79 not out from 87 balls but even he was forced to take a backseat as Dhoni tore into the bowling. His unbeaten 72 from 46 deliveries earned him the Man of the Match award and led *Wisden Cricketers' Almanack* to describe his batting rather chillingly, as: 'hooligan stuff, casually violent and full of chauvinistic machismo'.

David's opinion was quite to the contrary. 'It's terrific to see someone so new in international cricket handle the pressure so well. His performance over the last six to eight months has been critical to our success,' he observed.

The pressure was indeed crushing, with 99 runs needed from 92 balls when Dhoni marched to the crease. Not as much the power of his shot-making, it was the seemingly impervious air about him that had his teammates and fans spellbound.

To withstand the intensity of a daunting run chase in an India-Pakistan encounter so early in one's career, and deal with it in such an imperturbable way was what took the breath away.

Dhoni himself admitted he felt that this was one of his best innings, putting it above his whirlwind maiden ton at Visakhapatnam. 'My 148 helped my team to win and it was at a crucial time. It was an opportunity to grab for me but the amount of pressure here was much more. This was a much better innings that way.'

It also took him past 1,000 runs in his 33rd ODI, giving him an average of 50.19 with a strike-rate of 107.44.

India were on a roll by now and coasted home by five wickets at Multan to wrap up the series. Dhoni was not required to bat, but his diving effort to dismiss Yousuf off Ajit Agarkar had the experts nodding their heads in appreciation.

The icing on the cake came at Karachi in the fifth and final game, courtesy of another storming stand between the two poster boys of Indian cricket, Yuvraj and Dhoni. Pakistan's 286 for eight was passed with ease for the loss of two wickets as Yuvraj recorded his first century of the series, and Dhoni was not out on 77. Six boundaries and four sixes from 56 balls—it was as if he was toying with the opposition bowling, such was the arrogance with which they were treated.

Yuvraj was the Man of the Series but with scores of 68, 72 not out, 2 not out and 77 not out giving him an average of 219, Dhoni was not far behind.

The coach's comments on his match-winner's influence in the dressing room were fascinating. 'He's quiet and is aware of his presence—one who is silent, yet strong. When he speaks, it's worth listening to. He speaks his mind. There's an honesty about him that's appealing. There's no false modesty there. His self-belief is strong.' (*Cricinfo* magazine)



CHAPTER SIX

Indian Idol; Globe Trotter

IT WAS BARELY 16 months since he first played for the country. But in that short span a combination of his machismo and his brutal batting had elevated M.S. Dhoni to the cult status of a teen idol.

It was no surprise then, that he was voted *MTV's* Youth Icon for 2006. The rock-star image was an instant hit with cricket fans, particularly the younger lot.

Typically, Dhoni gave cricket the credit. 'I think it is a prestigious award,' he commented on *MTV*. 'The youth are the ones who poll and decide who the icon is. Most others contestants were from different fields, and that's where I feel cricket played a role in me winning the award.'

He had first grown his hair long on the India 'A' tour of Zimbabwe and Kenya in July/August 2004. By now it had become a superstition as he felt it gave him, Samson-like, strength and energy.

It hit the international headlines when it emerged that Pakistan President Pervez Musharraf, too, admired his hairstyle.

'A lot of placards in the crowd have suggested that you should get a haircut, but if you take my advice, you look good in this hairstyle,' Musharraf told Dhoni over the public address system during the prize distribution ceremony following the Lahore ODI on 13 February 2006. Dhoni took the public compliment in his stride.

The swagger to the crease, the broad shoulders and the supreme confidence bordering on arrogance all reminded cricket followers of a generation earlier of the one-and-only Vivian Richards, the West Indian legend who struck terror into the hearts of bowlers.

An earlier generation waxed nostalgic, recalling the exploits of Budhi Kunderan and Farokh Engineer, Indian wicket-keepers of the '60s who had attained minor cult status thanks to their flamboyant batting.

Dhoni thus successfully managed to bridge the generation gap and his appeal to all ages helped him bag a pile of product endorsements in record time.

To complete the macho image was his much publicised obsession with motorbikes and all their associations with speed, power and raw masculinity.

India's advertising world could not have asked for more, and beat a path to his door to sign him up for products ranging from hair cream to shoe polish and, of course, bikes.

A particularly evocative commercial for Cherry Blossom shoe polish had him smartly turned out in his Railways uniform talking about how fate could so easily have consigned him to his early profession.

The inevitable links to the world of Hindi movies—an advertisement that featured him with screen legend Shah Rukh Khan, and being briefly linked with starlet Deepika Padukone—would come later, after the triumph in the inaugural World Twenty20. But there was no doubt he had firmly established himself as a superstar in the imagination of the Indian people.

His then manager, Jeet Banerjee of *Gameplan Sports*, explained his appeal in *The Sportstar* (14 October 2006): 'It's been a combination of factors. First, his performances on the field endeared him to the advertisers. He has single-handedly won games for India. Then there is the fact that he is from a small town; he gives people a reason to dream. His unconventional appeal—he had long hair even before he played for India—plays a part.'

Banerjee pointed to the diverse range of companies that wanted Dhoni to lend his image to their products as proof that his appeal cuts across demographics and socio-economics. 'It does sound flattering, but *GE Money* told us their only two celebrities worldwide are Roger Federer and Dhoni,' said Banerjee.

The grunge look was in, what with the success of actor John Abraham and his motorbike-movie *Dhoom*, and Dhoni fitted right in. The timing of his rise was perfect. India was struck by a wave of ‘Dhoni-mania’.

Back in 2006 he had four bikes in his collection, a 650-cc Yamaha Thunderbird, an RD 350, a Bullet Machismo and a CBZ. That number has now grown and includes a custom-made one-of-a-kind prototype worth lakhs of rupees, which was gifted to him by the brand he currently endorses. Plus at least two SUVs.

The highways around Ranchi are ideal for biking, and Dhoni has let it be known that he roars down these roads at speeds of up to 180 kph, his unique way of relaxing during the rare moments he gets to go home and unwind.

It was as a youngster watching bikes on the streets of Ranchi that Dhoni got hooked on fast wheels. ‘I love the feeling of riding a bike. I think it gives you some kind of energy,’ he has said.

Exide batteries, Cherry Blossom shoe polish, GE Money, TVS bikes, Pepsi, Reebok, Bharat Petroleum and Videocon Electronics were the early brands he signed on with. Now, they number close to twenty-five.

Apart from bikes, his other hobby is playing computer games on his PlayStation. ‘Off the field, it is one of the things I do most of the time,’ he has disclosed. ‘But I like to play only if I get a stretch of two to three hours. I don’t like to leave the game in the middle, go for a training session and then come back. I am basically into first person-shooting games like *Counter Strike*, *Black Hawk Down*, *Men of Valor*.’

Back home in Ranchi it is his dogs, black labrador Zara, and pug Sam, that he loves to spend time with. Asked what kind of girl he would eventually like to marry, he stated categorically that she should be an animal-lover.

Ranchi is a town that is close to his heart and, despite his riches and superstar status, Mahi has never expressed a desire to move anywhere else.

It is this devotion that has endeared him to his townfolk (save for the shameful immediate post-World Cup incident I shall come to later). Even when he is not in town, youngsters garland the bikes parked outside his house in an act of reverence to the man who has single-handedly put Ranchi on the map of the cricket world.

As I mentioned in an earlier chapter, Dhoni’s success has made Ranchi go simply cricket-mad. The city’s club leagues now feature eighty-

five teams, more than double the number six years back. There are at least seven cricket coaching camps with between 25 to 100 boys each. As many as 600 turn up for state selection trials, all part of the magical Dhoni effect.

Coaches at the national level have noted how boys from districts tend to be more committed and hardworking, compared to those from big cities. Dhoni whole-heartedly agrees with this assessment.

Earlier treated with contempt, the domination of such players in the national squad has given an air of confidence to their young counterparts.

At the height of Dhoni-mania, Mahi admitted he had lost his privacy. He could not even venture out of his home to the hairdressers without being mobbed by fans and chased by ubiquitous TV cameras.

But he has always stressed that he has not forgotten his roots and would remain close to his childhood friends, and to his coaches, from Ranchi.

‘Mentally and physically, everything is the same [following his success]. Only thing is, I travel more these days. Things like endorsements do not bother me because my agent looks after them. I am the same boy from Ranchi.’ (*The Sportstar*, 3 December 2005.)

There was certainly plenty of travel coming up, both within the country and abroad.

To the UAE, the island nations of the West Indies, Sri Lanka, Malaysia, South Africa. . . all in a span of less than twelve months.

But first it was time to take on England at home.

Ashes hero Andrew Flintoff had taken over the captaincy from Michael Vaughan. The tourists were in a catastrophic state on the eve of the first Test at Nagpur, as they had been hit by injuries and withdrawals.

India were thus in a supremely confident mood and expected to easily wrap up the series. The script did not, however, work out quite as expected.

England gained a small first innings lead at Nagpur and then, after declaring on the fifth morning, suffered a brief scare as India made a late attempt at chasing down an improbable target. Despite the draw, it was England who came away with most of the credit, for bouncing back from their pre-Test problems.

India eked out a small lead in the second Test at Mohali. England’s batting then collapsed for 181 in their second innings and India coasted

home by nine wickets.

Dravid and his men probably expected a cakewalk in Mumbai, but they would be in for a rude shock.

Once again, it was England who took the lead but this time it was a substantial one, worth 121 runs.

Dhoni had done nothing of note in the first two Tests. But in the first innings at Mumbai, he showed a new facet to his batting.

Half the Indian side had been sent back, for 142, when he joined Pathan. The two put down their heads, for once, and tried to restore some respectability to the batting.

Dhoni emerged top scorer with 64. Only Dravid also contributed a half-century in the woeful innings. In fact the last five batsmen almost doubled the total to help it reach 279.

The English bowling was tight and Dhoni depended more on nudges than on his usual expansive drives. He was also hit on the head by Flintoff when on 14, but carried on after being inspected on the field by the physio.

He had just begun to open up with three successive boundaries off Flintoff when he was controversially given run out by the third umpire. Replays were inconclusive about whether the bail had been completely removed from the groove in time.

With England out for 191 in the second innings, the target for the Indians was 312—difficult, but attainable. But on the final day, the Indian batting capitulated in shocking fashion to be all out for 100. It was a sensational finish for England, once again inspired by Flintoff.

Though all the batsmen were to blame, Dhoni (5) came in for particularly stinging criticism for his careless shots. Having defended grimly for more than three hours in the first innings, he seemed intent on self-destruction the second time around. He first slogged off spinner Shaun Udal high towards the inept Monty Panesar at mid-off, who made a complete hash of the chance. Back on strike three balls later, Dhoni repeated the shot and this time Panesar pounced it.

That about summed up the scatterbrained Indian batting as seven wickets crashed for 25 runs in 15.2 overs after lunch on the final day.

The 1-1 result was a massive boost to the Englishmen, but their bubble would be burst in the ODI series that followed.

The margin this time for the home side was 5-1 (one washout). Another decisive score-line to follow on the 6-1 margin against Sri Lanka

and 4-1 against Pakistan (as well as 2-2 vs South Africa). A record of 17 wins against five defeats was an outstanding achievement and the Dravid-Chappell combine was beginning to spell magic for Indian cricket. It was anyone's guess how long the winning streak would last, though.

Dhoni had few batting opportunities, such was India's domination. But he did have his moment in the sun in the sixth match in Jamshedpur.

India had by then sealed the series and though England pulled back a consolation win, the crowds had eyes only for their favourite boy.

Dhoni opened with Sehwag and his array of shots was dazzling, even at times bizarre. The bat was alternatively wielded in the manner of an axe and a tennis racket. And as has always been the case when he is on the rampage, the bowlers were made to look puny.

He fell four short of what would have been his third ODI century. He was rested for the seventh and final match in favour of Karthik, the first match he had missed since his debut in December 2004.

A milestone was passed when India sealed the series by winning the fourth match at Kochi. It meant they had won fifteen consecutive matches while chasing, overtaking the record of the formidable West Indies side in the '80s. And seven of those fifteen were in pursuit of totals over 250. The tag of 'chokers' was beginning to fade.

Kochi was India's eighth win in a row. And Yuvraj and Dhoni had been outstanding. In the victorious six months which stretched from the series against Sri Lanka starting in October 2005 to the win over England in April 2006, dashers Yuvraj and Dhoni both averaged over 100, remarkable figures indeed.

From a low of seventh in the rankings at the beginning of the series against the Lankans, the win over the English had now catapulted the team to third spot in the ICC ODI world rankings.

A rather pointless two-match series against Pakistan was staged in the intense heat of Abu Dhabi in April that ended deadlocked 1-1. The Indians were exhausted but they managed to claw their way back after losing the first match by six wickets. They claimed the second by 51 runs with Dhoni scoring 59.

That innings briefly catapulted him to the number one position in the ICC ODI rankings released on 20 April 2006. Dhoni displaced Ricky Ponting from his top spot by one point, even if only for a week. He became the first Indian batsman to achieve this honour.

Since his debut in December 2004, Dhoni had played 42 matches averaging over 52 with a strike rate of 103. It was certainly a meteoric rise to the top.

It was straight off to the Caribbean for the Indians, after the brief UAE stopover, and it was there that the wheels began to fall off India's record ODI run.

The series began on expected lines, with the Indians wrapping up their 17th consecutive run chase, winning by five wickets with a ball to spare, at Kingston.

It was downhill all the way after that. The Windies got their foot in the door in the second ODI, thanks to a Dwayne Bravo slower ball. That bowled Yuvraj on 93 off the fourth ball of the final over with India one run short of victory.

There was a second consecutive last-over defeat for the Indians as West Indies went 2-1 up by winning the third game at St Kitts. That took the wind out of India's sails and Brian Lara and his men enjoyed a rare moment of joy as they easily won the next two matches at Port-of-Spain.

The euphoria of the previous six months rapidly evaporated in the heat and haze of the Caribbean. Suddenly, questions were being asked, and the Dravid-Chappell duo that had been the toast of the nation, was feeling the heat. The experimentation process that had worked like a charm was now under intense scrutiny, arising from the stunning 1-4 reverse. After all, the West Indies were ranked a lowly 8th—above only Bangladesh and Zimbabwe—while India came into the series at number three.

It was a miserable time for Dhoni as well, with a top score of 46 not out in five innings, and he too was now under pressure in the Test series that followed.

Under the circumstances it was a creditable effort by the captain and the coach when they rallied the troops and recorded a series victory in the West Indies for the first time since 1971. In fact, the 1-0 end-result flattered the home side. India were clearly the superior side right through and with a little bit of luck could have made it 3-0.

Fortune had smiled only momentarily on Lara's side in the first and second Test matches.

Despite conceding a lead of 130 runs, India were strongly placed to win the opening Test at St John's. But West Indies' last wicket pair held out for the last 19 balls to hang on for a draw.

It was their second innings total of 521 for 6 declared that put India in a position of strength going into the final day. Opener Wasim Jaffer's 212 was the highest score of the series but it was Dhoni's 69 from 52 balls that accelerated the run scoring.

He was involved in a contentious situation with Lara on the fourth day, and that was the talking point of the match before the final-day dramatics.

Dhoni was at his clobbering best and had smashed spinner Dave Mohammed for three successive sixes. Going for the fourth he was caught by Darren Ganga right on the midwicket boundary edge. Third umpire Billy Doctrove was consulted to judge if the fielder had touched the boards while taking the catch. But the replays were inconclusive and it was left to the on-field umpires to take the call. After a show of petulance by Lara, Dhoni decided to walk off, and Dravid declared the innings.

Lara had wagged an accusatory finger at the umpires and even snatched the ball from them. An ironical tirade had followed, about the 'spirit of the game'. Dhoni had little choice but to succumb to pressure from one of the game's seniormost players who was in his final Test series.

With the fourth day completely washed out, West Indies were once again let off the hook in the second Test at St Lucia. Following on, they had lost seven wickets in their second innings to salvage a draw.

It was all to play for in the fourth and final Test at Kingston after the third also ended in a draw.

The bowlers came into their own here with only Dravid offering staunch resistance in both innings, and India ran out winners by 49 runs in three days.

It was their first significant rubber won outside the subcontinent since England in 1986. Pride was thus restored in the Indian camp after the ignominy of the ODI reverse.

The three ODI matches scheduled in Sri Lanka were washed out. But there would be no stopping the decline in ODIs with India failing to make the final of the DLF tri-series against Australia and the West Indies in Kuala Lumpur and then raining on their own parade in the Champions Trophy.

The tournament was being staged in India for the first time, but nothing went right for the hosts.

They did manage to win their opening match against England, by four wickets, at Jaipur. But defeat at the hands of West Indies at Ahmedabad—despite some bold strikes by Dhoni (51)—meant they were in a must-win situation against Australia in their final group match at Mohali.

But they were never in the picture and thus failed to make it to the semifinals. Australia beat the West Indies in the final at Mumbai.

By the time India were whitewashed 4-0 in South Africa at the end of 2006, a year that had started off with such gusto for the Indian team when they crushed Pakistan 4-1 and England 5-1, had now descended into chaos and recrimination.

Dhoni was one of the few Indian batsmen to come out with some credit. He smashed an entertaining 55 from 48 balls with four sixes in the third match at Cape Town and also totted up scores of 14, 26 and 44.

The dismal spell saw India win just three of their last 15 completed matches from the West Indies tour onwards. India finished 2006 with a record of 13 wins against 15 defeats and two ‘no-results’. The preparations for the 2007 World Cup were rapidly beginning to unravel.

The one consolation came in the one-off Twenty20 International at Johannesburg on 1 December. India (led by Sehwag) won by six wickets with a ball to spare in their first such match. It was a harbinger of things to come.

On three previous tours India had rarely come even close to winning a Test in South Africa. All that would change over four dramatic days in the first Test at the New Wanderers Stadium in Johannesburg.

The revolving-door policy involving Ganguly was on again and he was back in the playing XI. And what a difference it made.

In a low-scoring match his top score of 51 not out in the first innings took India to 249.

That total suddenly looked imposing as South Africa were bamboozled by young quick bowler S. Sreesanth who claimed his maiden five-wicket haul in his sixth Test match.

South Africa subsided from a catastrophic 47 for seven to 84 all out and the Indians could scarcely believe their eyes. It was South Africa’s lowest Test total since their first Test in 1992, following re-admission after the ban placed on them since 1970 for practising apartheid had been lifted.

Laxman calmly steered the ship in the second innings and a target of 402 was always going to be out of South Africa's reach, considering the tricky pitch.

The Indians were ecstatic as they won the Test by 123 runs. The wild celebrations in the dressing room, while understandable, did get out of hand, though, and resulted in severe damage and a hefty bill.

But as had so often happened with Indian sides in the recent past, the high of victory was followed by the low of defeat.

Graeme Smith's men came roaring back to level the series by winning the second Test at Durban by 174. More than 100 overs were lost over five days due to bad light, and barely ten minutes after the final Indian wicket fell, the rains came down.

It was a dismal display in the second innings as the task was to bat on long enough for the weather to ensure a draw. But the Indian batting was all at sea against, arguably, the best fast bowling attack in the world.

Andre Nel, Makhaya Ntini, Morne Morkel (on debut) and Shaun Pollock all bowled with speed, accuracy and hostility.

The target of 354 was never going to be attempted but, even after India lost two wickets late on the fourth day, the rest of the batting was expected to hold out for a draw.

Instead, with six down for 85 the next day, it looked like it would be over in a jiffy. The tail managed to more than double that score. But even with one eye on the clouds, it was too little too late.

Dhoni's brief counter-attacking innings of 47 (he scored 34 in the first) was not enough to hold back the surging tide of Saf's fast bowling machine.

Dhoni was forced to miss the third and final Test at Cape Town, due to a chest infection and bruised fingers, and Karthik was asked to open in Tests for the first time. It was his first Test since September 2005 and he acquitted himself admirably in scoring 63, adding 153 with Jaffer.

A first innings total of 414 should have been enough to make things safe for India. But they put up another display of inept batting in the second innings, and South Africa romped home by five wickets.

Chappell was understandably incensed and made it clear heads would roll.

Karthik, batting at number seven the second time round, was not out on 38, and also took five catches.

But it was now the beginning of World Cup year and the focus would once again shift to ODIs in the countdown to cricket's biggest event.



CHAPTER SEVEN

World Cup Debacle and After

THE FINAL COUNTDOWN had begun for the ninth World Cup in March, to be staged for the first time in the island nations of the Caribbean.

West Indies and then Sri Lanka visited India for ODI series which India comfortably won by margins of 3-1 and 2-1 respectively.

The big talking point was Sourav Ganguly forcing his way back into the ODI squad and with his Man of the Series award against Sri Lanka, making it to the India 15 for the World Cup.

Yuvraj Singh also returned after the injury he sustained in the Champions Trophy a few months earlier.

Against the West Indians, Dhoni was once more among the runs. In the first ODI at Nagpur, he struck 62 not out from 42 balls as India won by 14 runs. An astonishing 119 runs were smashed in the last 11.5 overs in partnership with Dravid.

India won the second match at Cuttack by 20 runs and then Dhoni was rested for the third at Chennai, replaced by Dinesh Karthik, as West Indies won their only game of the series by three wickets.

Dhoni was back for the fourth and final game at Vadodara, which India won by a whopping margin of 160 runs to wrap up the series 3-1. The wicket-keeper's contribution this time was 40 not out from just 20

deliveries. The result was a measure of revenge for the 1-4 reverse suffered by the Indians in the West Indies a year earlier.

Rain prevented a result in the first match against Sri Lanka at Kolkata and the visitors then went one-up by edging India out by five runs in the second at Rajkot. Dhoni chipped in with a steady 48.

India drew level when they won the third match at Margao by five wickets, and though Dhoni was top scorer with 67 not out, it was pace bowler Zaheer Khan who won the Man of the Match award for his five-wicket haul.

At 94 for four chasing Lanka's 230 for eight, the batting was beginning to wobble. Since taking their world record for chasing to 17 in a row last year, the Indians had subsequently lost their nerve when batting second. There was thus much satisfaction in the home camp as Dravid and Dhoni steered India to the target while adding 133 runs for the fifth wicket.

Dhoni was not required to bat at Visakhapatnam as India won the fourth match and series 2-1, romping home by seven wickets. He had played a leading role in the run-chase world record achieved in 2007. But at Rajkot he had just a single boundary in his 48, hit off the 67th delivery he faced. He was out off the very next ball as India fell just short of the target. And at Margao he played second fiddle to his skipper, taking 49 balls to reach 32 before he hit his first boundary with only three more to follow.

So the Indian World Cup campaign had received a timely boost after the slump late in 2006. It was just in time, too, and the team had a familiar look to it as it prepared to leave for the Caribbean.

Nine of the fifteen players had been in the 2003 squad as well, including Dravid who would be participating in his third World Cup, but the first as captain.

Ever since India had stunned themselves—as much as the rest of the cricket world—in 1983 by winning the Prudential World Cup under Kapil Dev, Indian fans' expectations had risen sky-high.

It was four years earlier in South Africa that they had come closest to emulating the 1983 feat when they reached the final, only to be crushed by Australia.

There was massive media hype surrounding the team's chances this time around as had been the case in the run-up to the 2003 World Cup.

Indian fans used to have little interest in the World Cup but 1983 changed all that. Now, with the explosion of TV news channels and with corporates sinking an enormous amount of cash in their World Cup campaigns, it was as if the entire nation had been struck by cricket fever. India were far from favourites, but public expectations fuelled by the media blitz were towering.

Champions Australia were placed in Group A with South Africa, Scotland and the Netherlands, while India were in Group B with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Bermuda.

In Group C were England, Canada, Kenya and New Zealand while Group D had Pakistan, Ireland, the West Indies and Zimbabwe. The top two from each group qualified for the 'Super 8' stage.

So confident were the ICC of India and Pakistan qualifying for the second stage, that they released a schedule of matches for the Super 8 matches with India and Pakistan slotted in as meeting in Bridgetown, Barbados in the marquee match on 15 April.

It was tempting fate. Thousands of Indian and Pakistani fans, mainly from the United States, made bookings in hotels and on luxury cruise liners for the big match—that was never to be.

In two of the biggest upsets in World Cup history, India were shocked by Bangladesh in their opening game and Ireland stunned Pakistan in Kingston, Jamaica on the very same day. Subsequent results saw the two sub-continental giants crashing out at the opening stage and the World Cup was doomed to be a financial failure.

The tragic death of Pakistan coach Bob Woolmer on the night of the defeat at the hands of Ireland also plunged the World Cup into a crisis. From then onwards most of the attention was turned away from cricket and towards the mystery surrounding the Englishman's death.

Few could have foreseen such a catastrophic scenario as India's three group matches were to be played at the Queen's Park Oval at Port-of-Spain in Trinidad. With its large People of Indian Origin (PIO) population this had been like a home away from home for India's cricketers ever since they first toured the West Indies in 1953.

The Indian team fatally underestimated the Bangladeshis for their opening match on 17 March. Reports were coming through of the players excessively enjoying the island's party atmosphere and cockily brushing aside the hopes of their unfancied opponents.

The first surprise of the day was when Dravid chose to bat on winning the toss on a tricky pitch. The Indian innings was one of fits and starts and eventually spluttered to 191 all out in 49.3 overs. Only Ganguly crossed 50 but his innings of 66 took 129 balls.

The only partnership of any substance was between Ganguly and Yuvraj (47) who added 85 runs for the fifth wicket. After that, five wickets fell in a heap with just one run added—including Dhoni out for a duck—and the team had dug themselves into a deep hole.

Medium pacer Mashrafe Murtaza picked up two early wickets and came back to bag two more to finish with four for 38. The trio of Bangla left-arm spinners gave very little away with even Tendulkar struggling to reach seven from 26 balls. It was dismal batting by the Indians and now the onus was on the bowlers to pull things back.

It never happened. Instead, three audacious teenagers, Tamim Iqbal, Mushfiqur Rahim and Shakib Al Hasan, came hard at the Indian bowlers with half-centuries apiece and the target was reached with ease with five wickets and nine deliveries in hand. The Banglas were ecstatic, the Indians stunned. Back home cricket fans were rubbing their eyes in shock and disbelief as the match ended in the early hours of the morning. The knives were already being sharpened.

Poor starts in the World Cup had become something of a sad tradition for the Indians. This was the sixth occasion in nine tournaments that India had lost their opening match. But this time it meant they would need a miracle to book a place in the Super 8 stage, something that had been taken for granted in the weeks running up to the tournament.

India's next match was against no-hopers Bermuda and they had to win by a massive margin to improve their net run-rate—and then beat Sri Lanka convincingly in their last group tie. If they lost that too, the only hope was for Bermuda to beat Bangladesh in the final group fixture—highly unlikely given the forms of the two sides. All this was assuming Lanka would defeat Bangladesh which they duly did with ease.

As expected, the India–Bermuda match was a no-contest. India became the first side to score 400-plus in the World Cup and the margin of victory (257 runs) was the biggest in ODI history. (It was overtaken in July 2008 when New Zealand beat Ireland by 290 runs at Aberdeen.)

Sehwag hit 114, Ganguly scored 89 and Yuvraj 83 in India's massive total of 413 for five in reply to which Bermuda tumbled to 156 all out. But

not much satisfaction could be drawn from the result. Bermuda were not only the weakest side in this World Cup, but one of the weakest of all time to play in ODIs.

The crunch match was always going to be the India–Sri Lanka encounter, the final league match for both sides with Lanka already through to the next stage and India gasping for survival.

March 23 was a fateful day for Dravid and his men and for countless millions of fans of Indian cricket around the world. It was a do-or-die encounter and it was as if the whole nation was holding its breath in anxious anticipation.

The Lankans—despite having won just two of their last 10 completed matches against India—were confident from the start. About the only thing that went right for India was Dravid winning the toss. Having learned his mistake after opting to bat first against Bangladesh, this time he put Lanka in.

The Indian bowlers stuck to their task manfully and did well to restrict their opponents to 254 for six on what was an easier batting track than for the match against Bangladesh.

But the Indian batting was a terrible let-down. Captain Dravid was like the boy on the burning deck, heroically holding out while the rest of the team fell all around him. He did get brief support from Sehwag (48), but after that he was forced to wage a lone hand. Ganguly and Tendulkar failed and Yuvraj was foolishly run out.

The last straw for the shattered captain, who could only watch ashen-faced from the other end, was when Dhoni walked even before bowler Muralitharan could appeal or the umpire give his verdict; trapped lbw, plumb in front for a first-ball duck. The batsman appeared almost embarrassed and that was a summary of just how pathetic the batting was. Dravid slammed Lasith Malinga for four consecutive fours, but that was done more in a fit of rage and helplessness as he forlornly watched his team throw it all away.

Murali was Man of the Match for his three vital wickets and two catches, as Lanka handsomely won by 69 runs. For India there was only despair and the faint hope that Bermuda might somehow pull off a miracle by beating Bangladesh in the last Group B tie two days later.

That was not to be and the misery of India's worst World Cup campaign since the second tournament in 1979 (when they also lost to Sri

Lanka) was thus complete. And yes, the unbelievable was now a reality—it would be Bangladesh vs Ireland at Bridgetown, Barbados on 15 April, and not India vs Pakistan!

After the defeat to Lanka, both Dravid and coach Chappell faced a grilling from the media. Dravid repeatedly expressed his disappointment while Chappell was defensive and refused to answer numerous questions, dubbing them ‘inflammatory’. Discontent with the coach had been simmering for some time, and it seemed to boil over once the team landed in the West Indies at the beginning of their World Cup campaign. There was a lack of fire and fight as morale appeared to sink to an all-time low.

Chappell more than anyone knew his job was in jeopardy. He had been appointed till the World Cup but any chances of an extension had now disappeared. Wisely, he stepped down before being asked to go. Anil Kumble too announced his retirement from ODIs on the team’s return.

Sadly, the public reaction back home brought only shame and ridicule to the nation. The passion for cricket in India was exposed as nothing but irrational fanaticism and the electronic media was culpable in several deplorable acts of protest across the country.

In Ranchi, a small group of vandals attacked—in full view of the TV cameras—the property gifted to Dhoni by the Jharkhand government. It later emerged that they had paraded themselves as some sort of a local political party, and had alerted the TV stations to their impending act of vandalism. Their fifteen seconds of fame (or infamy) were thus assured and such acts were repeated near Tendulkar’s home in Mumbai and Zaheer Khan’s family restaurant in Pune. Always present were the TV cameras.

Mahi’s parents were understandably furious. The sound bites they regularly gave to news channels whenever their son was in the headlines are now a thing of the past. Paan Singh and Devki have since boycotted all news channels. In this small but significant manner they have made clear their feelings.

The Board was quick to jump on the bandwagon of public sentiment. They reacted with indecent haste and issued a set of guidelines which sought to treat the nation’s cricketers like recalcitrant schoolboys.

It had long been felt in cricket circles that players’ agents maintained an unhealthy influence on selection matters. It was also rumoured—though never confirmed—that companies sporting their logos on bats had clauses offering bonuses linked to the amount of time the player spent at the

crease (thus increasing brand exposure) rather than runs scored. The hidden question: Could that explain the slow run-rate of some of India's top batsmen at the World Cup?

Now the BCCI decided that players' personal endorsements would be restricted to three products and not more than two players could endorse products other than those contracted to the Board. No player would be allowed to endorse a product two weeks before and after a series, and only the captain would be allowed to write a column.

The individual freedom of India's cricketers was being called into question and the agents' lobby immediately swung into action by launching a media campaign. Indian cricket was at a low ebb, and bitterness and recrimination were in the air.

But the stringent measures would not last for long. Just six months later would come a World Cup triumph of another kind in South Africa. . .

If nothing else, the early exit gave the players some breathing space before their next assignment. Less than two weeks after the end of the World Cup, the Indians found themselves in Bangladesh. India won both the ODI and Test series on the tour, but any feelings of revenge for the World Cup shock were meaningless.

Chappell's departure meant the team were without a coach, and the Board wisely appointed former Test captain Ravi Shastri as 'cricket manager' in a stop-gap measure.

Tendulkar and Ganguly were 'rested' from the ODI series, though many saw that more as a euphemism for being dropped. If that was indeed the case, it was an unwelcome first for Tendulkar. They were, however, both back for the two Test matches that followed.

There was a shock in store for India in the first ODI in Mirpur. It took a heroic display by Dhoni to save them from the embarrassment of what would have been their third defeat at the hands of Bangladesh in their last four encounters. Crippled by an agonising bout of cramps in the right hamstring, brought on by the extreme heat and humidity, Dhoni bravely batted on, practically on one leg, with Yuvraj acting as his runner.

Bangladesh had batted first and put up a challenging 250 for seven in 47 overs, the match being shortened by rain. Wickets began to tumble and at 114 for five, India required another 107 from 113 balls. Together at the crease were the two 'keeper/ batsmen, Dhoni and Dinesh Karthik.

Promoted once again to number three, Dhoni hobbled about and called for the runner when on 39. No doubt his usual exuberant style was also cramped and he showed a new side of his batting as he battled to take India home.

Despite numerous nervous moments, the pair closed out the victory with an undefeated century stand and with one over to spare. It had been almost too close for comfort but Dhoni's innings of 91 not out, which won him the Man of the Match, was a revelation.

After the match, Dravid told the press: 'He (Dhoni) does not play in just one fashion. He has got the ability to change gears, to change the tempo of the game, play according to the situation and that's a fantastic gift to have at such a young age.'

India won the second ODI by 46 runs and the third was abandoned due to rain. Rain also heavily curtailed the first Test at Chittagong which ended in a draw and then the full might of India's batting shut out Bangladesh in the second Test at Dhaka.

The top four batsmen all scored centuries, and Dhoni was 51 not out in India's imposing 610 for three declared. Bangladesh were crushed by an innings and 239 runs in less than three days.

But it was a no-win situation for Dravid as he acknowledged at the end of the tour: 'Had we not done well, people would have said, "What's happening?"' Had we won, it's not a big deal. So it was tough in that sense.'

The bigger challenge was just ahead, a long and arduous tour of England.

But before that there was the rather pointless exercise of the second Afro-Asia Cup with three ODIs staged in Bangalore and Chennai in June, the height of summer. The first edition had been staged in South Africa and was a big flop. The second did not fare much better. The whole concept of composite teams playing official international matches, as sanctioned by the ICC, has come in for a lot of flak from the world's cricket statisticians and journalists. And many of the top players understandably made themselves unavailable for the series.

Asia XI made a clean sweep of the series, though the high-scoring matches were quite competitive. Once again the crowds stayed away.

After scoring two and 33, Dhoni came into his own in the third at Chennai, where he recorded his third ODI century.

His blistering 139 not out (the highest score by a number seven batsman), combined with three stumpings, won him the Man of the Match award and his partnership of 218 runs for the sixth wicket with captain Mahela Jayawardene established a new world record. Ninety of Dhoni's runs came in boundaries.

After that, India set off to play three Test matches in England and a bewildering array of ODIs against a host of opponents. The one-off match against Pakistan at Glasgow was washed out; India trounced Ireland by nine wickets in their first match-up at Belfast and then beat South Africa, also at Belfast, for the first time in an ODI series away from home, winning 2-1. And all this even before the start of the Test series!

A number of the touring party were struck down by flu at the start of the tour and this saw Dhoni miss the one-off Ireland ODI and the opening match against South Africa.

The last time India (led by Ganguly) had played a Test series in England in 2002, it had ended 1-1. In 75 years of Test cricket they had only twice won a series on English soil: in 1971 when captained by Ajit Wadekar, and then in 1986 under Kapil Dev.

The opening Test at Lord's was a thriller till the very last delivery. It was ultimately a spell of rain on the final day that saved India who were nine down when the match was abandoned as a draw.

It was only the second instance in their Test history that India had salvaged a draw with just one wicket in hand and for this they were indebted to a stout rearguard action by Dhoni.

England took a handy first innings lead of 97 runs and had India on the mat after they scored 282 in the second innings, setting India 380 runs to chase down.

Given the conditions, with swing bowlers dominating India's only thought was to escape with a draw—and they just about managed to do that.

They finished the fourth day on 137 for three, and it is a fair bet that if it had not been for the weather—rain curtailed play on each of the five days—England would have gone one-up in the series. Only 55 overs were possible on the final day, due to rain and bad light.

Dhoni had failed to open his account in the first innings but made amends on the fifth day, coming in with the score-card reading a shaky 145 for five.

Though unconvincing in his technique and enjoying a large dollop of luck throughout his 203 minutes at the crease, his 76 not out was full of pluck and determination. It was the new-look Dhoni at the crease and one the Indian team were immensely grateful to.

Despite the fading light and tense situation, Dhoni did reveal glimpses of his attacking mindset and struck 10 boundaries even towards the end, when survival was the top priority. The 159 deliveries he faced made all the difference in the end for the relieved Indians.

It made up for his sloppy 'keeping in the match, though the conditions made it pretty tough for both the wicket-keepers.

The second Test match at Trent Bridge, Nottingham marked India's 200th Test abroad. It also turned out to be one of their most notable victories. With Zaheer leading the way with nine wickets in the match and Tendulkar scoring 91 in the first innings, the Indians sealed the match by seven wickets. It was their 29th win on foreign soil and only their fifth on 15 tours of England.

On 7 August, just two days before the start of the third and final Test at the Oval, it was announced that Dhoni would captain India at the inaugural World Twenty20 in South Africa. He was also named as vice-captain to Dravid for the ODI side.

Once India had piled up a record 664 in their first innings at the Oval, Dravid fell back on safety-first tactics. The captain was happy to sit on the 1-0 lead and failed to enforce the follow-on despite a first innings lead of 319 runs.

England lost six wickets in their second innings after Dravid's second innings declaration set them an impossible 500-run target. A little more time and the bowlers could have made it 2-0.

However, nothing could detract from the team's performance as they marked the 75th anniversary of India's entry into Test cricket with the first series victory on English soil since 1986. The Test itself was marked by Kumble's maiden century in his 118th Test and Dhoni's 92.

The wicket-keeper was back at his ebullient best. Having dourly staved off defeat at Lord's, he was now under no pressure as he came in this time with the score reading a healthy 345 for five. That gave him the freedom to play his natural attacking game and the result was a typically marauding 92 from 81 balls including nine fours and four sixes.

Despite his batting feats, both Dhoni and his English counterpart Matt Prior faced a lot of flak for their technique behind the stumps, even though the conditions made it difficult for both of them.

Writing in *The Sportstar* (22 September 2007), former Australian captain and coach Bobby Simpson lamented the lack of world-class wicket-keepers in the modern game. He blamed the emphasis on batting rather than 'keeping skills as the main reason behind this malaise. 'Much of the wicket-keeping problems today stem from the 'keepers' desire to take the ball on the drop below their knees. Great wicket-keepers of the past always took the ball about waist high, on the rise,' Simpson wrote.

'Dhoni had a good series with the bat and is probably good enough to hold his place in the team with his batting alone. But he has been disappointing behind the stumps, and I would be surprised if someone told me that there are no better wicket-keepers in India. Where are the Kirmanis of Indian cricket? Where are the Alan Knotts and the Wally Grouts? Cricket is poorer for their absence.'

After the Test series it was back to the one-day whirl with seven ODIs crammed into nineteen days. Before that there was also a one-off ODI against Scotland which India won with ease.

It meant the team had faced five different opponents on the tour—England, South Africa, Ireland, Pakistan and Scotland.

Although he did not produce any batting fireworks, Dhoni redeemed himself with a fine display of wicket-keeping. In the fifth match at Leeds he equalled the world record with six victims in the match (five catches and one stumping).

The series was an enthralling one, with the teams locked 3-3 going into the Lord's decider.

Once again, the famed Indian batting failed in a crunch game. Dhoni top-scored with 50, his highest of the series, as England won by seven wickets to take the series 4-3.

And so the tour, lasting two-and-a-half months, finally came to an end. But there would be no break for Dhoni and several others in the touring party. It was straight off to South Africa for the first World Twenty20.



CHAPTER EIGHT

Triumph in South Africa

IT WAS OBVIOUS from his first press conference in London on 7 August, after being appointed as captain for the World Twenty20, that Dhoni was a fast learner.

Being an Indian cricketer, especially as captain, is also about dealing with the media—particularly with people from the countless TV channels—and this can be a stressful business. One slip of the tongue can within minutes become a racy headline.

Dhoni was a mixture of tact and charm as he dealt with the verbal volleys thrown at him. There were a couple of ‘no comments’, but a broad smile rarely left his face.

Perhaps it had yet to sink in how a lad from Ranchi who first played for the country less than three years ago had now become the first from Jharkhand (or Bihar) state to receive the rare honour of captaining the national cricket team, albeit in the newest and shortest version of the game.

It was indeed one of modern India’s finest feel-good stories.

‘I am like a brand ambassador for the people of Jharkhand,’ he told the press without a hint of vanity. ‘It’s a small state where the infrastructure isn’t great for cricket. Five years ago nobody would have

ever thought that someone from this state would play for India. Now, if I look back, I'm excited for the job.'

Senior batsmen Rahul Dravid, Sachin Tendulkar and Sourav Ganguly had all opted out. It was felt the format was best suited to younger players and the team did have a youthful look to it— with the exception of some familiar names like Virender Sehwag, Ajit Agarkar and Harbhajan Singh. The two new faces were Joginder Sharma, and Yusuf Pathan, elder half-brother of Irfan, who was also selected.

'We thought it better if the younger guys played that tournament. Twenty20 is a game for youngsters. I think it was a proper decision and the way forward for Indian cricket,' was what Dravid told the press when the 30 probables for the event had been announced in England in July.

Yuvraj Singh was appointed Dhoni's deputy. There was a hint here and there that he was miffed at being passed over since he had made his international debut four years before the wicket-keeper batsman. But the feeling was, his party-boy image—rightly or wrongly—had inveighed against him.

The genesis of Twenty20 cricket had been in England, the land which also invented the limited-overs game in the '60s. Stuart Robertson, the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB) marketing manager at the time, is widely credited with being the brains behind the concept.

Average attendances at matches had dropped to 1,200 per game and it was hoped this would double in the first year of the new event. On 13 July 2003 the inaugural Twenty20 was launched and crowds averaged 5,000—which is impressive, considering the small grounds in England.

It rose higher the following year and Lord's was packed to capacity (27,500) for the Middlesex vs Surrey match. That was the seal of approval the format needed. If Lord's, the traditional home of cricket, could warm to this new concept, the rest of England would surely follow.

Soon, other countries introduced domestic Twenty20 competitions and it began to take off all over the cricket world. The matches were a massive hit in New Zealand, Australia, Pakistan and South Africa, where such crowds were unheard of for domestic cricket.

The first T-20 International was played at Eden Park, Auckland, on 17 February 2005, with Australia beating hosts New Zealand by 44 runs. But the players were yet to accept it as a legitimate form of cricket and the whole game was played in a lighthearted carnival atmosphere, with the

Kiwis turning up in their vintage beige outfits of the '80s and sporting retro hairstyles.

Only a handful of Twenty20 Internationals had been played prior to the world championship and the Indians had the experience of the solitary game which they had won in December 2006 in Johannesburg. Indeed, the Indian cricket board had held out the longest when it came to voting for the world championship at the ICC.

Ironical as it sounds now following the mega-success of the Indian Premier League, at that time BCCI president Sharad Pawar voted against the world championship as he felt Twenty20 cricket would adversely affect the playing techniques of youngsters.

A vastly different tune is being heard today. But as a result of their initial reluctance, the BCCI was dragged kicking and screaming into organising the first domestic Twenty20 tournament in the 2006-07 season.

It turned out to be a mighty flop, played as it was before empty stands despite all the top names participating thanks to India's early exit from the 50-over World Cup. The Board did not even bother to sell the telecast rights.

The whole thing was treated almost like a formality which the Board had been forced to go through with. When Tamil Nadu beat Punjab by two wickets in the first final in Mumbai on 21 April 2007, hardly anyone took notice.

Dhoni had scores of 1, 12, 37 not out and 73 not out. But Jharkhand failed to advance from East Zone to the national stage of the tournament, with only the top two teams from each of the five zones making it to this stage.

The ICC had learned their lesson from the disaster of the 50-over World Cup in the West Indies which had ended less than six months before. The duration of this tournament was much shorter and the restrictions on the crowds were relaxed to allow a party atmosphere to prevail—something that had been sadly dampened in the Caribbean.

Dhoni and his boys flew directly from London, without the chance to drop home for a breather. But, unlike in the 50-over World Cup, there was very little pre-tournament hype—and thus much less pressure on the team this time.

With the country's lack of experience in the Twenty20 format, no one really gave the Indians much chance. And as was the case 24 years earlier

with Kapil Dev's team at the Prudential World Cup, this lack of hype and pressure did a world of good to the side.

The 12 teams were divided into four preliminary groups, and India were in Group D with Scotland and Pakistan. The top two from each group advanced to the Super 8 stage where they would be split into two groups.

The Group D games were to be staged at Durban, where the large population of Indian origin was expected to give a boost to India's chances. The organisers could not have dreamed of a better launch-pad than the opening match between South Africa and the West Indies in Johannesburg on 11 September. It rained sixes, with Windies opener Chris Gayle smashing the first century, including a record 10 sixes, in Twenty20 Internationals. And yet the hosts won by eight wickets with plenty to spare.

The next two days produced two shockers. First, no-hopers Zimbabwe stunned 50-overs world champions Australia, and then Bangladesh sent West Indies crashing out of the tournament.

In Group D, Pakistan beat Scotland by 51 runs, and the next day, India's opening match against Scotland was washed out without a ball being bowled. It meant the India-Pakistan encounter had an added edge. India would be eliminated if they lost by a large margin.

But on the morning of the game, the Indian team were in for a shock. Back home in Bangalore, Rahul Dravid had dropped a bombshell—he was quitting the captaincy of the Test and ODI teams.

The players gathered in huddled groups at the hotel breakfast tables. Could it be true? Bowling coach Venkatesh Prasad phoned Anil Kumble to confirm the news. What could have been behind the dramatic move? After all, Dravid had just led India to their first Test series victory in England in 21 years.

For once, Dravid's timing could be faulted. A loss of focus would be fatal, and it took an extra effort for Dhoni to persuade his players to push the news to the back of their minds, with the crucial match just hours away.

The Australians were due to visit India for seven ODIs just after the world championships ended, and within days of Dravid's shocker, Dhoni was appointed captain for the 50-over game as well.

At the match in Durban, a boisterous full house watched engrossed as the nagging accuracy of Pakistan's opening bowler Mohammad Asif

reduced India to 36 for four. Then, in the first twist of a tantalizing game, Robin Uthappa (50) and Dhoni (33) rebuilt the innings in bowler-friendly conditions. The final score of 141 for nine was competitive, and it was game on.

Pakistan too suffered early shocks and half their side was out for 87. With 39 runs needed from 14 balls, it looked like India were home and dry. But Misbah-ul-Haq then let loose and Agarkar conceded 17 from the penultimate over. With two deliveries left in Sreesanth's final over, the scores were tied. Dhoni, though, kept his cool and managed to calm down his excited young players.

Misbah missed the fifth ball and from the sixth of the over, the last of the match, he was run out for 53. It was only the second tie in Twenty20 Internationals and the 'bowl-out' was employed to decide the winner.

Cricket's equivalent of football's penalty shoot-out has its fair share of critics. But while Pakistan were shell-shocked and slow to react, the Indians had come prepared. The first three Indian bowlers—Sehwag, Harbhajan and Uthappa—connected with the stumps, while the Pakistanis all missed. India had won the match by the football-like score of 3-0.

Pakistan captain Shoaib Malik and coach Geoff Lawson admitted they were unaware of the bowl-out rule. Dhoni, on the other hand, revealed that the Indians had been preparing for such an eventuality during practice sessions. He, however, admitted he was not happy with such an artificial way of deciding a result. 'I don't want to see a cricket match decided on a bowl-out,' Dhoni said. 'The team plays so hard to get a result and it should always be decided on the field.'

He wasn't expecting the match to end with a football scoreline of 3-0. 'It really amuses you. Winning a cricket match 3-0, it doesn't happen every time,' he said. 'But it is in the record books now. I can tell my friends, when I was captain my team won 3-0.'

It also meant India had kept intact their record of never having lost to Pakistan in a World Cup match, either 50-50 or Twenty20.

India were grouped with New Zealand, England and South Africa in the second stage of the tournament and their first match in the Super Eights put a temporary brake on their campaign.

At Johannesburg, New Zealand captain and left-arm spinner Daniel Vettori turned in a brilliant performance after opener Gautam Gambhir and Sehwag gave India a flying start in reply to the Kiwis' total of 190. When

Sehwag was out for 40, the first wicket stand had raced to 76 from a mere 35 deliveries and India looked to be sailing home.

Vettori had Uthappa caught and bowled for a duck in his first over and then accounted for Gambhir, Karthik and Irfan Pathan to send India crashing to defeat by 10 runs. Only Dhoni, with 24 from 20 balls, offered some resistance after the opening partnership.

The pressure was back on India as they faced England, but at least they were back at Durban in front of their adoring supporters. Every match from now on would be a must-win for Dhoni and his boys.

The match turned out to be a sizzler, featuring one of the greatest feats of big hitting in cricket history. Gambhir and Sehwag's opening stand of 136 was the ideal launch pad and then, in the 19th over, Yuvraj re-wrote the record books.

Andrew Flintoff made the mistake of provoking Yuvraj at the end of his previous over in which the left-hander had struck two boundaries. A nasty remark from England's all-rounder saw Yuvraj advance down the pitch to confront him while captain Dhoni rushed to restrain his teammate.

It was the spark that lit the fuse. Fast bowler Stuart Broad and his English team-mates did not know what hit them as Yuvraj smashed six sixes in the over.

In 129 years of international cricket till 2006, the feat had never been achieved. Then, in 2007, in the span of six months, it was done twice, first in the 50-over World Cup by South Africa's Herschelle Gibbs against the Netherlands.

Only Garry Sobers and Ravi Shastri before them had pulled off the remarkable achievement, but theirs were in domestic first-class matches, not the international arena. And Dhoni could only look on in awe from the non-striker's end as Yuvraj went berserk, and so did the crowd. His half-century came from 12 deliveries, the quickest in the history of top-level cricket. It was also sweet revenge for Yuvraj, as earlier that month at the Oval, he had been clouted for five sixes in an over by England's Dmitri Mascarenhas. England were beaten by 18 runs but in reality it was Yuvraj who had knocked the fight out of them.

India needed to beat South Africa, too, in the final Super Eight match held at Durban, to make it to the semis. The hosts, on the other hand, were the only unbeaten team in the championship and were simply required to

score 126 to reach the last four. But, as had happened so often in the past, they botched things up.

Yuvraj could not play due to tendonitis of the left elbow and was replaced by Dinesh Karthik. Batting first, India slipped to 33 for three before a partnership of 85 runs for the fifth wicket between 20-year-old Rohit Sharma (in his first innings in the championship), and Dhoni took them a challenging 153 for five on a difficult batting track.

At the halfway stage, they had only 57 runs on the board before the last five produced 56 with Sharma (50 not out) and Dhoni (45) both striking the ball clean and hard. Left-arm seamer R.P. Singh then took control and South Africa's reply subsided to 31 for five.

Dhoni had given up the gloves as he was suffering from back pain, and Karthik, who took over behind the stumps, was outstanding in the field. He had earlier taken a spectacular catch at second slip to send back Gibbs, and now, with the gloves, he pulled off two stumpings.

There was a late surge but the South Africans were caught in two minds: should they go for the winning target of 154, or settle for 126, which would book their berth in the semifinals?

In the end, they got to neither, finishing on 116 for nine. The tag of 'chokers', which had haunted them for so many years, now seemed fully justified. A stunned captain Graeme Smith was furious, not only at the result but also at the crowd which supported India vociferously. India had found a new star in Sharma, who batted brilliantly and fielded thrillingly to take home the Man of the Match award.

So the semifinal lineup was decided: Pakistan vs New Zealand at Cape Town, and India vs Australia at Durban. Pakistan easily won the first semi by 33 runs. Would it be an India-Pakistan final for the first time in a World Cup?

Australia could consider themselves fortunate to have got this far, thanks to the championship format. After the shock of the early defeat at the hands of Zimbabwe, they were also beaten by Pakistan in their Super Eight match. But they made it on the back of crushing wins against Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

The reigning 50-overs world champions had still not quite taken to cricket's new format. Captain Ricky Ponting admitted as much, and it was obvious from the Australians' lacklustre show so far.

Still, this was different. India and Australia were battling for who would make it to the first-ever final of the World T-20 championship and their matches over the last six years had always carried that extra edge.

India were the shock team of the tournament. No-one, not even the players themselves, could have imagined their getting this far, considering their lack of experience. But Dhoni had led from the front and his level-headedness in a crisis had brought out the best in all the players.

It turned out to be the best match of the tournament till then. Though India won by 15 runs, it could have gone either way, right till the very end. The intensity from both sides never dipped.

Dhoni stuck to his formula of batting first on winning the toss—it had worked against England and South Africa. Brett Lee and Nathan Bracken gave nothing away, and after eight overs, India had managed only 41 runs for the loss of Gambhir and Sehwag.

Fortunately, Yuvraj was back in action and he pulled Stewart Clark for six to get off the mark. He found the perfect partner in Uthappa and the pair cut loose to slam 84 runs from 40 balls. Among Yuvraj's five sixes was a flick off Lee that sent the ball soaring 119 metres over square leg—the biggest hit of the tournament. Dhoni smacked 36 at the strike-rate of 200 and the last 11 overs had yielded 140 runs.

Australia started positively in chasing down India's 188 for five. Matthew Hayden and Andrew Symonds took charge and the target began to shrink.

Dhoni pulled off the first of his tactical masterstrokes when he brought back Sreesanth for his fourth and final over to break the stand. His fiery yorker uprooted Hayden's off stump and the bowler celebrated wildly. Still, Australia were in control of the chase, needing 55 runs from 32 balls. In fact they were level with or ahead of the Indian total right till the end of the 18th over. With 30 needed from three overs, it was Dhoni again who did the trick by bringing Harbhajan back into the attack. The off-spinner bowled Michael Clarke and conceded just three runs. Then R.P. Singh gave away only five runs from the 19th over.

Suddenly, it was all over. Dhoni's tactical acumen and his bowlers' discipline had saved the day. It would be an India–Pakistan final after all.

The Indians celebrated long, hard and deliriously. Indeed, Sreesanth was fined 25 per cent of his match fees for excessive appealing. And Yuvraj's manic arm-waving at the end did appear over the top. But their

joy was understandable. They had beaten the world (50-overs) champions and were in the final just six months after their humiliation in the World Cup in the West Indies.

At the end of the match, Dhoni gently pulled the leg of TV presenter and former captain Ravi Shastri, who had written in his column the day before that Australia were the favourites to win. 'I read your column,' Dhoni said to Shastri, a cheeky grin spreading across his face. 'You said Australia were favourites. I think we surprised you.' A red-faced Shastri could only nod meekly as thousands of Indian fans roared their approval at their captain's boldness.

The seeds of bitterness that emerged in the matches between the two nations over the next few months were sown in this match. The Australians resented the intensity of the Indians' euphoria and Symonds said as much in his newspaper column. It was a clear case of sour grapes—India were hungrier on the day and their record in the championship was far superior to Australia's.

Indeed, an India–Pakistan final was one the rest of the cricket world, and the ICC as well, were praying for after the shock exits of both Asian giants in the World Cup in March. They had also been the two best sides at this event and it was their tied match 10 days earlier (won by India via the bowl-out) that brought the cricket world to its feet.

The traditional rivalry between the two sides would guarantee a full house and top up what had been a roaring commercial and critical success. It was like the kiss-of-life to world cricket and its governing body, the ICC, after the fiasco of the Australia–Sri Lanka World Cup final in Barbados in April.

Dhoni's luck with the toss continued and he stuck to his habit of batting first. It was a thriller from the very first ball—a third-umpire referral that reprieved Yusuf Pathan from a close run-out call.

Gambhir once again played the anchor role to perfection with 75 from 54 balls. He was out in the 18th over, but the big hitters failed to complement him. Uthappa, Yuvraj and Dhoni were all out cheaply and it took some late hitting from Rohit Sharma (30 not out from 16 balls) to help India post a competitive—though not imposing—157 for five.

India's striker bowler R.P. Singh once again made early inroads with the scalps of Mohammad Hafeez and Kamran Akmal. Uthappa brilliantly ran out Imran Nazir (33) just when he was threatening to take control.

With Younis Khan and Shahid Afridi both falling in the same over from Irfan Pathan, Pakistan's innings was in tatters at 77 for six after 11.4 overs.

But Pakistan's hero Misbah was battling away and as long as he was at the crease, no cause seemed lost. Harbhajan had conceded 18 runs from his first two overs. But in his third, the 17th of the innings with Pakistan requiring a steep 54 from four overs, Misbah decided to it was time to cut loose. The result was the off-spinner being clouted for 19 runs, including three sixes, and now the equation had dropped to 35 runs needed from three overs.

Pace bowler Sohail Tanvir decided to display his batting prowess and Sreesanth went for 15 runs, including two sixes. But he bowled Tanvir from the last ball of the over and the pendulum had swung India's way again with Pakistan on 138 for eight.

It was down to 20 runs from the last two overs with two wickets in hand—including Misbah. Singh bowled tightly to concede only seven, and also take the wicket of Umar Gul. The last pair were now at the crease with 13 needed from the final over.

Harbhajan had an over in hand but his confidence had been shattered by the previous over onslaught, and Dhoni turned after much discussion to his weakest link, medium pacer Joginder Sharma. The other three top bowlers—Singh, Sreesanth and Irfan—had all completed their quota.

The rookie bowler betrayed his nerves by bowling a huge wide first ball and with Misbah on strike, Pakistan's hopes were high. A quiet word in the bowler's ear from his apparently nerveless captain, and a dot ball followed. The next though was a full-toss which Misbah carted for six. Six runs needed from four balls—and surely Pakistan now had the trophy in their grasp.

But with memories of the tied group match at the back of his mind, when he had failed to score off the last two balls, Misbah decided to throw caution to the winds. He confessed later he did not want to leave it till too late and his desperate leg-side scoop landed safely in the hands of a nervy Sreesanth.

It was all over. India were World Twenty20 champions against all the odds and even Dhoni's cool façade cracked briefly as he pumped his fists in a mixture of joy and relief.

Finally, another major world title to follow on from the Prudential World Cup of 1983. And that, too, at the same venue, the New Wanderers

Stadium in Johannesburg, where India had lost the 2003 World Cup final to Australia.

Dhoni's refusal to attack his players on the field when something went wrong led one writer, after the final, to describe him as the only adult in Indian cricket. The decision to give Joginder the final over may have been forced on him. But the same bowler had also bowled the last over in the semis when Australia needed 22 to win and had plenty of wickets in hand. He gave away just six in that over and took two wickets as well, so maybe Dhoni was on to something after all. Comparisons were already being made with Mansur Ali Khan (the Nawab of Pataudi), arguably India's most iconic skipper.

As the Indians celebrated deliriously, Dhoni assumed a Zenlike calmness, after his brief celebration when the final wicket had fallen. He peeled off his India shirt and handed it to a young Indian boy who had been present at all the team's games. It was a spontaneous and moving gesture that touched the hearts of millions (and inevitably spawned a TV commercial weeks later). His bare-chested swagger captured the imagination of the cricket world.

Back in India, the streets at night filled with jubilant fans setting off fire-crackers and dancing with joy. The humiliation, anguish and bitterness of six months had suddenly been swept aside.

It was yet another display of fan schizophrenia and when happy crowds gathered outside Dhoni's residence in Ranchi, his parents refused to greet them or speak to the waiting reporters. The fans' and media's memories may have been short. But Paan Singh and Devki were not yet ready to forget and forgive.

The tournament was a massive success and India's victory was the icing on the cake. It would also set in motion events that months later would change the face of cricket forever.

Dhoni gave credit to his bowlers who had defended magnificently throughout the championship. 'On paper the batting was much stronger,' he said after the final. 'But the way the bowlers bowled was very good, and if you compare the two, our bowling was much more consistent. Though there were a few good individual batting performances, the bowling was better through the tournament. Our fielding helped too. We effected a run-out in almost every game.'

About the decision to bowl Joginder instead of Harbhajan in the final over, Dhoni said it was prompted by the form on the day. 'That was the best option available. Harbhajan didn't bowl his last over very well. I thought, if a medium pacer bowls, it would be slightly difficult, since Misbah was timing it very well against Harbhajan, who was also not 100-per-cent sure about his yorkers. And Joginder had had a decent spell till then in the match, so I decided to go with him.'

He modestly brushed aside praise of his captaincy. 'The captain hasn't done much. The players, who have been given the responsibility, have delivered.'

It was not only the fans who were playing chameleon. The top BCCI officials, who had treated the players like so many errant schoolboys six months ago, had rushed to South Africa once the team made it to the final. Now, they crowded and jostled their way into the team photos, when, months earlier, they were busy washing their hands off the flop show.

Amazingly, just five days after the final, India would face Australia at home in the first of seven ODIs and one T-20. There was barely time for the players to catch their breath and soak in the victory.

A hastily arranged open-bus victory parade from Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji airport to the Wankhede Stadium paralysed the city, as massive crowds turned out to greet their heroes in pouring rain. The journey took five hours, leading Dhoni to exclaim: 'We are told that Mumbai is a city which is always on the move. See, my boys and I have brought the entire city to a standstill today.'

Victory was indeed sweet—as was the Rs-80-lakh bonus awarded to each player by the BCCI. All the strictures of a few months back were quietly swept under the carpet. Who could argue with world champions?

Dhoni addressed the crowd at the Wankhede Stadium and admitted he was a bit nervous about his maiden captaincy assignment. 'A little nervousness at this level is justified, but the way all 15 players responded, I hardly had reason to worry,' he said. 'Whoever I tossed the ball to fetched me wickets. Whoever walked out to bat, scored runs. So the pressure was considerably less on me. Besides, the entire team had full faith in each other's abilities and that's important.'

Amidst all the euphoria, the Australians were back in India, smarting from their defeat in the T-20 semifinals and vowing revenge in the 50-over

format. It was soon back to business, and for Dhoni it was his first taste of captaincy in the 50-over format.

It was not a pleasant experience. The Australians were ruthless, with Symonds in blazing form. His batting was awesome, his off-spin useful, and his fielding electric. The result was a 4-2 victory with the first match declared a no-result due to rain. The Indians were clearly outplayed in all departments. The racist comments from the crowd directed at Symonds were an ugly omen of things to come in Australia a couple of months later and sadly overshadowed a magnificent display by the world champions.

The players also went at each other in the first half of the series before Match Referee Chris Broad stepped in to cool things down. Dhoni, while not exactly stoking the fires of aggression from his side, did nothing to control them either. It was the start of the fight-fire-with-fire policy. Overall, the tour left a bad taste in the mouth.

Dhoni batted usefully in the second, third and fourth games, before his performance tapered off. But there was some consolation for the Twenty20 world champions as they handily beat the 50-overs title holders in the one-off T-20 international at Mumbai that followed the ODI series.



CHAPTER NINE

On Top Down Under

WITH RAHUL DRAVID having resigned the captaincy in September, and M.S. Dhoni given charge of the Twenty20 and ODI team, the selectors were now faced with the task of choosing a Test captain. The immediate challenge was posed by Pakistan arriving in India to play three Tests and five ODIs.

Once Sachin Tendulkar turned down the job, it was a toss-up between Dhoni and veteran leg-spinner Anil Kumble.

Amid much drama and speculation, the choice was made on 8 November. Kumble would lead India at the age of 37—one of the oldest Indian captains at the time of appointment—and with 118 Tests behind him, a world record.

It was a popular choice for Kumble had been a silent and long-serving warrior for the country, having made his Test debut in 1990. He was the first pure-bowler captain to be appointed since Bishan Singh Bedi took over in 1976.

No bowler had won so many matches both at home and abroad for India. And having retired from ODIs after the World Cup, it would be the first time India would have different captains for Tests and limited-over matches.

With two high-profile encounters up ahead, first against Pakistan at home and then Australia away, the selectors' line of thinking was to give

the captaincy to the experienced man rather than Dhoni who, at 26, had just three years of international cricket behind him. But Dhoni was already vice-captain for the Tests and it was obvious he was the heir-apparent once Kumble called it a day.

‘Better late than never,’ was the new captain’s typically laconic response to the news.

Pakistan, too, came to India with a captain, Shoaib Malik, who had been appointed just a few months earlier, while for Dhoni this was only his second 50-over series in charge after the recent 2-4 loss at the hands of Australia.

On the day of Kumble’s appointment Pakistan won the second ODI at Mohali by four wickets in a sensational manner, overtaking India’s 321 for nine with one ball remaining. The series was now level 1-1.

Dhoni had been Man of the Match and top scorer for India in the first game at Guwahati with 63, the home side winning by five wickets.

Dhoni and Yuvraj had a match-winning century stand at Guwahati and they were at their best again in the third match at Kanpur. India won by 46 runs to take the lead in the series. This time it was Yuvraj’s (77) turn to be Man of the Match, with Dhoni contributing 49.

At 159 for four in reply to Pakistan’s 255 for six, India were struggling in the fourth match at Gwalior. That’s when the dynamic duo took India home without further loss with an unbeaten century stand, their third in the series.

That sealed the deal for the home side and once again Dhoni was the toast for his first 50-overs series rubber. Pakistan had a consolation win in the fifth and final match but it was too late and the score-line read 3-2 in India’s favour.

Deservingly, Yuvraj claimed another Man of the Series award, though Dhoni was not too far behind. He was also a clear winner in the captaincy contest against his Pakistani counterpart.

It was fitting that Feroze Shah Kotla in New Delhi was the venue for Kumble’s captaincy debut. It was at this ground, against Pakistan in 1999, that he had become only the second bowler (after England’s Jim Laker in 1956) to take all 10 wickets in an innings.

Once again, he was in peak bowling form, claiming four wickets in the first innings as Pakistan collapsed to 231.

Pakistan's bowlers hit back on the second day. Shoaib Akhtar bowled with tremendous pace and left-arm seamer Sohail Tanvir picked up two wickets on debut as the Indian innings subsided to 93 for five.

V.V.S. Laxman and Dhoni were the last recognised batting pair at the crease, even though captain Kumble, who was next in the line-up, had recorded his maiden century in the previous Test in England.

Initially, the pair batted cautiously, scampering singles to ease the pressure. But it was in the final session of the second day that Dhoni opened up, singling out spinner Danish Kaneria for special treatment.

While Dhoni used his own special brand of muscle power to overcome the bowlers, Laxman was all silken touch, as always. It was a fascinating contrast, watching the two in unison salvaging the situation.

Dhoni was hampered in his movements after reaching his 50 due to an ankle injury he had picked up in the Jaipur ODI flaring up. Though he had it strapped on the field, it was clearly a factor when, on 57, he charged at Kaneria and got a thin edge to wicket-keeper Kamran Akmal.

The partnership had been worth a priceless 115 runs. It enabled India to come within sniffing distance of Pakistan's total with four wickets still in hand and Laxman batting on 57 by stumps on the second day.

India managed a slim lead of 45 runs on the third morning, and by close, Pakistan had reached 212 for five to lead by 167 runs. The match was now evenly balanced.

It took some particularly inept batting by the Pakistanis on the fourth morning to swing it back in India's favour. The last five Pakistani wickets fell in a heap and India were left with the task of scoring 203 to go one-up in the series.

They survived some nervy moments and a torrid spell by Akhtar who claimed all the four Indian wickets to fall. But it was all over by the fifth morning and India were home and dry by six wickets.

It was a special moment when Kumble collected the Man of the Match award for his seven wickets.

The next two Test matches, both drawn, were a personal triumph for Sourav Ganguly, who was in the best form of his life in the autumn of his career.

The second Test at Kolkata was particularly sweet for him. In eleven years of playing in front of his adoring Eden Gardens fans he had just one half-century to his credit. This time he brought the house down with his

innings of 102. With opener Wasim Jaffer top-scoring with 202 and Laxman unbeaten on 112, India's total of 616 for five declared gave them the upper hand.

Pakistan replied with 456 to avoid the follow-on. Kumble then declared the second innings at 184 for four on the fifth morning. Pakistan, chasing an improbable 345, were struggling at 78 for four before they were rescued by stand-in skipper (Malik was injured) Younis Khan with 107 not out.

Dhoni would have been pleased with his two knocks of 50 not out, and 37, as he had to play the Test with his sore ankle strapped up throughout. But the injury ruled him out of the third and final Test at Bangalore, and Dinesh Karthik, who had played in the first two Tests as an opening batsman, took over the big gloves.

Ganguly cornered the glory at Bangalore with his maiden Test double century (and 91 in the second innings), but it was fellow left-hander Yuvraj Singh who had the pundits purring with delight with his sublime 169 on the opening day.

Ironically, the big debate before the series was whether Ganguly was blocking Yuvraj's place in the playing XI. And Yuvraj would not have played at all if not for injuries to both Dhoni and Tendulkar which forced them to miss the match.

The two southpaws got together on the opening day when the Pakistan bowling attack was right on top, reducing India to 61 for four. When Yuvraj fell just before stumps, the pair had added 300 runs in a glorious exhibition of counter-attacking batsmanship.

The overnight total of 365 for five progressed to 626 all out the next day, Ganguly finishing on 239 (the highest Test score by an Indian left-hander) and another leftie, Irfan Pathan, helping himself to his maiden Test century.

Pakistan replied strongly with 537 to trail by 89 runs, and by the penultimate day, a draw looked to be on the cards.

The last day proved pretty dramatic, though, and at the end of it, Pakistan were struggling to survive, having lost seven wickets after being set 347 to win.

Bad light saved the visitors as the Bangalore fans were treated to the rare sight of their hometown hero and captain Kumble picking up five wickets bowling medium pace, such was the condition of the pitch. This

was how Kumble had started his first-class career some 20 years back, before switching to leg spin.

Kumble perhaps timed the declaration a wee bit too late on the final day. Closing the second innings at 284 for six meant the Indian bowlers had just 48 overs in which to clinch a 2-0 series victory. Finally, it was bad light that brought about a premature close with 11 overs still in hand, saving Pakistan much embarrassment.

Still, it was the first time since 1979-80 that India had beaten Pakistan in a Test series on home soil. Kumble could well be satisfied with both the team's performance, and his own, in his first series as captain, as the team readied to fly to Australia for the toughest of all tours.

In his own unobtrusive manner, Karthik had booked his berth for the tour with 24 and 52 in Bangalore while also neatly keeping wickets in Dhoni's absence. It meant the Indian touring team had the luxury of two frontline wicket-keeper/batsmen in their ranks, something few international teams could boast of.

Kumble's task would be formidable and having toured Australia on two previous occasions, he was well aware of the challenge.

The tour marked the 60th anniversary of India–Australia cricket relations. This was the ninth tour since India first visited Australia back in 1947-48, with India having failed to claim a single series rubber. Three were drawn, including the previous one four years earlier under Ganguly's captaincy.

Ever since India had stunned Steve Waugh's formidable team at home in 2001, India–Australia contests had acquired a highly competitive edge. Indeed, India were the only country that seriously challenged Australia's Test hegemony going back over ten years.

Waugh had memorably referred to tours to India as Australian cricket's 'final frontier' and it was no different for Kumble in Australia, the only Test nation apart from South Africa, where India had yet to win a Test series.

There was thus tremendous anticipation across the cricket world when India landed in Australia for four Test matches, followed by the Commonwealth Bank ODI tri-series also involving Sri Lanka, plus one T-20.

Unfortunately for the tourists, they paid the price for their lack of preparation by getting trounced by 337 runs in the opening Test at

Melbourne.

The Indian Board had agreed to just one four-day warm-up match prior to the Test series and due to heavy rain, only 48 overs could be bowled in that game against Victoria.

The woeful lack of practice was cruelly shown up by the ruthless Australians. They romped home with a day to spare to record their 15th straight Test victory, one behind equalling their own world record set at Mumbai in 2001. That run of 16 had been halted by India, with historic wins first at Kolkata, and then at Chennai.

Captain Ricky Ponting was hell-bent on showing he was capable of carrying on his predecessor Waugh's great legacy. The second Test at Sydney was thus assuming Holy Grail proportions as the Aussies were under tremendous pressure from their fans and the media to match the world record.

Sadly, Sydney turned out to be one of the bitterest and most controversial Test matches of all time. And the fall-out almost brought world cricket to its knees. At the end of all the heat and dust, Australia pulled off a miraculous victory with just nine minutes remaining when part-time spin bowler Michael Clarke grabbed the last three Indian wickets from five balls just when a draw looked inevitable.

But India justifiably felt they had been robbed by shockingly poor umpiring decisions by Mark Benson and their old nemesis, Steve Bucknor. On the opening day, Andrew Symonds gained a reprieve from Bucknor when on 30, when he was given not out after a confident appeal for caught behind. His unbeaten 162 turned things around for Australia who had earlier been struggling, and at the end of the day's play Symonds rubbed it in by admitting he had got an edge to Ishant Sharma's delivery.

That set the tone for the rest of the match. Things got out of hand on the third day, when Harbhajan Singh was frustrating Australia's bowlers in a century stand with Tendulkar. Symonds made a jibe at Harbhajan who then, according to the Australian fielders, responded with a racist slur. Ponting filed a complaint with match referee Mike Procter, who decided to sort out the matter at the end of the Test.

All this obscured some magnificent batting from both sides with India gaining the edge thanks to a brilliant unbeaten 154 by Tendulkar and 109 from Laxman, giving them a first innings lead of 69 runs.

Few teams have managed to lose after scoring 500-plus in the first innings, but the Indians did just that. On the stormy final day, both Dravid and Ganguly fell under controversial circumstances as tempers rose to fever-pitch and the two umpires completely lost control of the proceedings.

Ponting and his men celebrated with ill-concealed glee at the end of the match, and when Kumble told the media, 'Only one team was playing in the spirit of the game', he struck a raw nerve.

With an acute sense of cricket history, Kumble had echoed the words of Australian captain Bill Woodfull during the bitter 'Bodyline' series of 1932-33 when all of Australia felt outraged by the behaviour and tactics of Douglas Jardine's Englishmen.

The hearing against Harbhajan stretched till 3 a.m., with the Indian spinner supported by Tendulkar and opposed by Symonds and the Australian fielders who were in closest proximity when the alleged comments had been uttered on the third day.

Procter's verdict that Harbhajan was indeed guilty of a racial slur and would be banned for three Test matches broke open the floodgates of outrage back in India. The BCCI came under pressure from their own players who, it appeared, were ready to call off the tour till it was agreed an appeals hearing would be called at the end of the series and Harbhajan would be free to play till that hearing. It was also agreed that Bucknor would be removed from standing in the third Test at Perth and replaced by New Zealand's Billy Bowden. Benson, in any case, was not slated to stand in the last two Test matches.

Things cooled down somewhat by the time the teams moved to Perth for the third Test. Australia could not lose the series now that they led 2-0 and they thus retained their grip on the Border-Gavaskar Trophy. But Ponting was keen to re-write the world record by extending it to 17 straight wins and make it all his own, rather than sharing it with his predecessor. And Perth appeared the perfect venue for achieving just that.

Asian teams had lost all nine previous Test matches at Perth and the Aussies looked upon the venue as their personal fortress as they had not been beaten there since February 1997. At one time in the '70s, it was considered the fastest track in the world and even though it had slowed down since then, it was still expected to suit the home bowling attack.

Certainly, the buildup in the Australian media made it look like another victory was a *fait accompli*.

What transpired proved all the experts wrong. The victory, by 72 runs, entered the annals of Indian cricket folklore as one of the greatest of all time.

The last time Australia had been beaten in a home Test match was back in December 2003, and India were the winners then as well. It meant that for the second time in seven years it was India who halted the Aussie winning streak at 16.

Bowlers on both sides dominated, with Dravid's first innings, 93, the highest score of the match. But it was India's swing bowlers—plus the scorching pace of new find Ishant Sharma— that did the trick rather than Australia's fearsome fast bowlers.

Dhoni was kept busy behind the stumps with six catches and a stumping, his best show thus far in a Test match. He also chipped in with a useful 38 in the second innings, just when runs were hard to come by, with the Indians struggling at 160 for six.

The match was over in four days and the delighted Indians headed to Adelaide for the fourth and final Test with their pride restored.

The match ended in a tame draw, with both sides scoring 500-plus in the first innings and five batsmen recording centuries.

Though Australia finished 2-1 winners, the Sydney Test could have gone either way. Kumble led the Indians with skill and dignity and returned home with his head held high after yet another classic series between the two sides.

Dhoni failed to contribute much with the bat and his highest score in eight innings was 38, at Perth. There would be a stern test ahead for him with the limited-overs matches looming large.

Harbhajan's exoneration on a technicality, at the hands of New Zealand High Court judge John Hansen, allowed him to take part in the rest of the tour. The whole thing, though, left a bitter taste in the mouth, and the rest of the tour was played under a cloud of controversy.

What was proved conclusively at the end of the sorry affair was that India now ruled the cricket world thanks to its immense money-power. And with the IPL round the corner, that clout would only increase. Australia's cricket fraternity was left muttering under its breath, but there was little they could do about it.

It was time to get back to on-field action, and the two sides headed to Melbourne for the high-voltage T-20 clash.

Having been beaten twice over the last four months in this shortest version of the game, the Aussies were thirsting for revenge at the MCG ground. The result was an embarrassing rout for the world champions who capitulated to a crushing defeat by nine wickets after being sent packing for a miserable 74 all out.

Harbhajan was enemy number one in the eyes of the Australian public and the hostile reception he got from the massive crowd set the tone for the ODI series that followed.

India had competed in five previous tri-series on tours of Australia, reached the best-of-three finals three times, but on each occasion they failed to win a single match against the hosts.

This time they would be up against formidable opposition as World Cup-losing finalists Sri Lanka were the third side in the competition, staged for the 29th and final time in Australia.

The decision to drop Ganguly, Laxman and Dravid (who in any case suffered a broken finger at Adelaide) from the squad created the predictable storm back home. Indications were Dhoni was keen to retain a youthful side after the success at the World T-20 and he had his way with the selectors. It was a bold gamble— that ultimately paid off and vindicated the captain's decision.

Tendulkar was the only senior statesman left in the team and he certainly proved his worth.

Both the first and second matches at Brisbane against Australia and Sri Lanka were declared 'no-result' due to the weather. In the first, the Indian batting failed but the bowling looked impressive in a short spell, and in the second, the batsmen came into their own but rain prevented the bowlers from having a go at Lanka's batting.

It was obvious by now that the pressure of captaincy was not going to be a factor in Dhoni's batting as had been the case with so many Indian captains in the past. In the two opening games, first against a rampaging Australian attack, the captain was second top-scorer with 37, and then, against Lanka, he struck an impressive 88 not out, again second top-scorer after Gautam Gambhir's 102 not out. It was also his highest score as captain till then.

Coming together at a shaky 83 for four, Gambhir and Dhoni added 184 runs for the unbroken fifth wicket. It was a pity that rain prevented what would have been a fascinating run-chase.

Australia looked to be peaking after crushing Lanka by 128 runs. But they were stunned by the pace bowling of Ishant Sharma at Melbourne in the next game, and suffered a rare reverse at one of their strongholds.

Ishant picked up four wickets, and was well supported by Sreesanth with three, as the home side crumbled to 159 all out in 43.1 overs.

Dhoni marshalled his bowling resources brilliantly, always keeping on the pressure, and he was well rewarded with an outstanding Indian performance in the field. He also had five dismissals (four catches and a stumping) and this was the third occasion on which he had collected five or more in his short career. Only Nayan Mongia among Indian wicket-keepers could match this feat.

The target of 160 was hardly challenging. But the batsmen made heavy weather of it, losing half their wickets with 102 on the board.

If Ishant had been so impressive with the ball, his surname-sake Rohit Sharma showed admirable maturity in compiling an unbeaten 39. The young guns in the team were already beginning to justify their captain's faith in them.

Rohit had his captain at the other end to guide him, and though Dhoni's contribution was only 17 not out from 54 balls, it was crucial under the circumstances.

The pair took India home in 45.5 overs to give them their first win of the tri-series. Dhoni's strike rate (31.48) was the lowest of his career, but with the target so small, all that mattered were a cool head and wickets in hand.

In the topsy-turvy way of things in a tri-series, India then lost their next two matches and suddenly found themselves in a tricky situation.

The eighth match of the series at Adelaide would be crucial for both India and Lanka, with Australia well-placed to make the finals. It went down to the wire and in the end it was India who held their nerve to win by two wickets with just five deliveries to spare.

Yuvraj had been going through a miserable spell on the tour, without a single 50 either in the Test or ODI series, and Dhoni was coming under pressure to drop him. But he persisted and the left-hander finally came good with a match-winning 76.

Chasing Lanka's 238 for six, the India innings began disastrously, slumped to 99 for four, partially recovered thanks to a stand worth 59 between Yuvraj and Dhoni, then 58 between Dhoni and Irfan, stumbled again towards the end as three wickets fell for 20 runs, and finally made it to the finish line thanks to a remarkable piece of batting by their captain.

It was heart-stopping stuff but, right through, Dhoni was unflappable. His 50 not out did not contain a single four or six, only the fifth such instance in an innings of 50 and above by an Indian batsman. And yet his strike rate of 73.52 showed how hard he ran between the wickets, something quite unusual for an Indian batsman.

It was his 22nd ODI score of 50-plus and one of the most vital, and it was fitting that he hit the winning runs in the final over.

The home side won both their next two matches against Lanka and India to ensure their place in the finals. And so it came down to the wire with the winner of the final league game between India and Lanka at Hobart going through to play Australia.

Medium-pacer Praveen Kumar had gone wicket-less against the Lankans at Adelaide and had been replaced by Sreesanth in the next match against Australia at Sydney, which India lost by 18 runs.

But despite Sreesanth picking up two wickets at Sydney, Dhoni decided to replace him with Munaf Patel and bring in Praveen in place of Sehwag for the crunch game in order to field a five-bowler attack.

It proved another master-stroke by the captain. Praveen broke the back of the Lankan batting with four for 31 to pick up the Man of the Match award. India coasted home by seven wickets and thus cemented their place in the finals.

Despite scoring 63 in that final league match, Tendulkar's lack of runs was a cause for concern. 'People have been talking about Sachin for all the years I've played. But one should be careful when one writes about him. He has scored 16,000 runs; I haven't even played 16,000 balls,' Dhoni told the press at the end of the Adelaide match. And once again, he was spot-on.

It had been six years since India had won a final outright in a tournament consisting of three or more teams. Now they did it in grand style. And the Aussies were left stunned by the supreme confidence and bold aggression of the Indians, characteristics they felt they had exclusive rights to.

It was Tendulkar's masterly 117 not out that guided India home by six wickets with 25 balls to spare in the first final at Sydney.

But once again Dhoni made surprise bowling choices that clicked. Praveen was called upon to open the bowling instead of Ishant, and he made the early breakthroughs by cheaply dismissing both Gilchrist and Ponting.

Dhoni also brought young leg-spinner Piyush Chawla into the playing XI for the first time in the series and he responded with a neat spell of bowling.

Everything the Indian captain touched was seemingly turning to gold and the streak continued to the second final at Brisbane.

But it went right down to the last over and if Australia had sneaked through, they would have been favoured to win the third and deciding match.

Instead, India stunned the world champs by taking the series 2-0, winning at Brisbane by nine runs, as Dhoni and the team held firm just when the match looked like swinging away from their grasp.

Once again, Tendulkar was the batting hero with 91. But Praveen won the Man of the Match award for the second time in the last three matches as he picked up four wickets.

After all the toil, bitterness and controversy of a long, hard tour, the Indians had emerged triumphant. Australia were left to lick their wounds. They hardly knew what hit them.

It was the second major title for Dhoni and India in the last seven months following the World T-20 crown. But Dhoni was quick to say after the match: 'This is a greater victory.'

He also downplayed his own contributions, although he had been magnificent both tactically and with bat and gloves. 'The role of the captain was not the only one. The captain is one guy, who gathers the pressure and then channels it to the individual player, and then it depends on how that individual reacts,' he said.

Dhoni had gambled on youth in picking the squad and was ready to face the flak if the policy failed. Now he was confident enough to say: 'Even if we had lost this tournament, we should have stuck with the young boys. This will be the team's core.'

No one was in a position to argue with the captain. Every hunch of his had proved right, as it had in South Africa back in September. Eight of

the team in the finals had not played an ODI in Australia before. Dhoni summed things up during the trophy presentation when he asked: '*Sabse chota kaun hai* (Who's the youngest)?'

The sight of the little 19-year-old Piyush Chawla holding aloft the CB Trophy was deeply symbolic of India's youthful campaign, epitomised by the captain himself and his faith in his charged-up rookies.

Later, Dhoni was questioned as to why his reaction was so low-key at the moment of victory even as his team-mates were going ballistic with joy, clambering all over him. It was almost as if he was in a trance.

As he explained to *Tehelka* magazine (22 March 2008), it was his way of responding to the hostility of the Australian team and media. 'A victory is like winning a million verbal duels. I knew we would win, hence I refrained from reacting. I knew we would give it back at an appropriate time.'

There had been a significant shift in his batting style since being appointed captain. Till December 2006, he had played 59 ODIs with an average of 43.37 and an amazing strike rate of 98.3.

Now, in 15 matches in charge till the end of the CB series, his average had gone up to an excellent 51.75, but the strike rate dropped to 79.92. It was still impressive but it also showed how the responsibility of captaincy had made him slow down. The percentage of runs from boundaries had also dipped by nearly 20 per cent. In the end, though, what was most significant was the success rate of the team in which his mature batting had played such an important role.

The only flaw for Dhoni in the series came during the 10th league match, the final preliminary game against Australia at Sydney which India lost by 18 runs. He also took his 100th ODI catch during the match but was caught out on a technicality. An eagle-eyed TV expert, former Australian wicket-keeper Ian Healy, spotted that Dhoni's specially manufactured gloves had extra webbing between the thumb and forefinger, and reported it to match referee Jeff Crowe.

The gloves were deemed 'illegal' as according to the rules, 'The wicket-keeper's gloves shall have no webbing between the fingers except joining index finger and thumb, where webbing may be inserted as a means of support.' Dhoni was let off with a warning and told to change the gloves immediately, but the controversy blew over when Australian wicket-keeper Adam Gilchrist sprang to his defence.

Dhoni has since switched to custom-made gloves with a green camouflage design, reflecting his passion for all things connected with the military.

Back home, the celebrations were on. The plans for another open-bus tour were scrapped, as the Board rightly sensed the players were too exhausted and needed to get home as soon as possible.

Instead, a low-key function was organised at Delhi's Feroze Shah Kotla ground. This time the players were rewarded with a purse of Rs 10 crore from the BCCI.

Dhoni sat stoically throughout the felicitation. Part of the reason may have been fatigue. But he also hinted in interviews that he was upset at the criticism he had received when choosing the team. There was a sense of grim satisfaction about him.



CHAPTER TEN

Dhoni is Priceless'

EVEN AS THE Indian team were fighting to stay alive in the Commonwealth Bank ODI tri-series in Australia, dramatic events were unfolding in a five-star hotel in Mumbai that would change the face of cricket forever.

For the first time, cricketers were put on the auction block and were being bought and sold like cattle (in the words of Adam Gilchrist).

The Indian Premier League (IPL) had caught the attention of the sporting world with its player auction on 20 February 2008. The world's cricketers were agog, logging onto the internet to see how much they were worth as the eight franchise teams bid for their services.

Some of the figures were mind-boggling, some baffling. Most of the players were delighted, some, like Ricky Ponting, disgruntled at their low price.

What took the breath away was the figure the Chennai Super Kings (CSK) forked out to buy up M.S. Dhoni as their captain— \$1.5 million (approximately Rs 6 crore). In an astonishingly short span of time, Dhoni had risen to the top as the most highly-priced cricketer in the world.

Close behind Dhoni was Australia's star all-rounder Andrew Symonds, who was bought by the Deccan Chargers of Hyderabad for \$1.35 million.

Ponting, on the other hand, went to the Kolkata Knight Riders for a mere \$200,000. No wonder the Australian captain was left scratching his head in dismay.

The eight franchise teams had been bought for sums ranging from \$67 million for the Rajasthan Royals, to Mukesh Ambani's Mumbai Indians at \$111.9 million, and Vijay Mallya's Bangalore Royal Challengers at \$111.6 million.

The glamour element at the auction was provided by Shah Rukh Khan, part-owner of the Kolkata Knight Riders, and Preity Zinta of the Kings XI Punjab.

Just round the corner from the hotel at the Wankhede Stadium, the final of the premier national zonal tournament, the Duleep Trophy, was being contested between North and West Zone. It was watched by just a handful of spectators and even fewer reporters, while journalists from all over the cricket world had flown into Mumbai to witness the historic auction.

'Dhoni is priceless,' is what CSK's consultant V.B. Chandra-sekhar told Ajay S. Shankar of *cricinfo*. 'He can create ripples with his game and we can get our team to play around him.'

The bidding for Dhoni had been fast and furious, starting from the base price of \$400,000. Reliance (the Mumbai franchise-owners) raised the stakes to \$1.3 million. But once Chandrasekhar upped that to the final figure, CSK had finally got their man. Chandrasekhar, a former International, had been a member of the national selection panel that had chosen Dhoni for the first time in 2004. 'I have seen him transform from just someone from Jharkhand to what he is today,' Chandrasekhar said, with justifiable pride and elation at their prize catch.

While some of the franchises were left to lick their wounds, one of Delhi's representatives, another former selector and cricketer, T.A. Sekhar, was more candid in speaking to *cricinfo*: 'All of us would have wanted Dhoni to play for our teams, why not? Every football team would love to have somebody like David Beckham in their side. Similarly, everybody would be proud to have Dhoni with them.'

One financial newspaper estimated that Dhoni would be paid more per hour during the IPL—Rs 56,818 at a rough estimate— than Mukesh Ambani, one of India's richest persons!

Even as the euphoria was sweeping all around him, Mahi got some wise counsel from his parents, who warned him not to get distracted by all the money and to keep his feet firmly planted on the ground.

His own response was nonchalant. He told a news channel he could buy 1,000 motorbikes with the IPL riches, but that he would always put country above club as he had already earned enough from cricket for himself and his family.

The inaugural IPL season was to be launched on 18 April. But before that, Graeme Smith's South Africans were back in India to play three Test matches. Not that anyone appeared to care too much. All concerned—the players on both sides, fans and the media—were too distracted by the hype around the IPL, and the Test series passed off almost unnoticed.

It is ironical that just a year earlier, the BCCI had laid down stringent conditions for players endorsing products, soon after the World Cup debacle. Now, on the eve of the Test matches, the same Board was ordering the players to appear all over the country for promotional launches for their franchise teams. The signals were already pretty clear: who cared about Test cricket?

The first Test, on a flat Chepauk track at Chennai, ended in a high-scoring draw with Virender's Sehwag's 319 the highlight of the match. It made him the only batsman after Don Bradman and Brian Lara to record two innings of 300-plus in Test cricket. But Sehwag and the other Indian batsmen were undone when they were caught on a lively wicket at Ahmedabad and routed in under three days.

In a matter of just 20 overs—the shortest innings in the history of subcontinental Test cricket—the Indians were swept aside for 76, with fast bowler Dale Steyn grabbing five wickets.

Only Dhoni (14) and Irfan Pathan (21) could reach double figures, and from there on, India were fighting a losing cause.

South Africa romped home by an innings and 90 runs despite an improved Indian batting performance in the second innings. But 328 all out (Ganguly 87, Dhoni 52) was just not enough.

It was ironical that, with the Twenty20 circus round the corner, the Indian batting lasted for just 20 overs in the first innings. Even in the absence of an injured Tendulkar, it was a shocking display.

It was new coach Gary Kirsten's first assignment in charge and his South African nationality made things uncomfortable for him, by his own

admission. A sense of desperation had crept into the Indian camp. They were determined to pull out all the stops to win the third Test at Kanpur, to at least square a series they were expected to win. But the home side received a big setback when Kumble was declared unfit due to a groin injury and pulled out of the Test. It meant Dhoni became the first Indian wicket-keeper to lead the country in a Test match and he did a commendable job of it.

This Test, too, ended early on the third day. But this time it was India who turned the tables to win by eight wickets and square the series 1-1. After gaining a slender first innings lead, thanks to a masterly 87 by Ganguly, the Indian bowlers did their job by dismissing South Africa for 121 in the second innings to set up the victory.

Dhoni came in for much praise for the way he handled his bowlers. He made a number of smart changes which paid off, and in the second innings surprised the opponents by asking off-spinner Harbhajan Singh to open the bowling with Ishant Sharma. He also kept wickets pretty competently—not easy on this track, with the spinners getting vicious turn and the ball keeping low when the fast bowlers came on.

So the Test series was done and dusted, and now it was time for the event the cricket world had been looking forward to with great anticipation—the Indian Premier League.

The big question was: would Indian fans take to cheering domestic club sides that included foreigners, when it had been the national side all these years that had a monopoly over their loyalties?

Each team would play the other seven sides twice, both home and away, before the semifinals and final to be played in Mumbai.

There was tremendous pressure on Dhoni in particular. Would he live up to his star billing and justify the massive price-tag?

The jamboree got off to a spectacular start with world records in the opening game. New Zealand's dashing wicket-keeper/ batsman Brendon McCullum stunned one and all with an amazing innings of 158 not out for the Kolkata Knight Riders against the Bangalore Royal Challengers on the latter's home ground.

McCullum set Twenty20 world records for the highest individual score, and most sixes (13—since overtaken) and the IPL organisers had got just the start they had wished for.

Bangalore were crushed and their campaign went downhill all the way from there.

The next day, CSK began their campaign with a bang by beating Kings XI Punjab by 33 runs at Mohali. Michael Hussey took over from McCullum with a barnstorming 116 not out for the winners, and though Dhoni failed with the bat, he once again caught the eye with his tactics.

Manpreet Gony and Palani Amarnath, virtual unknowns on the domestic circuit, shouldered most of the bowling burden and in a case of *déjà vu*, it was once again Joginder Sharma who was given the task of bowling the final over. It all nicely fell into place.

It was much tighter in their next game, their first at home in the M.A. Chidambaram stadium in Chennai against one of the glamour teams, Mumbai Indians.

With Mumbai needing 19 runs from the final over, it was once again the ice-cool Joginder who kept things under control and took CSK home by six runs.

A crushing nine-wicket win against Kolkata followed at home, and then a closer verdict against Bangalore by 13 runs with Dhoni earning his first Man of the Match award with 65 not out from 30 balls. The captain's form was picking up and CSK were now on a roll with four wins on the trot.

It was the Delhi Daredevils led by Virender Sehwag who brought that streak to a grinding halt by beating them at Chennai by eight wickets. CSK were now without their Aussie stars Matthew Hayden, Michael Hussey, and Kiwi Jacob Oram, all of whom had left for national duty, their absence having an immediate impact on their batting. They were replaced by Stephen Fleming, S. Vidyut and Albie Morkel.

Most of the other franchises were equally hard hit by the departure of many of their foreign stars, and that led to a level playing field which would make the rest of the tournament much tighter.

After a slow start, it was the Rajasthan Royals led by an inspired Shane Warne who were proving to be the surprise package of the tournament and sure enough, they handed Dhoni's boys another eight-wicket pasting in Jaipur.

By the time CSK were beaten by seven wickets by the Deccan Chargers at home, the wheels were beginning to fall off the campaign. The Chargers were at the bottom of the points table and CSK's defeat made it

three losses in a row. It meant they had slid from first to fourth in the current points standing.

The batting, which was their strength, was looking dangerously thin at the top, with totals of 169, 110 and 144 in the last three defeats. With key players like Fleming, Makhaya Ntini and Parthiv Patel failing to deliver, Dhoni's options were severely limited.

It took a nerve-tingling win off the final ball of the match to get the campaign back on the rails.

Dhoni's winning streak with the toss continued but for the first time, he asked the opposition—Delhi Daredevils—to bat first.

It paid off. CSK's bowlers pulled things back after the Delhi top order threatened a huge total. Dhoni played his part with a run-a-ball 33 as CSK chased down Delhi's 187 for five to win by four wickets.

It took a couple of tactical blunders by Sehwag to hand the match to CSK, and in the captaincy contest, it was Dhoni who outdid his more experienced counterpart.

Dhoni led from the front once again with a power-packed 60 not out in the return game against Punjab. The sixes were now raining from his bat. But it was former Test fast bowler L. Balaji who took the honours with five wickets, including a hat-trick, to bowl CSK to victory by 18 runs. Once again, CSK were looking like serious contenders for one of the coveted semifinal spots.

From then on it was a roller-coaster ride for CSK. The tournament was reaching the business end with teams desperately jostling to make it to the last four.

With Sri Lankan opener Sanath Jayasuriya racing to the fastest century of the tournament, and Tendulkar back in action after his injury, Mumbai Indians dealt Dhoni his biggest defeat by nine wickets with 37 balls to spare.

They would go on to lose two of their next three games, and now it came down to a do-or-die situation in the final match against Deccan Chargers at Hyderabad. Victory would see CSK through, defeat would allow Mumbai to seal a semifinal berth.

The Chargers had turned out to be the biggest flop of the show despite a host of superstars in their ranks. They had recorded just two wins in the tournament and one of those was against CSK in Chennai. Though CSK were in control for most of the match, it still went down to the final

over. Suresh Raina, in sublime form, sealed it with a six with four balls to spare, after Dhoni's 37 from 25 balls had boosted the innings.

So, after 54 matches and six weeks of battling it out, the semifinal line-up was finally complete: Rajasthan Royals v. Delhi Daredevils, and Chennai Super Kings v. Kings XI Punjab.

With 16 points from eight wins and six defeats, CSK were third in the league points table, behind toppers Rajasthan Royals and Punjab, and one point ahead of Delhi. Crucially though, CSK had beaten Punjab in both league matches and this gave them an added boost going into the second semifinal.

In the first, Rajasthan crushed Delhi by 105 runs and the second turned out to be just as one-sided; Punjab were beaten by nine wickets with a whopping 31 deliveries to spare.

Punjab struggled to 112 for eight and it was a no-contest from there as CSK only lost the wicket of S. Vidyut before romping home.

Rajasthan had lost just three of their 14 league matches and beaten CSK in both their earlier matches. But they would be without star opener and South African captain Graeme Smith for the final, due to a hamstringing injury.

After the one-sided semifinals, everyone connected to the IPL was hoping for a final befitting a hugely popular event. And that is what they got.

It was the best possible advertisement for the IPL and the Twenty20 game as Rajasthan scampered home off the very last ball of the match to win by three wickets and claim the inaugural crown. Put in to bat after Warne won the toss, CSK put up a fighting total of 163 for five with Raina (43) top-scoring again, and Dhoni blasting 29 not out from 17 balls towards the end.

Irfan's elder half-brother Yusuf Pathan picked up three wickets with his off-spinners and he would do the star turn with the bat as well, top-scoring with 56 to claim the Man of the Match award.

Eight runs were needed off the last over, with Warne and Pakistan's Sohail Tanvir at the crease. But Joginder was not around to bowl at the death as he had been dropped half-way through the tournament. It was left to Balaji to bowl and with the scores level, Tanvir hit the winning run from the final delivery.

Rajasthan had been the best side of the tournament despite having the smallest budget, and were fitting winners at the end. But Dhoni's boys had run them pretty close.

Even as Warne was mobbed by his jubilant teammates, Dhoni gathered his side around on the field in a huddle. He told them no one was to be blamed for the loss and that he was proud of the way they were able to keep up their intensity till the very last ball of the final.

He echoed that sentiment in the post-final press conference: 'I don't want to pinpoint any particular player (for the defeat). I agree that we made a few mistakes in the field but the main problem was that we had just five bowlers and even if any one of them had a bad day, we had to persist with him.'

The young master of the tight finish had finally been outdone by Shane Warne, the wily old fox.

Though Warne won most of the plaudits for the manner in which he marshalled his young team, Dhoni was not far behind in garnering praise. Gony, for one, who rose from obscurity to the Indian ODI team within a month of finishing as one of the top wicket-takers in the IPL, gave Dhoni much of the credit for inspiring him.

Dhoni was second top-scorer for the team with 414 runs at 41.40, with two half-centuries and a strike rate of 133.54, behind only Raina (421 runs). More than half his runs came from boundaries (242—38 fours and 15 sixes). In the CSK team only Raina was just ahead of him in runs scored from boundaries (248).

It was calculated that Dhoni earned a whopping \$3623.19 per run, making him the priciest in this category as well. But of course it was much more than rupees per run. His value to the franchise went far beyond that, including the number of sponsors CSK drew in thanks to the USP that is 'Brand Dhoni' today.

As for the IPL itself, its massive commercial success in its very first year went far beyond even the wildest dreams of Modi and Co.—the 'Slapgate' controversy notwithstanding. TV ratings went through the roof, and it looked like the Indian public was as hooked on Twenty20 as it had been with traditional ODIs (50/50) after India won the Prudential World Cup in 1983.

There were far-reaching implications, however, for the world of cricket, both positive and negative, arising from the mega-success of the

IPL. The effect of these would be seen in the months and years to come.



CHAPTER ELEVEN

Taking a Break

WISDEN CRICKETERS' ALMANACK, published without a break since 1864 and the world's longest running sports annual, announced in their 2008 edition that M.S. Dhoni was one of their '*Wisden* Forty' for the best cricketers in 2007.

Lauding his captaincy skills in bringing India victory in the World Twenty20, it wrote: 'It was the year in which the jock became the head boy, with outstanding results.'

The short profile noted: 'While his glove-work relied as much on natural athleticism as technique, his batting showed signs of newfound maturity, though he still hit more sixes in Tests than anyone.'

It was indeed an outstanding year, capped with the captaincy of the T20 and ODI teams.

In eight Test matches in 2007 he scored 468 runs, averaging 52 as well as taking 14 catches and three stumpings. In 37 ODIs he had 1,103 runs at 44.21 with 31 catches and 18 stumpings while in eight T20 Internationals, the figures read 163 runs at 32.60 with one catch.

There was not much breathing space following the end of the first season of the Indian Premier League on June 1. After nearly 50 days of 20/20 cricket, it was back to 50-overs cricket for Dhoni and his boys.

Within a week of the IPL final, Dhoni found himself in Dhaka playing in a rather pointless tournament. The Kitply Cup involving India, Pakistan and hosts Bangladesh served little purpose and only bolstered the growing contention that the 20/20 version would effectively kill off 50-overs cricket.

The weather was unbearably hot and humid and there was little motivation for the teams. The crowds too stayed away.

Despite Bangladesh's shock win over India in the World Cup the year before, there was little doubt that India and Pakistan would contest the final.

Bangladesh were brushed aside by both India and Pakistan in the preliminary games. But there was a surprise in store when India took on Pakistan in their pre-final encounter.

India won by a massive 140 runs, their biggest margin of victory in ODIs against Pakistan (in terms of runs) and the knives were out for the Pakistan team. India piled up 330 for eight and the bowlers then did their job by sending Pakistan tumbling to 190 all out.

A mail from the Pakistan Cricket Board chairman to the team management warning of severe action against the team and its coach was leaked to the media and it was a pumped-up Pakistan squad that took on India in the final.

The turnaround was amazing from just four days earlier.

Centuries by Salman Butt and Younis Khan propelled Pakistan to an imposing 315 for three and it was an uphill task for the Indians from thereon.

Though seven of the top eight batsmen reached double figures, only that old reliable pair of Yuvraj Singh and his captain could convert good starts into fifties. But it was not enough.

Dhoni's top score of 64 came at better than a run a ball. But once Irfan Pathan had gone for 28 after adding 60 runs for the seventh wicket—the highest of the innings—Dhoni became increasingly desperate as he ran out of partners. Valiantly he tried to win the match off his own bat as wickets and overs began to run out.

Dhoni had come in at number seven after Suresh Raina in order to be there for the late charge. But try as he might, he could not pull it off without the assistance of a specialist batsman at the other end.

Shahid Afridi bowled the penultimate over with India nine down and needing 32 runs to win. Dhoni hit the first ball for six to revive the team's hopes. But the very next ball he perished in trying to repeat the stroke and Pakistan were home and dry by 25 runs.

After the defeat, Dhoni was his candid self with the media.

'I made a mistake,' he admitted. 'I should have come before Raina. That decision was taken in a positive frame of mind. If Yuvraj had played through, and Raina rotated the strike with singles, we would have been very comfortable at the end of the 40th over. With me and Irfan coming later it would have been an easy target.'

As it turned out, 64 runs from the last six overs and only Dhoni left among the top batsmen proved to be a bridge too far.

The non-stop grind that has become the lot of the Indian professional cricketer now moved onto Karachi for the Asia Cup. India had won the title on four of the previous eight occasions, but the last victory had come back in 1995.

Their campaign began on June 25, an auspicious day for Indian cricket since it was the 25th anniversary of the 1983 Prudential World Cup triumph.

Minnows Hong Kong stood no chance and were brushed aside by 256 runs. It was a virtual no-contest.

Raina recorded his maiden ODI century while Dhoni scored his third for India and fourth overall (he scored one for Asia XI in 2007). Three of his six sixes landed on the roof of Karachi's National Stadium.

The very next day the Indians were back in action taking on arch-rivals Pakistan. It was an exhausting business in the enervating conditions. This time thanks to a whirlwind century by Sehwag, they made light of Pakistan's 299 for four.

The target was reached for the loss of only four wickets and most remarkably, with plenty of deliveries (47) to spare. It was India's quickest chase while facing a target of 300 or more.

Predictably, the big four of Asia made it into the second stage. The batsman-friendly tracks saw to it that all three of India's matches in the 'Super Four' stage were high scoring.

First, with a just day's break, it was the turn of Bangladesh to face the might of India's batting. The Banglas put up a challenging 283 for six which was easily overtaken with seven wickets and 40 deliveries to spare.

The Indians were sloppy in the field and at the end of the match a candid Dhoni gave the reasons. He hit out at the scheduling and explained the team were feeling exhausted after playing for 36 of the previous 84 hours.

‘Back-to-back games make it really tough for the players. I am not really happy with the schedule; two teams are playing back-to-back games, and two teams are not. Under these conditions it is really tough, you are playing cricket throughout the year, and then you play back-to-back matches. You could make out from the start the intensity was not there.’

Pakistan turned the tables on India in the next match. Dhoni top scored with 76 and India’s 308 for seven looked a safe total to defend. The bowlers though looked drained and Pakistan romped home for the loss of only two wickets.

During this innings, Dhoni reached 1,000 runs as captain at the superb average of 62. It only proved that captaincy had brought the best out of him.

It was a case of back-to-back matches again for the Indians. Sri Lanka had booked their place in the final but India had to win this match to edge out Pakistan.

This they did by overhauling Lanka’s 308 for seven losing four wickets in the process. Once again, Dhoni was in good nick with 67 runs which earned him the ‘Man of the Match’ award.

Pakistan’s final Super Four match against Bangladesh was thus rendered inconsequential and while some Pakistan ex-players cast doubts over the Lankan’s intensity, it was hard to question a team that had notched up a total of 300-plus.

The Indian batting looked to be in supreme touch and in all five games had scored 280-plus. It was the third time in the tournament they had successfully chased down 300 or more.

But they were in for a shock in the final. It would be a repeat of the 2004 showdown which Sri Lanka had won. And this time their hero was mystery spinner Ajantha Mendis.

The Lankans had decided not to play Mendis in their final Super Four match against India. Pace bowler Chaminda Vaas too had been rested but the speculation was that they were shielding Mendis from the Indian batsmen who had never faced his bowling.

The ploy worked wonders. The bowler with the mysterious ‘carrom ball’ flummoxed all the Indian batsmen in only his eighth ODI to pick up the amazing figures of 6 for 13 from eight overs.

Sanath Jayasuriya’s century took Lanka to a healthy 273 and though India began well, they were clueless against Mendis who delivered his mystery ball with a flick of the middle finger.

After opener Sehwag’s 60, the team lost their last nine wickets for 97 runs. Dhoni scored 49 of those and gave an object lesson to the rest of how to face up to Mendis, playing him as late as possible. But it was a hopeless task as the innings folded up for 173, a defeat by 100 runs. It was Vaas who accounted for Dhoni’s wicket.

It meant that India had now lost 17 out of 21 finals which they had competed in since 1999 with just two outright titles (England in 2002 and Australia in 2007-08) and two shared titles. It was a massive indictment of the formidable Indian batting which always seemed to collapse in pressure situations.

‘He just outdid us. None of our batsmen read him properly,’ Dhoni admitted of Mendis’ bowling. The gunner in the Sri Lankan army’s artillery regiment had become an overnight sensation.

Even as the team was returning to Mumbai, the rumours were flying thick and fast. Would Dhoni ask for a break and miss the series of three Test matches to be played in Sri Lanka starting from end July?

Despite the loss in the final, Dhoni had been the outstanding batsman of the Asia Cup, finishing on top with an eye-popping average of 109.

One of those most impressed was Wasim Bari, Pakistan’s legendary wicket-keeper of the ‘70s. Bari had briefly led the Pakistan side but he expressed amazement at how Dhoni managed to handle the triple task of ‘keeping, batting and captaincy so successfully. ‘There have been very few successful wicket-keeper/batsmen captains and that’s why I feel he is an exceptional player and is doing a great job.’

In recent years only Zimbabwe’s Andy Flower and England’s Alec Stewart had managed the balancing act that Dhoni was performing with such aplomb.

Now though the strain was beginning to tell. Following his public condemnation of the hectic scheduling in the Asia Cup, the BCCI had hit back by claiming the players had not complained despite back-to-back matches in the IPL.

It was conveniently forgotten that an IPL match consisted of a maximum of 40 overs in a day while in ODIs that stretched to 100 overs.

Shortly after returning from Australia in March 2008 following the CB ODI series, it had been estimated that in a span of 15 months the Indian wicket-keeper had traveled approximately 112,00 kilometres covering eight countries and five continents and taking about 50 flights.

Since the start of 2007, he had played 47 ODIs, 11 Test matches and eight T20 Internationals, the most by any international cricketer in that period. And this was before the IPL where Dhoni's team reached the final, playing a total of 16 T20 matches across the length and breadth of India.

Three Tests at home against South Africa and nine ODIs (three in Dhaka and six in Karachi) were also added to that packed itinerary by July 2008. The number of kilometres traversed would have been close to 125,000 by now.

Sure enough, Dhoni had had enough and requested the selectors to rest him for the Lanka Test series citing fatigue. They did so without fuss and chose two wicket-keeper/batsmen in Dinesh Karthik and Parthiv Patel for the tour.

That immediately opened up a nation-wide debate since an Indian cricketer voluntarily skipping a series was almost unheard of.

Most observers lauded his move as courageous. It is true that he could have cited some niggling injury as an excuse for opting out. Still, some awkward questions were being asked.

The most pertinent of these was whether a cricketer would ever miss the IPL citing fatigue, considering the vast sums of money involved. It was obvious now that the hectic scheduling and pressures of the IPL were taking a toll on the players. Asking for a break from national duty and even premature retirements could become the norm once the IPL expanded its scheduling.

The club vs country dilemma that has been the bane of world football for decades was for the first time casting its shadow on cricket as well.

Writing in *Sportstar* (19 July 2008), former cricketer and respected columnist Peter Roebuck (since deceased)—while appreciating Dhoni's decision—also questioned his priorities and warned against it turning into a trend.

'He must take care not to burn himself out. Otherwise he will be prematurely lost to the game. Dhoni has been playing a lot of cricket but

has he not also been dashing about at the beck and call of sponsors? And at every appearance the player must perform. . .His exhaustion has been partly of his own making. . .The BCCI was right to release its vice-captain but it must be a one-off. Hereafter Test cricket must come first. For his part Dhoni must put things in their proper places.’

On return to Mumbai from the Asia Cup in Karachi on July 7—his 27th birthday—it was announced that Dhoni had signed up with a new sports management firm, leaving behind *Gameplan Sports* who had been the first to snap him up in 2005.

His new agent was Yudhajit Dutta who quit *Gameplan* to form *Mindsapes Maestros*, a new player in the field. It was thought to be the biggest contract for a cricketer and was apparently a lifetime signing.

Despite his stated fatigue, Dhoni stayed back in Mumbai, missing the opportunity to fly back home for his birthday. There were new commercial commitments to fulfill and he spent four days in Mumbai making product appearances and shooting new ads before he finally reached Ranchi.

Now word was out that giant US cola firm *Pepsi* was dropping Tendulkar after an association of over a decade and signing up Dhoni and youngsters Rohit Sharma and Ishant Sharma as part of their ‘youngeistan’ campaign.

With Ganguly and Dravid having been dumped earlier, the signals from the market were clear—the seniors were passé and the young brigade was the in-thing.

By now Dhoni had also surpassed Tendulkar as the cricketer with the most endorsements and the highest price tag. It was estimated that in 2008 he would earn Rs 50 crores from endorsement deals while Tendulkar would be a distant second with around Rs 35 crores. It was hard to keep up with the exact number of deals in Dhoni’s kitty as practically every week his beaming face was popping up on our TV screens with a new ad campaign.

Karthik and Patel squandered their chance to make good in the absence of Dhoni from the Test series in Lanka. Between them in six innings they scored a grand total of just 50 runs and Dhoni’s batting was certainly missed as India were outclassed 2-1.

Ajantha Mendis, who had destroyed India in the Asia Cup final just a month earlier, was again their nemesis with 26 wickets in his maiden Test

series. He now loomed as the biggest threat in the ODI series that followed which saw Dhoni back at the helm.

But India turned the tables and with the captain leading from the front and taking the Man of the Series award, India won a bilateral ODI series in Lanka for the first time. Dhoni top scored with 192 runs at a strike rate of 79.33, was always positive in the field and stuck by his guns in pushing for youngsters in the squad. In the end, India emerged on top and the captain stood vindicated. The rest from the Test series had obviously done him a world of good.

Now it was time to take on Australia at home with Dhoni back in the Test side. The first Test at Bangalore ended in a tame draw but there would be plenty of drama in the next at Mohali.

As at Kanpur earlier in the year against South Africa, Dhoni was told just half an hour before the toss that he would be stand-in skipper in place of the injured Kumble. And he maintained his 100 per cent record as India thrashed the Aussies by 320 runs, their biggest-ever margin of victory by runs in Test matches.

Dhoni did everything right from winning the toss to ringing in the bowling changes and scoring swashbuckling innings of 92 and 68 not out. And to boot, he picked up the Man of the Match award as well. Already critics were calling him the captain with the Midas touch. It seemed only a matter of time before he was handed the Test team reins on a fulltime basis.

That happened somewhat sooner than expected when Kumble picked up another injury in the next Test at New Delhi and announced his retirement on the final afternoon of the drawn Test. It made for emotional scenes as Kumble was chaired round the ground where he had achieved his greatest feat back in 1999.

It meant Dhoni was now the captain of the national side in all three formats—Tests, ODIs and T-20 Internationals, a huge burden for a wicket-keeper and top batsman as well. But he slipped smoothly into the role in the fourth and final Test at Nagpur, scoring 50s in both innings. India regained the Border-Gavaskar Trophy after eight years as they won by 172 runs to take the series 2-0.

There was barely time to celebrate before England arrived for 7 ODIs and two Test matches. But the tragic events in Mumbai that unfolded in

the last week of November would take the nation's attention away from cricket.

The teams were returning to their hotels after India had made it five ODI wins in a row at Cuttack when the shocking events at Mumbai began to unfold. Terrorists had struck and for three days the nation was at a standstill.

Understandably, the English team took the next available flight out of India and the final two ODIs were cancelled. But as the world tried to come to terms with the horror of it all, the Indian government and BCCI were determined that the show must go on.

As a result, England under the captaincy of Kevin Pietersen were convinced it was safe to return for the Tests and all of India reacted with relief and gratitude at their decision.

The first Test scheduled for Mumbai was shifted to Chennai and barely a fortnight after the horror of it all, the nation basked in the glow of a famous victory.

India chased down the target of 387 with plenty to spare and it was fitting indeed that Mumbai's very own emotional Tendulkar struck the winning boundary that took him to 103 with Yuvraj on 85 at the other end. There was barely a dry eye at Chepauk and even the English players and their supporters in their hearts knew how much this win meant for a wounded India.

The second and final Test at Mohali was inevitably an anti-climax as it meandered its way to a draw. But Dhoni had done it again—unbeaten in his first five Tests as captain!

There was an interesting comment from Sourav Ganguly who obviously saw something of his maverick self in the new Test captain: 'We in India make the mistake of thinking that only good boys make good captains.'



CHAPTER TWELVE

Top of the Test World

WITH VICTORIES AT home against Australia and England late in 2008 and the third place in the ICC World Test rankings, coach Gary Kirsten and captain M.S. Dhoni now set their sights in 2009 on moving past Australia and South Africa to reach the summit. The first step would be taken in New Zealand.

But before that, the BCCI had somehow managed to squeeze in yet another ODI series in Sri Lanka which Dhoni and his men handily won 4-1. Lanka after all was now like a second home to them.

New Zealand on the other hand was like hostile territory. India had not won a Test series there since the very first tour under Mansur Ali Khan Pataudi way back in 1968. It was about time that aberration was removed.

The man who had never captained a side at any level before taking charge of the Indian national team was clear when asked what type of captain he saw himself as: 'I am an aggressive captain.'

There was even talk of New Zealand being the mythical 'final frontier' for our cricketers even though the Indian team is yet to win a Test series in either Australia or South Africa. The Kiwis were ranked eighth and India third in the ICC Test rankings at the time of the series and so the visitors started off as favourites.

Losing both the T-20 matches was not the ideal way to start the tour. But outstanding batting by Sachin Tendulkar and Virender Sehwag helped India take the ODI series 3-1 with Dhoni chipping in with two 50s.

On the previous tour in 2003 the Indian batsmen had been routed in hostile conditions and a Test win was long overdue against one of cricket's traditional under-performers.

That task was efficiently and effectively achieved in the first Test at Hamilton which India won by 10 wickets. It had been a long wait of 33 years since India's previous victory under the captaincy of Sunil Gavaskar at Auckland in 1976.

In the 13 Test matches played there since Auckland, India had lost six and drawn seven.

It was a pretty poor record which was now finally being rectified.

Dhoni did not put a foot wrong from the start, when he won the toss and put the opposition in. His seamers rewarded him with early strikes as the home side tottered to 60 for six. Though centuries by captain Daniel Vettori and Jesse Ryder helped them to 279 it was barely enough against the formidable Indian batting lineup.

Tendulkar's sublime 160 was the fulcrum for India's 520 with the first nine batsmen all chipping in usefully. New Zealand folded up in their second innings for an identical 279 and it took the openers less than six overs to knock off the tiny target.

Right through the decade under the leadership of Dhoni's illustrious predecessors, the Indians had worked hard to remove the stigma of being pushovers on foreign soil. But New Zealand frustratingly had remained the one stumbling block.

'Why do you always want to compare things?' the winning captain asked with a touch of irritation in his voice when asked how this win ranked with the team's achievements abroad over the last eight years, a period in which India had won at least one Test match in every Test playing nation apart from New Zealand.

That sense of history hanging over the team perhaps accounted for Dhoni's caution in the third and final Test at Wellington where he delayed India's second innings declaration till he had set the hosts an impossible target of 617. Rain had also played its part in the draw.

Dhoni had missed the second Test at Napier with a back strain and in his absence, Virender Sehwag led India to a face-saving draw thanks to

brilliant rearguard batting after being forced to follow-on.

With the serious business of Test cricket behind him, it was now time for Dhoni to lead Chennai Super Kings in the second season of the IPL. Following a dramatic stand-off with the government, the organizers were forced to shift the annual jamboree to South Africa as the dates were clashing with the national elections.

Having ended IPL I as runners-up, CSK this time made it to the semifinals before being beaten by Royal Challengers Bangalore who in turn lost to Deccan Chargers in the final. Dhoni was in good form with the bat but he was outshone this time by another wicket-keeper/batsman/captain in Chargers' Aussie skipper Adam Gilchrist.

With two seasons of IPL behind them and as the reigning world champions following their victory in the inaugural World Twenty20 in South Africa, India started as favourites for the second edition in England. But the wheels fell off their campaign even before the start of the tournament and the captain was left to hold the can.

The Board's opaque and archaic manner of dealing with the media meant Dhoni had to face the music when opener and vice-captain Virender Sehwag was forced to pull out before the first game after facing just 10 deliveries in the nets.

Sehwag had been nursing a bad shoulder for some time and this was aggravated during the IPL semifinals shortly before the team was selected. But he was passed fit by the team physio and it was only after landing in England that he realised he was not in a position to play.

The media hinted at a rift between Dhoni and Sehwag and to make things worse, one daily even claimed the captain himself had leaked information about Sehwag's fitness woes.

The 'Captain Cool' façade showed signs of cracking in public for the first time as an incensed Dhoni had the entire team stand behind him in an apparent show of unity while addressing the media after a practice session at Nottingham. He read out a statement stating there was no rift in the team as he furiously denied all media speculation.

Dhoni had maintained a distance from the media since taking charge of the T-20 team in 2007 but made sure to be cordial in his dealings with them. He was always smiling and ever ready to crack a joke to ease the tension at press conferences. But now it appeared the pressures of the job were finally getting to him.

The controversy also brought into sharp focus the role of the IPL where franchises put pressure on their star players to play with niggles which would only get worse, thus jeopardizing their fitness when it was time for national duty. With the IPL now taking up a chunk of the already jam-packed calendar, the recovery time for unfit players had also been drastically reduced.

The second edition of the World T-20 was full of surprises right from the first match with hosts England being stunned by lowly Netherlands on the opening day. The mighty Australians too crashed out in the preliminary stage while the Indians eased through into the Super Eight stage with easy wins over Bangladesh and Ireland.

But disaster struck after that as the defending champions tasted defeat in all three of their games at the hands of West Indies, England and South Africa to fail to make it to the semifinals. After a golden run of two years, Dhoni's Midas touch finally appeared to be deserting him and the knives were out.

The West Indies bowlers peppered the Indians with short pitched bowling and this ploy worked so well that the English used the same tactics to dump India out of the event. By the time they were to face South Africa, the fight had gone out of the camp.

Not only had Dhoni failed to click with the bat, his tactical blunder in not sending Yuvraj Singh higher up the order against England meant the team fell short of victory by just three runs after requiring 19 in the final over. It was a tad too much for the captain and big hitter Yusuf Pathan.

Chasing 153 for victory, the raw Ravindra Jadeja was sent in at 63 for three in the 11th over with Yuvraj cooling his heels in the pavilion. By the time the youngster was out for a scratchy 25 and Yuvraj strode in, the asking rate had climbed to over 10, a task beyond the team.

Dhoni had to face the heat from a press pack baying for blood and he struggled to explain another spineless display that had effectively brought the campaign to an end.

To add another twist, Pakistan emerged champions even though their players were excluded from all the IPL franchises in the second season. It threw up the question of just how much was the IPL worth to the cause of the Indian national team. As always, opinions were sharply polarized.

Hardly had the captain and his men found time to recover, they were off to the West Indies for an ODI series. It may have served no purpose on

the face of it. But Dhoni's welcome return to form and the 2-1 verdict in India's favour did much to lift spirits.

A rare break of two months between the West Indies tour in July and another trip to Sri Lanka in September must surely have come as a huge relief to all the Indian cricketers. In August the world of cricket sat up and took notice as Australia were dethroned from the top spot in the ICC Test match rankings for the first time since they were introduced in June 2003. In fact, Australia had been the leading Test match nation ever since they had inflicted a stunning defeat over the West Indies in the Caribbean in 1995. But with the retirement of many of their superstars they were now a team in transition and successive losses to South Africa and England pushed them from the top spot.

Now the Aussies were pushed down to number four with South Africa, Sri Lanka and India taking the top three positions. South Africa were also number one in the ODI rankings with India breathing down their necks just one point behind.

Writing in an Indian publication at the time, the late Peter Roebuck predicted India would soon take the top spot in the Test rankings. Four months later, he proved to be spot on.

Coach Kirsten's immediate target as India prepared to take on Sri Lanka and New Zealand in the Compaq tri-series, however, was to make it to number one in the ODI rankings. And India achieved that coveted position after beating the Kiwis by six wickets at Colombo on September 11.

The euphoria, however, lasted precisely 24 hours. Being crushed by Sri Lanka by 139 runs the very next day meant they lost the top spot under the odd ICC ranking rules.

Two days later the same two teams contested the final which India won by 46 runs, riding on a dazzling century by Tendulkar and Harbhajan Singh's five wickets. But this did not result in their regaining the top spot in 2009.

It was for the first time since 1998 that India had won a tournament in Sri Lanka and this meant that the team had emerged victorious in four consecutive ODI series abroad in 2009, an outstanding feat.

So was India peaking at the right time for the Champions Trophy in South Africa, a tournament in which it had twice reached the final, losing to New Zealand in 2000 and sharing the title with Sri Lanka in 2002?

Not quite. For the second time in an ICC world event in the year, the team failed to make it to the semifinals. There was talk of them being chokers on the big stage.

But then India were without three of their tried and trusted match-winners. Sehwag and Zaheer Khan were down with injuries and to add to the team's woes, Yuvraj broke a finger during practice before the opening match.

In effect, India were eliminated after losing just one match, the first one against Pakistan in which the depleted bowling attack was so weak that the captain made the telling comment after the match about how he felt he was three bowlers short.

The next one against Australia was a 'no-result' due to rain and by the time India took on the West Indies in their final league match, their fate depended on Pakistan beating Australia at a match being played simultaneously just 40 kilometres away.

Agonizingly, though India trounced their opponents, the result was purely academic as Australia scrambled home by two wickets from the final ball to seal their place in the semis and send India packing.

Not even the first international wicket for Dhoni (Travis Dowlin) or being named ICC ODI 'Player of the Year' for the second straight year could take the pain away from another early exit.

However, it must be emphasized that if a captain is only as good as his team, then indeed Dhoni was hamstrung.

There was another welcome break for Dhoni as his IPL side CSK had not qualified for the inaugural Champions League. Such breaks have been few and far between especially now with Dhoni captaining in all three formats as well as in the IPL.

Seven-match ODI series usually are a match or two too long. But Australia were back in town in October and contests between the two nations have over the last decades always produced the sparks. This one was no different and even though India were beaten 4-2 (the final game being washed out), there were some magnificent performances on both sides.

With Sehwag finally back at the top of the batting order and Dhoni in cracking form, India had the momentum and they led the series 2-1 after being edged out by four runs in the opener at Vadodara.

India's massive 354 for 7 in the second game at Nagpur was built round a brilliantly paced 124 by Dhoni that took them home by 99 runs. It was his first century in 36 matches, the previous one being against Hong Kong in the 2008 Asia Cup.

Dhoni was there at the end with an unbeaten 71 as India cantered home by six wickets in New Delhi in the third match to take the series lead.

But like true champions, Australia bounced back. They made it 2-2 after a spine-tingler at Hyderabad where not even a masterly 175 from Tendulkar could prevent the Champions Trophy winners sneaking home by three runs. The world champions then wrapped up the series with ease, cantering home at both Mohali and Guwahati before the washout in the final game at Mumbai.

Normally a visit by Sri Lanka for a Test series would not elicit much attention. But this series was different with the number one Test position within India's grasp.

Centuries by Rahul Dravid and Dhoni helped India recover from early setbacks to cross 400 in their first innings in the first Test at Ahmedabad. It was only Dhoni's second century in 38 Tests and his first in more than three years.

The Lankan batsmen then ground the bowlers into the dust as they amassed 760 for 7 declared, the highest total ever on Indian soil. After that the match petered out into a tame draw.

Kanpur was a cakewalk for the home side, winning by an innings and 144 runs in four days. And it was of special significance too, being India's 100th Test win.

Now the coveted number one place was just one win away. And fittingly it came at the historic Brabourne Stadium in Mumbai where Test cricket was returning after 36 years.

Sehwag's blitzkrieg 293 knocked the stuffing out of the Lankan bowlers and with Dhoni reaching his second century of the series, the visitors crumbled to a second consecutive innings defeat.

There were euphoric scenes as the final Lanka wicket fell on December 6, 2009 marking the day India were finally crowned the top Test cricket nation in the world.

Dhoni was quick to give credit to all his teammates, coach Kirsten and the support staff. 'This was not achieved through one or two

individuals, but it was a long process and everyone has contributed, whoever has been a part of the side for the last 18 months. It has been a hard-earned achievement and it will be tough to maintain that at the same time.'

For seniors in the side like Tendulkar, Dravid and V.V.S. Laxman who had seen Indian cricket plumb the depths a decade earlier, the achievement was particularly sweet.

Dhoni had assumed the mantle of captaincy a year earlier from Anil Kumble. Before Kumble, Dravid and Sourav Ganguly had all guided India to memorable victories abroad thus ensuring that India would never again be considered pushovers in the Test arena. And former coach John Wright had also played a stellar role in the climb to the top.

The new found fervour for Test cricket among the players, fans and media forced the Board's hand. They had shown scant interest in the five-day game but now the clamour grew for India to play more meaningful matches at a time when it appeared the IPL was all set to overwhelm everything else in its path. South Africa were due to play five ODIs in February 2010 but this was hastily changed to three ODIs and two Test matches. Without more Test matches, India's time at the top would have been in jeopardy and the BCCI suddenly woke up to the value of Test match cricket.

In all the excitement, for once ODIs took a backseat. Both teams won a T-20 apiece while India took the ODI series 3-1. Dhoni's sparkling form continued with another century in the second ODI at Nagpur. But he was forced to sit out the next two matches after the Match Referee handed out a ban for slow over-rate in the Nagpur match which was Lanka's sole win in the series.

At the end of his first full year in charge of all three formats, Dhoni could look back with some satisfaction at 2009. There was the big disappointment of flops in the World Twenty20 and Champions Trophy, tempered by five ODI series wins out of six.

But ending the year at the top of the ICC Test rankings was surely the icing on the cake.



CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Domestic Bliss

YES, 2010 WAS indeed a year of domestic bliss for M.S. Dhoni.

How so?

Well, firstly he captained Chennai Super Kings to their maiden IPL title and then followed up by leading them to the Champions League crown as well. Both are after all classified as domestic tournaments.

But the highlight of the year for the Indian captain? Surely that came when he wed his girlfriend of two years, Sakshi Singh Rawat in Dehradun on July 4, just four days before his 29th birthday. So it was domestic bliss both on and off the field for Captain Cool.

The wedding also ended once and for all the speculation and rumours swirling around his alleged affairs with various movie stars. His days of bachelorhood were over and millions of young female fans around the country were left heartbroken.

The guest list was intriguing. It included two movie stars, John Abraham and Bipasha Basu and just two of his cricket friends, R.P. Singh and Suresh Raina plus a couple of Jharkhand politicians. None of the big names of Indian cricket nor any senior BCCI officials got an invite.

Needless to say, the media were given a wide berth. The tight security ensured they could not even come close to *Vishranti*, the resort where the wedding was held and TV reporters in particular were left desperately

scrambling for sound-bytes a safe distance from the venue. Perhaps it was the groom's way of getting back at the media for the torrid time they had given him the year before.

India's first test as the number one Test team in the world at the start of 2010 was passed easily enough as they beat Bangladesh in both the Test matches. A recurring back sprain kept Dhoni out of the first Test at Chittagong after India had been beaten by Sri Lanka in the final of the ODI tri-series at Dhaka that preceded the Test series. Dhoni's superb batting form carried on from the previous year with 89 in the second Test at Mirpur.

The real test came after that at home against South Africa, the second ranked team in the world in a Test series the Indian players had virtually demanded from the Board.

And there was a shock in store for the home side as they were swept away by an innings and six runs by South Africa's rampaging fast bowling attack in the first Test at Kanpur. It was a novel experience for Dhoni as it was the first time that India had lost a Test match under his captaincy and he was quick to admit India had been outplayed in all three departments.

India had to win the second and final Test at Kolkata to hold onto their top rank and they did that with minutes to spare in a tense finish with Hashim Amla emerging as South Africa's batting hero in the short series.

Dhoni's 132 not out was the fourth century for the Indians and their 643 for six declared meant that SA had to follow on. There were just nine mandatory deliveries to go when Harbhajan Singh got the final wicket and charged round the ground in celebration with his jubilant teammates chasing after him.

It showed just how much Test cricket meant to the Indian players even if officials and fans had largely turned their backs to it.

'We are very happy and it's fantastic to win the way we did. The heart was pumping in the end', said the off-spinner who had a haul of eight wickets at his favourite ground where he had first established himself in 2001 with 13 wickets against Australia.

The thrilling cricket continued into the ODI series as well and here it was Sachin Tendulkar's historic feat of becoming the first in ODI history to score a double century at Gwalior that grabbed the spotlight. India nosed ahead 2-1.

After squeaking home by a single run in the first match at Jaipur, the world of cricket was awe-struck as Tendulkar's 200 not out saw India romp home by 153 runs at Gwalior. Dhoni was batting with Tendulkar as India raced to 401 for 3. But the captain almost became the villain of the piece as he hogged the strike towards the end to be not out on a barnstorming 68 (35 balls) as the champion batsman just about managed to get across the line in the final over of the innings.

The IPL was back home in India after its brief sojourn in South Africa the year before. Chennai Super Kings suffered a setback early on when captain Dhoni was forced to sit out three matches with an arm injury and Suresh Raina led in his absence.

Dhoni top scored in the two opening games, a defeat at the hands of Deccan Chargers and a win against Kolkata Knight Riders in which fast bowler Shane Bond inflicted the injury on the CSK captain during Dhoni's match winning 66 not out.

But once Dhoni was back, CSK showed great spirit to recover from their poor start in which they had lost five of their first eight matches. They were helped by the inclusion of Australian left arm fast bowler Doug Bollinger who formed a match winning partnership with off spinner R. Ashwin and took them to six wins in their final eight games.

The crunch match came at Dharamshala in the return match against Kings XI Punjab where CSK were in a must-win situation to make the semifinals. CSK had lost the first at Chennai in the super over after the match ended in a tie.

The task looked enormous with 29 needed off the last two overs and 16 from the final bowled by Irfan Pathan. Now the captain took control, smashing a four and back-to-back sixes and his normally calm façade cracked as he screamed with joy and relief, punching his jaw before being engulfed by his frenzied teammates. He had smashed 30 runs off his own bat from nine balls of the last two overs.

It was an astonishing sight and one that raised eyebrows around the cricket world. The IPL was apparently different and the players were showing their emotions like never before. The high stakes and pressure from team owners was undoubtedly the cause of all this melodrama.

Dhoni admitted as much. 'Your franchise pays so much money for you, you should at least make the semi-finals. After that you can say it is a lottery.'

With seven wins in 14 league games, CSK managed to sneak into the semis on better run rate. But the semifinal against defending champions Deccan Chargers was no lottery. Defending a modest total of 142, Dhoni opened the bowling with Bollinger and Ashwin and they choked the champions' batting from the start. Going in with three spinners proved a master move and Chargers stumbled to 104 all out.

CSK were in the final for the second time in three years. Indeed, they were the only team to reach at least the semifinals in all three editions, a tribute to Dhoni's tactics and cool head under intense pressure. He had become Chennai's favourite son even before the final in a cricket-mad city where Tendulkar had been the all-time favourite before the advent of the IPL.

The final pitted these two superstars of Indian cricket against each other. And it was the Young Turk who outwitted the Old Master. Tendulkar blundered by sending in big hitting West Indian Kieron Pollard late down the order as MI unsuccessfully chased CSK's 168 for 5.

Despite some frantic hitting, the asking rate was too steep and the match was all but over with Pollard's dismissal for 27 from 10 balls. It came about thanks to a master stroke by the CSK captain. He placed Matthew Hayden at an unorthodox straight mid off only for Pollard to hit Albie Morkel into the hands of the fielder. A 'gut feeling' as Dhoni put it modestly. But it was his day and CSK romped home by 22 runs to lift the trophy for the first time.

Staring elimination in the face at the halfway stage, it was Dhoni's return which inspired his teammates to come up with something special and fight their way out of the tight corner to clinch the title.

Having been drained by the marathon IPL in the blazing Indian summer, the world's national cricket teams now hotfooted their way to the West Indies for the third World Twenty20. Could Dhoni also inspire his Indian teammates as he had done with CSK?

It was not to be and for the third ICC tournament in succession the Indian team fell short. In fact it was a case of déjà vu of the worst kind for them. Once again they made it to the Super Eight, including an impressive win over South Africa in the first stage. And once again they were found wanting against the short stuff and lost all three of their matches as had happened in England the previous year.

Having moved from St Lucia to the livelier tracks at Bridgetown, Barbados for the second stage, the former champions were thoroughly exposed and outplayed. Australia, West Indies and Sri Lanka all preyed on the traditional weakness of the Indian batsmen. It was left to Dhoni to blame excessive travelling and the compulsory IPL parties for player fatigue and burnout. Coach Gary Kirsten also attacked the team's fitness levels, hardly surprising considering the frenetic IPL schedule in the gruelling summer months.

What was clear as day was the huge gulf in standards between the IPL on placid Indian wickets and international cricket and how good performances in the glamorous domestic tournament was going to the heads of some cricketers.

Just as Pakistan had won the second edition in 2009 when none of their players had been picked following the inaugural IPL season in 2008, so England with just a handful of players in the IPL winning the world title in 2010 only added fuel to the fire.

The debate thus continued to rage: was the IPL beneficial to Indian cricket or should it be seen as a purely commercial venture?

It was little surprise that Dhoni led an exodus of the top players staying away from the Micromax ODI tri-series in Zimbabwe that followed so soon after the World T-20. Their exhaustion was reaching breaking point and it was left to the hapless Suresh Raina to captain the team. Being beaten twice by the hosts and failing to make the final did not say much for Indian cricket's bench-strength.

Recharged and rejuvenated, the Indians were back at full strength for the Asia Cup in Sri Lanka, a tournament in which they have enjoyed precious little success. In fact, the last title triumph was way back in 1995 and in the previous edition in 2008 they were undone by Lanka's mystery spinner Ajantha Mendis in the final in Karachi.

Victory in the final in Dambulla was therefore doubly sweet as Lanka were routed by 81 runs. But the path to the final was not that smooth for the eventual champions. They scrambled home by three wickets in the last over in a tense faceoff with Pakistan in which Dhoni (56) scored crucial runs and then lost to Lanka in their second league game just before turning the tables on them in the final.

July was a busy month for Dhoni. Following his engagement on July 3 and marriage the next day came the headline making news that he had

signed Indian sport's most lucrative endorsement deal ever with *Rhiti Sports Management* and *Mindscapes One* for a whopping Rs 210 crore (approximately \$42 million) over the next three years.

Dhoni's macho persona, his gung-ho batting style and commanding captaincy that had seen India rise to the top in all three formats since he first took over the reins of the national side in 2007 made him hot property in the corporate world and few were surprised that this youth icon—even at 29—had now surpassed Tendulkar as far as market value was concerned.

In short, he was now Indian cricket's number one superstar.

Dhoni did not have much time to enjoy either his status as a newly married man or his bulging bank account as the Indian team returned to Sri Lanka for a Test series just a month after the Asia Cup.

Lanka romped home in the opener at Galle while the second was buried under a mountain of runs by both sides.

India had to win the third and final Test at Colombo's P. Sara Oval—where Lanka had not lost a Test since 1994—to salvage the series and justify their top world ranking. It took another special innings by V.V.S. Laxman battling a bad back to see them over the line on a tense final day and once again the team showed resilience to bounce back after early setbacks in a Test series.

The Indian and Lankan players must have been fed up of facing each other on the cricket pitch by now, but there was to be no respite. Just three days after the Test series had ended, India were part of yet another ODI tri-series and it was not all that surprising when they were thrashed by 200 runs by New Zealand in the opening match, even though the margin of defeat came as a shock.

Predictably though, India and Lanka faced each other in the final again and this time Lanka lifted the Micromax Cup without breaking a sweat.

These were worrying signs for the Indians with the World Cup just months away. The team looked jaded and for the captain and coach much work remained to be done before the mega event.

But first there was the small matter of the Champions League in South Africa, a new experience for Dhoni and CSK as they had not qualified for the inaugural event in 2009.

With Muthiah Muralitharan and Ashwin being the leading bowlers in the tournament and Murali Vijay the top run scorer backed by Raina and

Mike Hussey, Dhoni's task was made somewhat simple. No side boasted such an array of international stars with the captain as usual inspiring with his leadership and batting.

In the final the IPL champions overpowered home favourites Eastern Cape Warriors by eight wickets to emerge kings of the Twenty20 domestic game. It meant that Dhoni now had the unique treble of the World T20 title for India in 2007 and now in one year, the IPL and Champions League in his captaincy kitty.

The high profile India-Australia series have enjoyed since 2001 meant the Aussies were back in India again after a year and a familiar pattern revealed itself in the pulsating first Test at Mohali.

Laxman's phenomenal run against the visitors continued. And just two months after he had guided India to victory in Sri Lanka despite a bad back, he was at it again. Chasing 216 for victory, the home side were seemingly down and out at 124 for 8. Laxman, battling spasms of the lower back once again showed his knack of shepherding the tail and India won a nail-biter by one wicket with Laxman's unbeaten 73 one of the greatest non-century innings in the history of Test cricket.

It was just a two-Test series so India winning the second Test at Bangalore by seven wickets made it a clean sweep for the hosts.

Only one match could be completed out of three in the ODI series due to rain and India won that by five wickets at Visakhapatnam to send the Aussies home without a win.

The New Zealanders followed their Trans-Tasman neighbours to India and put up a good show in drawing the first two Tests, marked by two centuries from the unlikely blade of Harbhajan Singh. But the Kiwi fight fizzled out in the third Test at Nagpur as they were crushed by an innings and 198 runs. The Test marked a welcome return to form for Dhoni as he fell two runs short of his century.

Dhoni took another break for the ODI series that followed and with Gautam Gambhir leading in his absence for the first time, India made a 5-0 clean sweep.

India were proving worthy of holding onto the number one Test place but they were now facing their sternest test as they headed to South Africa, the real 'final frontier' for the Indian team as they had only won one Test match there since first touring in 1992 and had not even managed a drawn series in four previous visits.

The series turned out to be one of the classics of all time, South Africa's ferocious fast bowlers against India's formidable batsmen led by the imperious Tendulkar. For the third time in 2010, India lost the opening Test and for the third time, they bounced back to level the series.

Even the ODI series turned out to be a humdinger with South Africa nosing ahead 3-2.

India were crushed by an innings in the opening Test at Centurion with their two innings a study in contrast. They were routed for 136 in the first, then bounced back with 459 in the second. But against the South Africans' 620 for four declared, it still turned out to be a rout. Tendulkar's awesome 50th test century and his stand worth 172 with Dhoni were the highlights for India, albeit in a losing cause. Dhoni's 90 was one of his best knocks as he took on the bowlers with bold, attacking strokes to give just a glimmer of hope to his team.

The home supporters were predicting a 3-0 whitewash but once again the Indians showed tremendous character to bounce back and take the second Test at Durban by 87 runs. In a low scoring match V.V.S. Laxman with 96 in the second innings was the only batsman on either side to score a half-century.

It meant that Dhoni had now won 14 of his 23 Tests as captain to be level with Mohammad Azharuddin as the second most successful Indian captain, though Azhar's 14 victories had come in 47 Tests. Going back into history, only Ricky Ponting, Steve Waugh and Don Bradman had a better success rate among those who had captained in more than 20 Tests.

It was a record to be proud of and by drawing the final Test at Cape Town, Dhoni also maintained his clean slate of never having lost a Test series to date.

Now as 2011 dawned it was time to look forward to the big prize, the World Cup to be staged in India, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh.



CHAPTER FOURTEEN

From Sublime to Ridiculous

‘I BELIEVE IN positive thinking, the Cup will be ours.’

Was captain M.S. Dhoni being a touch over-confident when he uttered these words in an interview to an Indian newsweekly on the eve of the 10th World Cup and the third to be staged in Asia?

Yes, the World Cup was coming back to the commercial and arguably, the spiritual home of cricket for the first time since 1996. But in the 36 years since the inaugural event had been staged in England in 1975, no team had won the final on their own soil.

Dhoni was at least outwardly confident but would all that would change at Mumbai’s Wankhede Stadium, venue of the final slated for April 2? Even if the team given to him was shaky in bowling and sloppy in fielding, it did boast of one of the most awesome batting lineups in world cricket.

If ever there had been an event where ‘Captain Cool’ would have to live up to his sobriquet it was now, with the entire nation expecting, almost demanding nothing less than the world title that had last been won famously in 1983 under the leadership of Kapil Dev. But back then, India were the no-hoppers of one-day cricket. This time the pressure to succeed at

home—something India had failed to do both in 1987 and 1996—was enormous.

The Indian team played true to type in the tournament's inaugural match against Bangladesh at Mirpur. This was a grudge match for the Indians who had crashed out at the first stage of the previous World Cup after being stunned by the same side in their first match in 2007.

It was the batsmen who ensured this time around that there would be no repeat of the 2007 humiliation. Virender Sehwag's 175 and World Cup debutant Virat Kohli's 100 not out saw them storm to 370 for four. In reply Bangladesh did well to reach 283 for 9. But though they were never in the contest, the wayward bowling of S. Sreesanth meant the Indian team management had a problem on their hands at the very start of the tournament.

The rest of the Indian campaign would be on home soil and it was at Bangalore that the World Cup exploded into action after a tame start.

The India-England encounter produced everything the full house could possibly ask for—except a winner! It was the first tie for both teams in World Cup history and the cracks that appeared in India's bowling attack in the opening game now appeared to have got alarmingly wider.

England were set a huge 339 for victory, more than any team had scored batting second in the World Cup, after Sachin Tendulkar's brilliant 120. India's total was impressive but could have been so much higher—they slipped from 305 for three in the 46th to 338 all out in the final over.

England's charge was led by captain Andrew Strauss whose 158 was the highest score by an Englishman in the World Cup and took them to the doorstep of victory at 280 for 2 in the 43rd over before Zaheer Khan bowled India back into the match. Needing a steep 29 runs from the last two overs, Piyush Chawla was smashed for 15 in the penultimate and now it was left to Munaf Patel to stem the tide. England needed two off the final ball of the pulsating match but could only manage to scramble a single. All of India breathed a sigh of relief!

With India facing Ireland and the Netherlands next, they had some time to catch their breath and try to rally the team after the near-trauma against England.

Ireland though just four days earlier had caused the upset of the tournament when they stunned England and Dhoni knew he could not take them lightly. In the event it was a splendid all-round performance by

Yuvraj Singh that saw the Indians through. His best bowling figures of 5 for 31 saw Ireland stumble to 207 all out and just when the jitters began to show again with India at 167 for 5, the left hander steered them home with a calm unbeaten 50.

It was Yuvraj again who was the standout performer in a less than impressive win over the doughty Dutch. There were sterner tests ahead and Dhoni had a battle on his hands.

It was hardly a surprise really when India finally stumbled in their fifth league match against South Africa at Nagpur. The margin may have been narrow—defeat by three wickets with two deliveries to spare—but there was no escaping the writing that was now on the wall.

The knives were out in the media with millions of Indian cricket fans around the world also wracked with doubt. Could their heroes overcome glaring weaknesses in the bowling and fielding departments? Was the mighty batting going to be enough to carry them through?

At Nagpur even the batting let them down. At a formidable 267 for one in the 40th over, 350 was a distinct possibility. But in the direst collapse of the World Cup, the last nine wickets crashed for the addition of a measly 29 runs.

The nation and the team looked towards their inspirational captain to hold his nerve and marshal his limited resources. But even he was flabbergasted, stranded on 12 at the other end, gaping in horror as one batsman after another trooped their way back after a blazing start from Sehwag and Tendulkar had come to naught.

After the match, Dhoni made a stinging comment to the waiting media: ‘You don’t play for the crowd, you play for the country.’

The format was such that India were assured of a place in the quarterfinals. It was only a question of which position they would finish in and after they defeated West Indies by 80 runs in Chennai—thanks to a maiden World Cup century by Yuvraj Singh—they ended up second to South Africa in Group B with West Indies and England also going through.

They were joined from Group A by Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Australia and New Zealand in the quarterfinals. No surprises there, but India now found themselves up against their most formidable challenge yet as the World Cup entered the nervy knockout stage.

It was to be India against Australia, champions of the last three World Cups in the big ticket match at Ahmedabad. Do-or-die time had

arrived for all eight sides.

It was billed as the final-before-the-final and had all the elements of a summit clash. Ricky Ponting's defiant century saw Australia to 260. It could have been much more, but the Indian fielders raised their game just when needed.

If the fielding was electric, the heat was oppressive and the atmosphere was heavy with tension as the Indian reply staggered to 187 for 5 with the exit of Dhoni. The crowd of 51,000 gasped, then held its collective breath as the nervy Suresh Raina came out to join Yuvraj, India needing 74 runs from 69 balls.

As he walked back the captain whispered a barely audible: '*Shabaash* Yuvraj, stay till the end' to India's crisis man.

Inspired, that is just what he did and with Raina rising to the occasion, the two left-handers with a series of bold strokes grabbed the initiative from Australia's flagging fast bowlers.

Yuvraj—Man of the Match for the fourth time—ended it all with a flourish with two overs to go. Down on his knees, pumping his fists with a mix of joy and relief, now finally the moment had arrived when the entire nation joined the team in the conviction they had shared with their leader from the start—that this was destined to be India's Cup!

Now what could possibly top the pressure of an India-Australia clash? Why, an India-Pakistan match-up in the semifinal of course!

A dream for cricket lovers around the world no doubt, but a nightmare for the players of both sides. With the heads of state of India and Pakistan present at the ground, a cricket match had been converted into a mini-summit. As if the pressure of a World Cup semifinal was not enough already.

The last time the two nations found themselves in a World Cup knockout match was in the quarterfinals at Bangalore back in 1996. Four times they had met on cricket's biggest stage and each time India had come out comfortable winners. It would be no different this time as well.

The Pakistanis were woeful in the field, giving Tendulkar four 'lives' and also lackadaisical with the bat. What should have been a high octane encounter fizzled out in the end though it did have its moments, enough to keep the cricket world riveted to Mohali.

India, losing finalists in 2003 and Sri Lanka, runners up in 2007 knew each other's games inside out since bilateral visits had become routine by

now. The final between them at Mumbai would be decided by the side that held its nerve best.

Nerves were indeed jangling as Mahela Jayawardene guided the Lankans to a challenging 274 for 6 with a sublime innings of 103 not out.

On five previous occasions, batsmen scoring a century had finished on the winning side in a World Cup final. But the Indians were determined to write their own chapter in cricket history under the lights of the modernized Wankhede Stadium.

When Lasith Malinga blasted out openers Sehwag and Tendulkar to leave India tottering on 31 for two an eerie silence descended over the ground.

Nerves were settled as Gautam Gambhir and Kohli added 83 but when Kohli fell for 35 at 114 for three, the target still appeared distant and daunting.

In what was to be the decisive moment of the match, Dhoni decided to promote himself ahead of the in-form Yuvraj. It turned out to be a master stroke but could so easily have been his undoing.

The captain's highest contribution with the bat so far in the tournament had been 34. Now something extraordinary was needed and Dhoni did just that. With Gambhir providing rock-solid support, Dhoni took on the bowlers and was the dominant partner in a stand worth 109 which was only broken when the opener fell three short of his century.

Dhoni settled the issue in grand style, a massive six off Nuwan Kulasekara with Yuvraj at the other end. It set off massive celebrations at the ground and around the country as millions of fans turned their cities, towns and villages into an all-night party zone.

Thus Dhoni entered the pantheon of India's cricket demi-gods, emulating Kapil Dev's feat of 1983 and adding a second world title in four years following victory in the inaugural World T20 in 2007. The Cup belonged to the team and the nation, the Man of the Match award to the captain for his epochal 91 not out and the Man of the Tournament to Yuvraj. With India also ranked the number one Test playing nation in the world under this captaincy, Dhoni's fame and fortune was now unparalleled in the history of Indian sport.

He deserved every bit of it. While at the ground the team chaired Tendulkar and coach Gary Kirsten (in his last match with the Indian team) on their shoulders, the captain preferred to keep a low profile. When

someone pointed out that he should be the one hoisted by his teammates, he gestured towards Tendulkar and said, 'It is his night!'

Perhaps. But it was Dhoni who had stuck to his guns despite criticism over some of his early decisions, coaxing his players to lift their fielding standards, marshalling his resources and taking the heat off his teammates by tackling the media after every match.

Cruelly, there was barely any time for the players to celebrate and relax with their families and loved ones. In less than a week it was back to the grind with IPL IV unfolding. And the onus was once again on Dhoni to defend the title Chennai Super Kings had won the previous year.

Dhoni expressed the feelings of his teammates when he admitted it would feel strange to oppose on the field those players with whom he had shared a dressing room in the national side just weeks earlier. But there was no way the fans could be persuaded this was the real thing after the high of being crowned world champions. They stayed away in droves and IPL IV turned out to be a giant flop.

Not for CSK though. They became the first side in the short history to win back-to-back titles. Captain Dhoni it seemed could do no wrong. He was the toast of his adopted city as the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium became a virtual fortress for CSK which became the first team to win all seven of their home ties. That took them into the 'first qualifying final' where they trounced Royal Challengers Bangalore by six wickets in Mumbai.

Four days later CSK were up against RCB again in the final. But with the match being played at Chennai there could be only one winner and Dhoni's men had it easy once again, getting home in a canter by 58 runs. Claiming the Fair Play award as well was a bonus and it led former India all-rounder, Chennai's own W.V. Raman to label Dhoni, 'One of the best captains the world has seen.'

Once again the fatigue factor set in and Dhoni and other top players skipped the ODI series in the West Indies where India led by Raina won by a comfortable 3-2 margin.

The increasing demands on Dhoni in all forms of the game had since the advent of the IPL seen him become selective in picking and choosing his tours. Under the circumstances it was hard to fault him though an Indian cricketer asking to take a break in the IPL due to fatigue is unlikely to ever occur.

The three Test series was won by India after they claimed the first Test at Kingston, Jamaica by 63 runs. The normally unflappable Dhoni found himself in the middle of a series of incidents that were the talking points of the series more than the cricket itself.

The third and final Test was to be the swan song of Australian umpire Darryl Harper. But he quit in a huff after the Kingston Test, condemning both the attitude of the Indian players who challenged his decisions and the ICC for not supporting him. The last straw for Harper apparently was Dhoni's pointed remark to the media at the end of the Test: 'If the correct decisions were made, the game would have finished much earlier, and we would be in our hotel by now.'

Dhoni's mood could hardly have improved after a technical blunder saw him dismissed in the first innings of the second Test at Bridgetown, Barbados. Umpire Ian Gould asked for a replay as he had doubts over the legitimacy of Fidel Edwards' delivery. But a previous delivery was shown instead and Dhoni was sent back. Later it was revealed that Edwards had indeed overstepped, leading to an apology from the production team of the host broadcaster.

The match saw a bold declaration by the Indian captain on the final day at 269 for six, setting West Indies 280 to win in 77 overs. They struggled to 202 for 7 in 71.3 overs before the umpires called off play due to bad light.

That boldness though seemingly abandoned Dhoni in the third Test at Dominica. He had the chance to become the first Indian captain to win two Tests in the Caribbean when the fourth innings target was 180 from 47 overs, coming down to 86 from the last 15 overs.

The crowd was stunned to see the Indian pair of Rahul Dravid and V.V.S. Laxman walk off the field at this stage and it emerged that the two captains had decided to call off the match. For a team ranked number one in the world this was a meek performance leading West Indies skipper Darren Sammy to comment, 'We were surprised. We thought with guys like Dhoni left, India would go for it.' Indian coach Duncan Fletcher defended the decision, claiming, 'It was an easy wicket to survive but a difficult track to score runs quickly.'

By the end of the series, Dhoni had emerged as the second most successful Indian skipper with 15 wins from 27 Tests, second only to Sourav Ganguly's 21 from 49. It was a wonderful record.

But disaster was lurking just round the corner. And it was in England that Dhoni and the Indian team would meet their Waterloo.

Truth to tell, the writing was on the wall from the beginning. India were ranked number one in the world in Test cricket and had just been crowned World Cup champions as well. But they came into the series with just one warm-up three-day match against Somerset and with most of the squad flying in straight from the Caribbean, they were under-cooked and under-prepared for the onslaught from a thoroughly professional English team.

With some of the players carrying niggles into the series and others picking up injuries during the matches, the captain found himself in charge of a squad that constantly needed tinkering and replacements. In all, seven players during the Test series and another two in the ODI series that followed were rendered *hors de combat*.

It was the 2000th Test match and 100th between India and England and with Tendulkar on 99 international centuries, worldwide interest was huge for the first Test at Lord's which saw packed houses on all five days.

But in the end, captain Dhoni was to rue his luck. 'Everything that could go wrong went wrong,' he said and indeed his woes began on the very first day.

Pace spearhead Zaheer Khan had missed the preceding West Indies tour with an ankle injury and had looked unfit against Somerset too. Now with Dhoni putting England in after winning the toss, the left armer prised out openers Alastair Cook and Andrew Strauss before limping off with a hamstring injury in his 14th over.

That was the end of the series for Zaheer and India never recovered from his absence. Despite a few ups and downs, England were always the dominant side and the heroics of Praveen Kumar with ball and Dravid with the bat went in vain as India went down by 196 runs.

So frustrated was Dhoni with his lack of bowling resources after Zaheer's exit that he even gave himself the ball and turned his arm over for eight overs in England's second innings.

India had their moments in the second Test at Trent Bridge. In fact till the end of the second day they looked marginally the better side. But after that it was England all the way and as the Indian challenge faded away, England stormed home by the crushing margin of 319 runs.

The turnaround was led by Ian Bell's second innings century, with England recovering from 57 for two to 544 all out and once again it was only Praveen Kumar and Dravid with another century in the first innings, who emerged with any credit. The Man of the Match award however went to all rounder Stuart Broad who became the first bowler in India-England Test matches to claim a hat trick besides innings of 64 and 44.

Dhoni had another miserable match with the bat but it was his gesture of withdrawing the run out appeal against Bell at the stroke of tea on the third day and allowing Bell to resume his innings under highly contentious circumstances that grabbed much of the headlines as England stormed to a 2-0 lead in the series.

Now England needed one more win to topple India off their perch and claim the number one Test position and they did it in emphatic style as India were crushed by an innings and 242 runs in the third Test at Edgbaston to revive the horrors of 1974 when India were crushed and whitewashed 3-0.

India's miserable scores of 224 and 244 was less than that scored by one man, England opener Alastair Cook and his massive 294 took England to an impregnable 710 for 7 declared.

Dhoni top scored for India in both innings but his scores of 77 and 74 not out were cold comfort as for the first time in his captaincy career, he felt the bitter taste of a series defeat.

The rout was complete and the whitewash was stark as India were once again crushed by an innings in the fourth and final Test at the Oval. It was the first time since Australia in 1968 that India had lost all four Tests in a series and for a side that had been ranked number one at the start of the series, the fall from grace could not have been more calamitous.

Dhoni managed to keep his composure as he was bombarded with tough questions at the end of the match and the series. Inevitably, the spotlight was on the IPL and how it had adversely affected India's Test match preparations. Dhoni put up a brave front but he really had no answers as to how India could have been so comprehensively defeated with Dravid's third century of the series at the Oval once again the lone saving grace for the vanquished.

There was no respite in the T20 match—lost by six wickets—and the ODI series that followed either. The tie in the fourth game at Lord's was the closest the Indians came to winning an international match all tour as

they were beaten 3-0 and Dhoni's Man of the Series award for three half-centuries was just about the only crumb of comfort he could take back with him.

Writing in the *Sportstar* at the end of the tour, English columnist Ted Corbett expressed sympathy for Dhoni. 'In common with every other captain Dhoni has made tactical mistakes but he has never failed to lead . . . the weight of responsibility has been so great that a poor run of batting form [in the Test series] was only to be expected . . . Dhoni has found many friends and admirers since he arrived in this country and there will be a wave of disappointment if he is blamed for the appalling results of the last few weeks.'

Dhoni's woes continued in the Champions League in which Chennai Super Kings were the holders. They beat Cape Cobras but lost to Mumbai Indians, Trinidad and Tobago and New South Wales to go out in the group stage with the Mumbai Indians winning the title.

Now less than a month since they met in the fifth and final ODI at Cardiff, England were in India for five ODIs. Cries of revenge were in the air and on the airwaves but even though India did gain a modicum of revenge by whitewashing England 5-0, it hardly made up for the indignities suffered during those three miserable months in England. For the second successive series, Dhoni's batting won him the Man of the Series award proving he was still a potent force with the bat at least in ODIs.

Writing in the *Sporstar* (October 14, 2011 issue) on the eve of the ODI series, former Test all-rounder W.V. Raman expressed the concern that the strain may be proving too much for Dhoni. 'The chances of Dhoni getting jaded, both mentally and physically are high and there will come a time when he has to take a break. He can get drained completely at some point given the fact that he plays in all formats of the game and executes various demanding roles.'

That break came a month after Raman's column in the five-match ODI series against the visiting West Indies which India won 4-1. Sehwag and Gambhir led in his absence and the series was marked by the new world ODI record of 219 by Sehwag in the fourth match at Indore.

India had easily won the three-Test series that preceded the ODIs with wins at New Delhi and Kolkata and a dramatic draw at Mumbai where India finished nine down and the scores level. Dhoni smashed a

swashbuckling 144 from 175 balls in the second Test at Kolkata with 10 fours and five sixes. It was his fifth Test century, all coming on the subcontinent.

The year ended with India heading to Australia for a highly anticipated series. Despite the whitewash suffered in England, it was India that started the series as favourites since the Australians were a team in transition and were still smarting from setbacks against South Africa and New Zealand under the new leadership pairing of captain Michael Clarke and coach Mickey Arthur.

India had never won a Test series Down Under and the pundits felt this would be their first chance. But Australia took the early lead in the series winning the Melbourne Boxing Day Test by 122 runs to see out a mixed 2011 for India, world champions in 50 overs, but not the recipients of much joy in Test cricket.



CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Pressure Tells

AS WITH THE England series, the Indians were competitive midway through the first Test in Australia as well. At 214 for two on the second day at Melbourne in reply to Australia's patchy 333, the visitors with their formidable batting lineup appeared in for a big lead. Instead they collapsed to 282 all out and 169 in the second innings.

Just how stark was the downhill slide after that is best illustrated by these statistics—only twice more in seven further innings did the Indians even manage to get as far as 214, four times falling for less than 200.

The Australians on the other hand were dismissed only once after the first Test and twice crossed 600. Three England batsmen had taken double tons off India's bowling months earlier. This time around, there were two doubles plus a triple ton from Australia's resurgent captain Michael Clarke.

Two innings defeats, two others by 122 runs and 298 runs—Indian cricket—the Test version, certainly—had sunk to an all-time low with eight straight defeats abroad.

Virender Sehwag described the pace attack of Peter Siddler, Ben Hilfenhauss, Ryan Harris, Mitchell Starc and James Pattinson as the best Australian bowling line-up he had ever faced. And as in England months

earlier with the exception of Rahul Dravid, this time too, the senior batting pros all failed leaving only young Virat Kohli with an enhanced reputation.

Dhoni's wretched form overseas continued with only 102 runs in three Tests. His habit of slowing down the game when the Australian batsmen were on top was not only ultra-defensive, it was also self-defeating and following the third Test at Perth he was suspended for the fourth and final game at Adelaide.

This defensive on-field attitude was on show off field as well with the team displaying a siege mentality as things began to fall apart. With the shadow of his impending 100th international century hanging over him, Tendulkar was in great demand. But he did not utter a word in public. Rookies were sent to face the heat of the press at the end of the day's play and when seniors like Sehwag and Gautam Gambhir addressed the media, they only made things worse with their indiscreet comments which undermined their skipper.

No captain could go through such a horror trot without some cracks showing up within the team and sure enough it was back to Dhoni vs Sehwag. The media played up the rift and the captain and his vice-captain hardly helped matters with their conflicting statements.

At the end of the third Test at Perth, Dhoni hinted it was time to phase out the 'seniors' with V.V.S. Laxman being apparently in his sights. By the next Test at Adelaide a fortnight later, acting captain Sehwag retorted that there was no need for any such change to come about. And so it went on.

Dhoni admitted he was the 'main culprit' once the series had been lost at Perth and hinted he was ready to fall on his sword and give up one format by 2013. He admitted to being more disappointed with his batting than with his captaincy. His poker face when facing the media and look of detachment, whether after a win or defeat, had helped him cope with the huge pressures of leading the country in all three formats and in the IPL and Champions League as well. But now there was a feeling that this detachment was detrimental to the team's cause and what was needed was someone with more involvement.

There was a ray of light with India drawing the T-20 series 1-1 and Dhoni playing two useful knocks. But the ODI tri-series involving India, Sri Lanka and Australia—the same teams which India had defeated in 2008—saw further disappointment.

India failed to make it to the finals—but only just. And following his maiden Test century, Kohli brought the house down at Hobart where he flayed Sri Lanka's bowling to the tune of 133 not out off 86 balls in what turned out to be India's last match of the CB Series.

India went into the game needing to beat Lanka by a big margin to keep themselves alive in the tournament and then hope Australia would beat Lanka in the final qualifying match.

It almost happened thanks to Kohli and Suresh Raina as India needed to chase down Lanka's 321 with at least 10 overs to spare. They did it in 36.4.

Just 48 hours later, it was all over for the Indians as Australia were beaten by 9 runs and India's dismal tour was over.

If India got as far as they did in the tri-series, they owed much to Dhoni's continued excellent run with the bat as he finished with an average of 51.25.

Once again though he was suspended for one match due to the team's slow over-rate, a bad habit that had developed under his captaincy. He also did not endear himself by blaming slow seniors—specifically, Tendulkar, Gambhir and Sehwag—in the field for the big loss to Australia at Brisbane. As part of the new fangled 'rotation policy' in team selection, Dhoni had decided that only two of these three would play in any one game and it did not go down well with either Gambhir or Sehwag with the vice-captain barely able to suppress his ambition to unseat the incumbent.

Dhoni stayed ice cool in the final over of two tense games. With India needing 13 runs in the last over against Australia at Adelaide, Dhoni struck a six to take the side home after Gambhir had contributed 92. Dhoni was sluggish to start with and at the end of the match, Gambhir criticized his captain for leaving the final charge so late. The cracks were now widening at a rapid rate and the morale of the side was at rock bottom.

Dhoni was also there at the end of the pulsating tied verdict against Lanka at Adelaide. He needed a boundary from the final ball from Malinga and managed to smash it for three to level the scores. Fittingly, in his 200th ODI Dhoni was Man of the Match for his 58 not out though Gambhir once again top scored with 91.

In *The Cricketer* (UK) magazine dated April 2012, Andrew Miller wrote about Kohli, 'In three years' time India will defend the World Cup

on Australian soil, by which stage Kohli, currently 23, will surely be their captain.'

Six months later, much of the Indian media would be echoing that prediction.

Tendulkar's quest for his 100th international century had been proving a distraction for the team on the tours of England and Australia. He finally got to the landmark in the Asia Cup match against Bangladesh at Mirpur and the team and his countless fans and the man himself could breathe easy now that the monkey was off his back. It was not enough though to prevent a shock defeat at the hands of the hosts and though India recorded big wins against Lanka and Pakistan, as title holders they failed to make the final.

The fifth season of the IPL that followed was marked by a spate of both on and off field controversies with TV stings, sex scandals and persistent fixing rumours tarnishing the brand. The big surprise came right at the end with Kolkata Knight Riders stunning one and all by taking the title after entering their maiden final.

Chennai Super Kings gunning for a hat-trick of titles made it to the final for the fourth time out of five but for the second time finished as runners-up. CSK were on the verge of elimination in the league stage and just about managed to make it to the final phase. Dhoni had a quiet time with the bat with just one fifty but that was a barnstorming 51 not out from a mere 20 balls in the elimination final against Mumbai Indians at Bangalore that powered CSK home by 38 runs. In the next game, the second qualifying match, CSK crushed Delhi Daredevils by 86 runs to make their third straight final where they ran into a resurgent KKR.

The now obligatory trip to Sri Lanka to squeeze yet another ODI series saw the Indians, by now totally at home in such conditions, easily win 4-1. The series though was a forgettable one save for the brilliant show by the sensational young gun Kohli with two centuries. With this verdict, India now climbed to No. 2 in the ICC ODI rankings.

After the rigours of the English and Australian tours, the home series against New Zealand was expected to be a cakewalk, kicking off an early start to a hectic season with England, Pakistan and Australia also touring India.

The first Test at Hyderabad proved a cakewalk for the hosts. But in the second at Bangalore they came up against an inspired spell of seam

bowling by Tim Southee who claimed 7 for 64 as the Kiwis took a small first innings lead. At 166 for 5 in the second innings chasing 261 for victory, India were in a corner till Kohli and Dhoni saw them home with a fighting unbeaten partnership worth 96 runs.

New Zealand proved a point by winning the T20 series. The first match at Visakhapatnam was washed out and then they clinched a thrilling game at Chennai by one run.

Eight days later the Indians opened their campaign in the fourth World T20 championship by beating Afghanistan at Colombo.

The event marked the fifth anniversary of Dhoni's ascension to the captaincy of the Indian T20 team in September 2007, leading India to that amazing victory in the inaugural World championship in South Africa on captaincy debut. The captaincy of the ODI and Test sides would follow.

It was also announced in September that Dhoni had been named captain of the ICC's ODI Team of the Year for 2011-12. This was the fifth year in a row that Dhoni had made the team but the first time as captain.

It has been quite a roller-coaster ride for Dhoni and the national side under his leadership over the past five years. The World T20 title was followed two years later by the world number one ranking in Test matches in December 2009, a ranking that lasted for just over 18 months and then came the crowning glory of the World Cup (50-overs) triumph on home soil in 2011.

On the domestic front, Dhoni's record with CSK was brilliant, clearly the best of all franchises—two titles and two runners-up finishes in five years. But 2011-12 also marked the twin whitewashes in the Test series in England and Australia while India's record under his captaincy in the three World T20 tournaments that followed the 2007 triumph was abysmal.

The failure to reach the semifinals in the fourth edition of the World T20 in Sri Lanka in 2012 followed similar flops in England in 2009 and in West Indies in 2010. But this time around the sympathy was largely with Dhoni and his men as they were edged out on Net Run Rate despite winning four of their five matches in the event.

A rather ironical situation since the format in all ICC world events had been re-jigged following India crashing out in the first round of the 2007 World Cup (50-over) in the Caribbean which ensured that the championship was a massive financial disaster.

Having eased past Afghanistan and then thrashed defending champions England in the group stage, India finished with two wins out of three in the Super Eights. Losing their first match in the Super Eights to Australia by nine wickets had put them in a spot. Dhoni's tactic of playing five specialist bowlers and once again controversially omitting Sehwag backfired and he had to face the music after the match. By now no doubt exhausted with the grilling, he wearily told the media he could not go on justifying every move.

India had to win the next match against Pakistan to keep their semifinal hopes alive and by doing so they maintained their perfect record in all World Cup (50 and 20 overs) tournaments since 1992. The Indians kept their nerve under pressure as Kohli's 78 not out demonstrated why he was now one of the leading batsmen in world cricket.

But events conspired against Dhoni and his men and despite winning their final match by one run against South Africa, they were forced to pack their bags, having been edged out of the last four on NRR.

All eyes were on the Pakistan-Australia tie just before India took on the South Africans. An Australian victory would have seen India through. Australia lost by 32 runs but they needed to make just 112 to seal their own place in the semis. This they just managed to reach in the final over, crawling to 117 for 7 in an unusually inept and insipid performance which raised many eyebrows including that of Sunil Gavaskar who wrote in his column that it was not so much the defeat as the margin and the manner of the Aussie batting that was surprising.

So minutes later, India went into their game knowing they had to beat their opponents by at least 31 runs, a near-impossible task once they lost the toss, batted first and managed to put up a modest 152 for six on the board. The South Africans knew they were already out but they dragged the match to the final over rather than cave in to the Indians. Once they had crossed the 122-run mark, the tournament was over for both the sides and Kohli for one was inconsolable at the manner of India's exit, reportedly sobbing in the dressing room after the match.

It was a dispiriting end to the Indian campaign and most of the sympathy in the Indian media was with the team for the cruel way in which they had been eliminated. The clamour over Dhoni's captaincy though was now rising to a crescendo.

Going in with three spinners worked against England early in the tournament. But persisting with the combination upset the team balance and gave the team an unsettled look. In all the chopping and changing, it was back to three pace bowlers in the final Super Eight match against South Africa. Against Australia, there was a short rain break between innings and when the Aussies came out to bat, the three spinners struggled to grip the ball.

Leaving Sehwag out of that match, Dhoni admitted was the toughest selection dilemma of his captaincy career. The openers also failed to deliver in every match and this put a strain on the rest of the batting. These factors at least were out of the captain's control as was Australia's shock capitulation to Pakistan which put India under immense pressure in the last match.

However, the dynamic captain who had captured the nation's imagination with his bold and dramatic moves in the World Cup at home a year earlier was nowhere to be seen now. In Sri Lanka he appeared to go into his shell, most notably when he virtually gave up the fight with defensive fields and holding back frontline spinner R. Ashwin as South Africa batted in the final Super Eight match.

Former India opener Aakash Chopra severely criticized this new troubling *avatar* of the captain in *cricinfo.com*. Under the headline 'From instinctive to inflexible', Chopra wrote: 'Of late, the flexibility that was Dhoni's forte seems to have deserted him. I'm not a huge fan of a captain being too flexible, since it can betray a lack of conviction, but rigidity isn't good either, for that stems from arrogance.'

Chopra put down this new safety-first approach to a fear of losing. So had Dhoni lost his mojo?

Outlook newsweekly certainly felt he had and they had Virat Kohli on their cover (October 15, 2012) as the heir apparent to the captaincy in the limited overs formats.

Right after the World T20, it was time for the Champions League played in South Africa for the second time and this time CSK failed to produce any magic, further denting Dhoni's captaincy credentials. CSK were champions when the CL had been staged for the first time in South Africa in 2010. This time they failed to reach the semifinals as they won two and lost two of their group matches. In the final inconsequential game against Yorkshire, Dhoni played as a specialist batsmen, handing the

captaincy reigns to Suresh Raina and the keeping gloves to Wriddhiman Saha. It was obvious by now that he desperately needed a break from the taxing triple role.

Dhoni's triple role as captain/wicket-keeper/batsman though is no longer unique in international cricket as it once used to be though none can approach his record of over 200 international matches as captain/wicket-keeper over the three formats. Significantly, his batting average is considerably higher as captain and this is a great credit to his temperament and dedication.

Before him only England's Alec Stewart in the '90s and later Sri Lanka's Kumar Sangakkara had excelled in these roles. Indeed the 2011 World Cup final in Mumbai between India and Sri Lanka saw two wicket-keeper/batsmen going out for the toss for the first time.

In 2011 Bangladesh's wicket-keeper Mushfiquur Rahim followed Dhoni's footsteps in taking charge of his team in all three formats while South Africa's wicket-keeper A.B. de Villiers is captain in the 50-overs and T-20 formats.

But leading CSK in the IPL and Champions League places additional strain on Dhoni and something would have to give sooner or later. Dhoni himself was giving hints that he would drop one format. And as we will see in subsequent chapters, that's exactly what he did.

In perhaps a sign of things to come, Dhoni on November 7, 2012 in Mumbai unveiled his Mahi Racing Team squad for the FIM World Superbike Championship in the Supersport category. It is the factory team of Yamaha in the 600 cc class.

Earlier known as the MSD R-N Racing Team India, Dhoni showed how serious he is about his passion for bikes by signing up three-time world champion Kenan Sofouglu and fourth-placed Fabien Foret for his new team. He also announced he had plans to set up a riding school in India.

Media speculation centred round his plans to open a riding school in India—perhaps Dhoni was already planning for his life after cricket. He summed up his feelings when he said: 'Frankly, if you ask me, coming from a small town, I never thought I would play for India; as simple as that! Opening a riding school was definitely never on the agenda for me, but now we are in a position where we can do that.'



CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Captain Ice-Cool

THE ELEVATION OF Mahendra Singh Dhoni from ‘The Man’ to the Superman of Indian cricket in 2013 centred round two memorable victories in the 50-overs game and also a rare clean sweep in favour of India in the Test arena.

The year marked Dhoni becoming the first captain to lift the triple crown of ICC world titles—T20 World Cup, 50-over World Cup and finally, the Champions Trophy in England.

Add to that the world number one ranking in Test cricket which India reached in December 2009 under his captaincy and two IPL and Champions League titles and Dhoni’s trophy cabinet was now packed to overflowing.

In the West Indies it was another ODI tri-series and yet again it involved Sri Lanka. The barnstorming finale though was anything but humdrum.

But those days of glory seemed pretty distant when the English cricket team came visiting in late 2012 for what the electronic media was rather predictably billing as the revenge series—‘revenge’ being for that 4-0 whitewash suffered the summer before in England.

England’s record in India had been pretty abysmal with only three captains—Douglas Jardine (the first tour in 1933-34), Tony Greig (1976-

77) and David Gower (1984-85) returning victorious. To that illustrious list was now added the name of Alastair Cook.

But the eventual shock 2-1 victory for England seemed highly unlikely with the series getting off to a predictable start at Ahmedabad. That old Indian formula—win the toss, bat first, amass a huge total and then let the spin bowlers take over—worked like a charm at the Sardar Patel Stadium and India romped home by 9 wickets.

But not before Cook gave the Indians a taste of what was to come as he batted for nearly 10 hours in the second innings for his defiant 176 which forced India to bat again. It was Cheteshwar Pujara's maiden Test double century however that got him the Man of the Match award.

Dhoni immediately called for the wicket for the second Test at Wankhede Stadium in Mumbai to aid the spinners from the start.

It sure did—but it was England's spin pair of Graeme Swann and Monty Panesar who hoisted India and their cocky captain by their own petard with 19 wickets in the match between them.

India were beaten at their own game and how. They went in with three spinners and just one pace bowler. But not for the first time a spin friendly track had played into the hands of the visiting team's bowlers. The shock of losing by 10 wickets left Dhoni and his men shell-shocked and ashen-faced.

For England it was an astonishing turnaround of fortunes led by Panesar (11 wickets), Cook (122) and Kevin Pietersen whose 186 was one of the most brutal innings played on Indian soil.

Dhoni's persistence on demanding turners fell on deaf years with the Eden Garden's 83-year-old curator Prabir Mukherjee slamming the Indian captain's call as 'immoral' and no amount of pressure from the BCCI and his host association could sway him.

Sure enough this time it was England's fast bowlers and not spinners that undid the Indian batsmen after another almost inevitable century by the immovable Cook set them on course for a mammoth 523 and a lead close to 200 runs. By now resistance appeared futile and England cantered home by 7 wickets to the amazement of the cricket world.

The fourth and final Test at Nagpur proved to be anti-climatic. India went in with four spinners but on a flat pitch there was never really any chance of a result. The excruciatingly slow batting of Virat Kohli and his captain on the third day however raised eyebrows as quick scoring was

vital if India wanted to force a result. Instead the pair added 198 runs for the fifth wicket in 507 balls. It was painful to watch.

Dhoni made his only substantial score of the series with his run out for 99 just about summing up his woes in the series where all his well-laid plans had backfired.

Now, the knives were out. The media was calling for his head and had virtually appointed the young sensation Kohli as his replacement. Things just got worse when Pakistan made a short visit and took the ODI series 2-1 and drew the T-20 series 1-1 though Dhoni's run of scores in the ODI series (113 not out, 54 not out and 36) only emphasised his indispensability in the limited-overs format.

'Embattled' was the headline for the cover story on Dhoni in the *Sportstar* weekly (13 January, 2013) while a newsweekly had Kohli, the heir apparent on their cover.

Dhoni's cause was not helped by a bunch of disgruntled and insecure senior players and the poor form of Sachin Tendulkar, Harbhajan Singh and Zaheer Khan. It certainly was not a happy camp.

Around this time it was also revealed by former selector and batting legend Mohinder Amarnath that the selectors had unanimously decided to remove Dhoni as captain early in 2012 after the 4-0 whitewash in Australia which had followed the same result in England in 2011. Amarnath claimed they were overruled by Board President N. Srinivasan who as the owner of Chennai Super Kings was perceived as having a vested interest in protecting Dhoni's star value.

There was a rare moment of happiness for the beleaguered skipper when England returned after the Christmas break for two T-20s (deadlocked at 1-1) and an ODI series which India won 3-2. The highlight came on 19 January, 2013 when Dhoni's hometown of Ranchi staged its maiden ODI and the local lad smashed the winning runs. His comment at the toss that he must have played tennis-ball cricket with at least half the 30,000-strong crowd set the scene for a memorable occasion and with India sealing the series, they had displaced England as number one in the ICC ODI rankings.

The busiest international season in Indian cricket history meant that the harried hosts barely had enough time to regroup before Australia under Michael Clarke's captaincy were in town for a series of four Test matches.

Once again there was talk of revenge in the air—Dhoni's men had suffered their second consecutive whitewash when they were crushed by Australia Down Under the previous season.

Revenge is exactly what was extracted, a full measure too as the 0-4 verdict was reversed and this time it was 4-0 in India's favour. It was only the second time Australia had lost all four Tests in a series, following their rout in South Africa back in 1970.

Dhoni led from the front and his 224 from 265 balls in the first Test at Chennai was the highest score by both an Indian captain and a wicket-keeper.

Despite the English spinners turning the tables on the home batsmen in the preceding series, the captain once again insisted on spin-friendly pitches and this time his ploy worked.

The tourists did not have the bowlers to exploit the conditions and Dhoni himself took the initiative by going after their spin attack at Chennai, shredding Nathan Lyon's off-spin to the tune of 104 runs from 85 balls.

Clarke's century in the first innings would turn out to be the team's lone ton in the series while the Indian batsmen amassed six, including two by opener Murali Vijay and doubles by Dhoni and Pujara.

Dhoni got the Man of the Match award for his maiden first-class double ton. But with local lad R. Ashwin bagging 12 wickets in the match, it must have been a close run thing. No surprise that India romped home by 8 wickets and that set the tone for the rest of the series.

Just as Australia had outplayed India in every Test on their own soil, India now paid them back in their own coin. They won the second Test at Hyderabad by an innings and 135 runs and both the third at Mohali and the fourth at Delhi by 6 wickets. Only the continued pressure on the curators by the captain and the Board officials to produce rank turners took some of the gloss off the victory.

The morale in the Aussie camp was in tatters, highlighted by the 'homework' episode with four of their players dropped on disciplinary grounds on the eve of the Mohali Test.

The dropping of Gautam Gambhir before the series and of Harbhajan and Virender Sehwag midway through—no doubt with the captain's blessings—plus the continued absence of Zaheer allowed the induction of much-needed fresh blood into the side.

Pujara cemented his place at number three with another double century while Shikhar Dhawan made a barnstorming century on debut and swing bowler Bhuvneshwar Kumar an impressive entry into Test cricket too. With Kohli reinforcing his status as one of the world's leading batsmen and spinners Ashwin, Pragyan Ohja and Ravindra Jadeja cementing their places, Dhoni finally had a team he could mould in his own image rather than having to constantly look over his shoulder at insecure seniors.

Tendulkar's decision to retire from ODIs must also have come as a relief to the captain and the team since his poor run of scores over the last couple of years was becoming a strain and a distraction.

No one was calling for Dhoni's head any more. But it was close. One more defeat and the pressure to remove him would have been too much to resist any further.

Now it was time for IPL Season VI, a tournament where Dhoni had enjoyed immense success with Chennai Super Kings.

Ranchi-born though he was, Dhoni had by now been happily accepted as Chennai's favourite adopted son. His double century in the Chennai Test against Australia only confirmed that.

It was the captain again who was in at the death of their opening match against Mumbai Indians at Chennai. In a contest between two power hitters, West Indian Kieron Pollard's 57 not out took MI to 148 for 6.

Half the CSK side were out for 56 before Dhoni stepped in to blow the Mumbai bowlers away. His 51 was scored at virtually two runs per ball and with 40 needed off 18 balls, Dhoni smashed Pollard for 17 runs. Now it was 23 off 12 and when Munaf Patel came in for the final over, the equation was down to 12—a cakewalk going by Dhoni's track record.

However, it was Pollard who was to have the last laugh on the night as he took an acrobatic catch on the deep midwicket boundary from what looked like a certain 6 and with Dhoni's dismissal, the chase petered out.

CSK roared back in the next match at Mohali, recording a rare 10-wicket win over Kings XI Punjab and followed that with a last-ball finish against Royal Challengers Bangalore courtesy a shocking final ball no-ball by RP Singh which allowed CSK to squeak home.

Delhi Daredevils were demolished by 86 runs and holders Kolkata Knight Riders given a rude shock in their backyard and despite a setback

against Pune Warriors, CSK were zooming to the top of the points table by the halfway stage after another heart-stopping win over Rajasthan Royals.

That drama was repeated three days later against Sunrisers Hyderabad and by now the Chennai fans were complaining—why did their captain always have to take their games down to the wire?

With 15 runs needed from the last over, Ashish Reddy went for a 6 and two boundaries and Chennai were home with two deliveries to spare. Those runs came off Dhoni's bat, naturally. His unbeaten 67 took 37 balls.

The talk of the match was his assault on Dale Steyn, widely regarded as the world's leading fast bowler who went for a whopping 45 runs from his four overs. Three of Dhoni's four 6s came off Steyn's bowling who despite bowling at ferocious pace found himself swatted away.

By now CSK bowling coach Andy Bichel was comparing Dhoni to Australian compatriot Michael Bevan, widely regarded as the best finisher in the 50-over game. But Bichel conceded Dhoni's task being was tougher given the shorter format.

One of the ironies of this IPL season was the splendid form of Australian opener Mike Hussey whose recent retirement from the national side had been one of the factors in his nation's whitewash at the hands of India.

Hussey was apparently more comfortable under Dhoni's captaincy than that of Clarke's and his first eight innings in the season brought him 445 runs at the amazing average of 89. Dhoni's inspirational captaincy allowed him to bring out the best in his players not only on the international stage.

With Suresh Raina, Dwayne Bravo and Ravindra Jadeja also in sparkling form, CSK ensured their record of being the only team to advance past the group stage in every season was intact. They ended with 11 wins out of 16 and the best away record in the league.

But even as the IPL was entering its final stages, came the stunning news on May 16 that three cricketers from Rajasthan Royals—including international bowler S. Sreesanth—had been arrested for alleged spot fixing in the IPL.

The news hit like a cloudburst. For those though who had followed the various shenanigans associated with the cash-rich league from its start in 2008, it did not come as a total surprise. There had been the TV sting on five players the previous year which hinted at the corruption lurking. The

lack of checks and balances and the total freedom given to the franchise owners was bound to have repercussions.

Even as the three players found themselves behind bars all the while protesting their innocence, came another bombshell with the news of the arrest of Gurunath Meiyappan, son-in-law of BCCI President N. Srinivasan on charges of betting on CSK matches.

Meiyappan, who was listed on Twitter (soon erased) as CSK ‘Team Principal’ and was a bidder at the IPL auctions, was also always present on the team-bench during matches.

Srinivasan’s contention therefore that he was a ‘honorary member’ of the team management and a mere ‘enthusiast’ elicited howls of derision and outrage from the cricket fraternity.

Srinivasan’s position was getting increasingly untenable and the original conflict of interest raised right at the start of the IPL about a BCCI official also being a team owner (through India Cements) had now come back to haunt him.

Amidst drama and intrigue so typical of murky BCCI politics, Srinivasan was eventually forced to ‘step aside’ till Gurunath’s name was cleared in a BCCI-appointed probe and the wily old fox of Indian cricket, Jagmohan Dalmiya made his umpteenth comeback, even if in a temporary capacity.

Subsequent events over the next two months are too complicated and fast-changing to record in a book. But a comment by Srinivasan in the course of a speech to students in Chennai in late July exposed his feudal attitude.

‘Why do you think people are jealous of CSK?’ he asked his young audience rhetorically. ‘It is because of Dhoni. There was a savage attack on me because I have Dhoni.’

The words also proved—if further proof was indeed needed—that cricketers post-IPL are now commodities to be bought and sold at the mere whim of fat-cat businessmen.

But at the height of the turmoil back in May, CSK found themselves under tremendous pressure and to make things worse for the captain, footage of alleged betting kingpin, failed actor Vindoo Dara Singh by the side of wife Sakshi during CSK games gave more fodder to the media.

Still, the IPL had to be played out even if under a cloud with every match—practically every delivery—now under intense scrutiny and

suspicion.

CSK brushed past MI in the first qualifier to make it to their fourth final in six editions, by far the best record of any franchise. In fact MI were the only team to beat them in both the group matches.

MI made it to their second final after beating Rajasthan Royals in the second qualifier but the final at Kolkata resembled a funeral rather than the climax of a cricket carnival.

In the event, a rare tactical error by Dhoni saw CSK finish on the losing side to give MI their maiden IPL crown. Chasing a modest 149 for their third title, Chennai crashed to 36 for 5 in the seventh over—soon to be 39 for 6--before their match-winning captain came to bat.

Despite Dhoni once again top scoring with 63 not out from 45 balls, it was not enough this time. There would be no last-over dramatics. At no stage did CSK look like they had their hearts in the chase with coach Stephen Fleming admitting before the final that his players were ‘stressed out.’

The innings petered out at 125 for 9, Mumbai were easy winners by 23 runs and Dhoni now had to face the flak for coming in so low down in the order at number seven when his side needed him the most.

It was CSK’s fourth consecutive final but the second in a row in which they finished on the losing side, something Dhoni is not accustomed to.

In the mad whirl that is the Indian cricket team’s schedule, the players barely had time to rest their tired limbs and now it was time to leave for England for what the ICC had decided was to be the final Champions Trophy, the 50-over tournament started in 1998 which India had never won outright.

But the heat was still on Dhoni and now it was his financial stake and that of some of his family members in the sports management firm, Rhiti Sports that a financial daily had uncovered which made for a pretty miserable fortnight for Indian cricket in general and Dhoni in particular.

That dreaded ‘conflict of interest’ issue now came to haunt him as three of the four India players on the company’s rolls, including Dhoni, were from CSK. Even the much-vaunted Rs. 200 crore deal he was said to have signed with Rhiti back in July 2010 now came under harsh scrutiny.

It was hardly the right frame of mind to be in before an international tournament and a stony-faced Dhoni was forced to stay mum at the press

conference prior to departure even as the media fired away with their probing questions. Even on landing in England, he was pushed to explain to the international media that he was in no position to discuss controversial matters at press briefings.

No wonder by now Dhoni's beard was showing more than a few telltale salt-and-pepper flecks. At least his famed head of hair was still intact unlike some of his recent illustrious predecessors! The Indian cricket captain's job is one of the most stressful in the world of sport, considering the relentless public and media scrutiny.

It was to the immense credit of the captain and his players that they were able to put all this behind them as they began the tournament with a bang.

Dhawan's maiden ODI ton and his century opening stand with Rohit Sharma powered India to 331 for 7 and despite some late resistance, South Africa were never really in the match at Cardiff.

It was the spin bowling of Jadeja, Raina and Ashwin that proved to be a revelation as they bowled 16 straight overs in the middle stages and conceded only 66 runs. It was an early indication of the surprising nature of the pitches in the tournament.

India assured themselves of a semifinal slot when they routed West Indies by 8 wickets in the next match at the Oval and it was Dhawan's second century on the trot and Jadeja's five wickets that knocked the stuffing out of the 2004 champions.

An India-Pakistan match anywhere in the world is always the most keenly anticipated and the Edgbaston game was no exception even though it was a dead one—India were through to the last four and Pakistan already eliminated.

Constant rain interruptions saw India's chase of Pakistan's 165 all out reduced to 102 in 22 overs and once again they sealed the deal by 8 wickets.

India's electric fielding was beginning to make waves and Dhoni was spot on when he said India were the best fielding side in the tournament. The young legs and fresh minds policy of the captain was beginning to pay rich dividends.

The semifinals at Cardiff saw a repeat of the 2011 World Cup final.

By now Indian victories by 8 wickets were becoming something of a habit and they did it again against Lanka this time—third time in a row—

in another dominating performance by the boys in blue. It meant Dhoni had needed to bat only once so far in the tournament and that was in the opening match against South Africa.

Dhawan had by now emerged as the star of the show with another commanding innings of 68, taking his tally to 332 runs at a 100-plus average.

The team was at its peak and facing up against England for the title was really a dream final—the world champs vs the hosts at Edgbaston.

That dream however almost turned into a nightmare for the organizers and fans due to the wretched weather which had bedeviled the tournament from the start.

With rain coming down in buckets, the ICC bent its own rules to extend the cut-off time in order to squeeze in 20 overs a side, the minimum requirement for a result.

India had twice been denied by rain in Colombo in 2002 against Sri Lanka and the title was shared back then. It almost happened again. But now ironically for the last final of this event it was down to a 20/20 shootout.

Both sides panicked. But crucially, India panicked a fraction less—and it was all thanks once again to their cool captain. Or Captain Cool.

How he pulled it off despite failing with the bat—his first duck in ODIs since October 2010—is now part of cricket's folklore.

Just as he had shocked one and all by bringing on Joginder Sharma for the last over of the inaugural World T-20 final against Pakistan in 2007, here again his rotation of the bowlers raised eyebrows.

It looked all over bar the shouting—by the smattering of English fans in the stands dominated by India supporters—when the hosts chasing India's shaky total of 129 for 7 cantered to 102 for four at the end of the 17th over with Ravi Bopara and Eoin Morgan in total control. There were three overs to go and 28 runs required—a stroll in the park for the well-set pair.

Then Dhoni repeated his stunner of 2007—he brought back Ishant (27 from three overs) for his fourth and final over despite the pitch aiding spin and Kumar and Yadav among the medium pacers having bowled far more economically at that stage.

First ball—dot ball; second ball, Morgan swings for 6; third—wide; fourth—wide again.

The match is slipping out of India's grasp. The fielders frown, a deathly hush falls over the ground.

Then the match turns in the space of two deliveries. Ishant holds his nerve, bowls a slower one, Morgan (33) mis-hits to midwicket and is caught by Ashwin.

Next ball, OUT! It's Ashwin the fielder again, Bopara out for 30 and by the end of the 18th over, 102 for four has miraculously changed to 111 for 6.

England can still do it. Instead, the final two overs of the match see fielders hovering round the bat, Jadeja and Ashwin turning the ball square and England's batsmen going into a blind panic.

Fifteen required from the final over, Stuart Broad and James Tredwell at the crease. Last ball, Tredwell swings and misses with six needed for victory. Dhoni leaps up and down in joy. . . and relief?

It's all over and the Indians are going berserk both on the field and in the stands. Just 15 minutes earlier they were staring defeat in the face. Till that fateful decision in the 18th over turned the match topsy-turvy.

Dhawan emerges the leading run scorer and Player of the Series, Jadeja the top wicket-taker. Already the team for the 2015 World Cup is shaping up well with Dhoni master of all he surveys.

There was barely enough time for the winning feeling to sink in for within 24 hours it was off to the Caribbean for the ODI series against the hosts and Lanka.

Dhoni would have been forgiven if he had asked for permission to fly home. Instead within a week of the Champions final, he was back on the field for India's opening match against West Indies.

But the strain had to tell. Not only did India lose by one wicket, they also lost their captain with a hamstring injury while batting. Dinesh Karthik took over behind the stumps and Kohli captained when Windies batted.

In the absence of their talismanic skipper, India were crushed by Lanka in their next match, came back to trounce Windies and then made it to the final when they beat Lanka by 81 runs.

All this while with Kohli captaining in his stead, Dhoni was prowling the boundary between treatment for his injury. Some questioned his presence, asking why he did not fly back home. Was he undermining his deputy? He could have celebrated his 32nd birthday on July 7—four days

before the final--with his family in Ranchi instead of in distant Port of Spain. But Dhoni was determined to be fit for the final—and he was.

Missing those three matches might have been a blessing after all. After the opener at Kingston, Dhoni since his ODI debut on 23 December 2004 had played a total of 352 days of Test cricket, 225 ODIs, 42 T20 Internationals, 96 IPL games (20/20), 14 in the Champions League (20/20) and 90 other days of cricket.

It all added up to a mind boggling 819 days in the field. Add in the days for travelling and it was a marvel Dhoni was still able to stand on his feet after nine years of the grind, let alone continue to bat, keep wickets, captain and win matches galore.

In those nine years he had missed eight Test matches, as well as 27 ODIs, three T-20 Internationals and three in the IPL and Champions League, either due to injury or enforced rest.

Now it was India vs Sri Lanka once again in a tri-series final, this time at Port of Spain and his teammates and fans were mighty relieved to see Dhoni back on the field.

And what a match it turned out to be, a Dhoni special if ever there was one!

Lanka's 201 all out should not have been much of a challenge. But though opener Rohit Sharma held the first half of the innings together with a cautious 58, his departure at 139 for 4 in the 32nd over brought Dhoni in at a tricky stage of the innings.

With the captain looking on helplessly at the other end, wickets now began to tumble with Raina, Jadeja and Ashwin going in quick succession and at 152 for 7 in the 38th over, Dhoni found himself with only the tail-enders for company.

When last man Ishant walked in the equation was daunting—one wicket in hand, 20 runs for victory and 22 deliveries to get them in.

Nerves were getting shredded as Dhoni barked orders to Ishant who had to face the entire penultimate over from Angelo Mathews from which he eked out two runs. But crucially, Dhoni was on strike for the final over from Shaminda Eranga—15 runs needed.

A stroll in the park? Yes, it was for the master finisher. First ball—a swing and a miss. Second ball, out of the ground, it's a six! Third ball—four.

Five needed now, but it's a formality. The fourth ball is smashed over extra cover for another 6 and Dhoni has done it again—victory by one wicket with two deliveries left in the match.

Pandemonium on the ground, the Indian players and their supporters can hardly believe it. It's that Midas touch again. Captain Cool has now turned into Captain Ice-Cool.

'I think I am blessed with a bit of good cricketing sense,' the beaming Man of the Match says at the presentation ceremony in a classic understatement. 'I knew I could get 15 runs off the last over.'

The statistics that now emerge are mind boggling and confirm Dhoni as ODI's greatest-ever finisher. His average in successful chases is 100.09 in 72 wins at the strike rate of 89.63. He also has the highest average (52.45) by far of any player while batting second. And the clincher—in 33 matches in which he remains unbeaten and takes India to victory, his strike-rate of 93.75 is the world's best.

Amongst all the heady post-final analysis, there was a masterly piece by Sandeep Dwivedi in *The Indian Express* (19 July 2013).

Writing under the heading 'Dhoni's Finishing Act, the Magic and the Math', Dwivedi explained Dhoni's 'agenda in tight games is to be alive till the final over for that all-or-nothing face-off with the death bowler. It isn't so much a gamble as a dare.'

Former Test batsman Sanjay Manjrekar was meanwhile left scratching his head for an explanation. 'Hopefully one day he might allow someone to get into his head and we may get to know how his brain ticks. . .'

The closest anyone has gotten 'into his head' is probably famed sports psychologist Dr. Rudi V. Webster. Interviewed for Dr Webster's book, *Think Like a Champion* (HarperCollins Publishers India) Dhoni explained how he copes with pressure situations.

'I love the challenge and the pressure. They have always pushed me to do well. . . .Pressure to me is just added responsibility. . . .It's not pressure when God gives you an opportunity to be a hero for your team and country.'

Amidst all the euphoria came the tragic news that one of Mahi's closest friends and the one who taught him the now-famous 'helicopter' shot, Jharkhand Ranji Trophy player Santosh Lal had passed away from

pancreatitis in a Delhi hospital at the young age of 32—the same age as his best buddy.

Dhoni had taken a much-needed holiday in New York and was monitoring his friend's condition and had ensured he was flown from Ranchi to Delhi for the best treatment. But it was too late. Always a loyal friend to his Ranchi mates, the news was heart-breaking for India's captain and must have taken away the sweet taste of victory.

Much of the rest of 2013 was overshadowed by the news that Sachin Tendulkar would be ending his storied 24-year international career with his 200th and final Test match against West Indies at Mumbai's Wankhede Stadium where his first-class career had begun in 1988.

As expected the visitors posed little challenge and were crushed by an innings in both the Tests and beaten 2-1 in the ODI series.

But before that was the tough grind of seven ODIs at home to world champions Australia with a series of record breaking scores which India won 3-2 (one 'no-result'; one abandoned). And among the mountain of runs—nine centuries by both sides—was Rohit Sharma's double century in the decider at Bengaluru and Dhoni's unbeaten 139 in a losing cause in the third game at Mohali. India also pocketed the lone T20 at Rajkot.

The year ended with India once again failing to win a Test or ODI series in South Africa since their first tour in 1992. And there was not much joy for Dhoni in the Champions League either with CSK losing in the semifinals to Rajasthan Royals at Jaipur in October.



CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Bolt from the Blue!

WINSTON CHURCHILL'S DESCRIPTION of the Soviet Union: 'a riddle wrapped in a mystery inside an enigma' perhaps best summed up Dhoni's reign as captain—a record 27 wins against 18 defeats in 60 Tests—and this rang truest on his last day as a Test cricketer in Australia at the fag-end of 2014.

Dhoni missed the first Test at Adelaide; he was back for the second at Brisbane—a second successive defeat which meant the Border-Gavaskar Trophy was relinquished—and then he saw India to a draw in the third at Melbourne.

Minutes after the obligatory and for Dhoni, seemingly dreary press conference at the end of the last day, Dhoni walked away and then came the bombshell of the press release from the BCCI announcing he had not only quit the Test captaincy, he had also played his 90th and final Test match. And this with one Test left in the series, a shocking but not quite unprecedented action in the annals of Test cricket.

It was breaking news on TV channels all night and the ire of most of the panelists—and certainly the anchors—was directed at the now ex-captain for 'abandoning' his floundering team.

In typical Dhoni sphinx-like style an explanation for the shock decision was not and may never be forthcoming. The BCCI release was predictably bland though it did mention 'the strain of playing all formats'.

Not only playing but captaining, keeping wickets and making vital contributions with the bat in Test, ODI and T20 Internationals as well in the IPL (and Champions League) for CSK. Just how much strain could one player take?

The first wicket-keeper to lead India in Test cricket, it was ironical that in his final Test he should establish the Indian record for nine dismissals in a match (since broken by Saha with 10 catches in the Cape Town Test in January 2018) and finish with the most runs for India while captaining.

Despite holding the record for most Test wins for an Indian captain, his overseas record was dismal. In his final year, the only bright spark was the victory at Lord's in England. But even that did not do much to ease the pain of a 3-1 defeat. And the ignominy of 2011-12 when India were whitewashed 4-0 both in England and Australia never really went away.

Dhoni's defensive style of captaincy in Tests was starkly different from his gung-ho methods in the limited overs version. Too often he let Tests drift, failing to go for the kill and always gave the impression that the five-day version was not his cup of tea.

Credit though must be given to Dhoni for making the dressing room a happy place and being loyal to his teammates and receiving the same loyalty in return. In the fractious world of Indian cricket that was no mean thing.

Even two years later in his *Sportstar* column (21 January, 2017) Sunil Gavaskar had yet to get over the shock decision: 'Quitting is the only way to describe it, for with the team losing and the pressure getting too much he wanted no responsibility. And to leave a Test series with one Test still left was not something expected of him.'

Nearly a year after the shock announcement the question was asked at a press conference in Sri Lanka as to how the transition of the Test captaincy from Dhoni to Kohli had been going and team director Ravi Shastri came up with the clearest explanation so far: 'I think that was one of the reasons why MS decided to quit. You know he realised that there are three formats of the game. It is becoming hard for him. But at the time he knew there was someone ready. Now if you think back, you will know why he made that decision. It was a good decision because it was clear in everyone's mind, across the media that this is your future captain and let him captain in that last Test match in Australia so that all speculation goes

to rest. Because India weren't playing a Test for another six, seven months. You know the obvious choice was Virat but by announcing his retirement, he made it clear that I believe this guy is ready and he needs a run.'

Indeed the strain from the poor results and wear-and-tear on the captain's body was beginning to show at the start of the year itself.

India's abysmal record in New Zealand—just one series victory since the initial tour win in 1967-68—continued in 2014 with Kiwi captain Brendon McCullum leading the charge with 224 in the home side's win by 40 runs in the first Test at Auckland and a record breaking triple century in the second drawn Test at Wellington. There was no success in the ODI series either, though Dhoni's batting at least could not be faulted with scores of 40, 56, 50, 79 (not out) and 47. It should be noted that though the team returned without a single win, it was a young side that was just beginning to establish itself after the retirements of the big guns of Tendulkar and co.

A side strain which he picked up at Wellington kept Dhoni out of the Asia Cup in Bangladesh in February 2014 and then just before the tour Down Under late in the year, he suffered a hairline crack in the right thumb which forced him to miss the last two ODIs at home against Sri Lanka in November having earlier taken a rest for the first three. That same injury kept him out of the first Test in Brisbane too.

The news that he would miss the Asia Cup saw Ian Chappell in his column call for Dhoni's removal from the Test captaincy, criticizing him for setting defensive fields and 'letting things drift' in the Wellington Test which allowed McCullum to lead the rearguard action. So when the decision was finally made on December 30, 2014 it should not have come as a total surprise.

That thumb injury had occurred in the course of India winning the truncated ODI series at home to West Indies 2-1 with the visitors boycotting the last match due to a pay dispute with their board.

On the 2014 tour of England that victory in the second Test at Lord's was the only redeeming feature as India were once again soundly beaten in the series. Indeed after the draw in the first Test at Trent Bridge, Indian cricket fans must have been rubbing their eyes in disbelief as they led the five-Test series 1-0 with hopes being raised of erasing the 4-0 whitewash in 2011.

Those hopes were sadly belied. But Lord's did provide a glimmer of hope and joy as India's opening bowlers Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Ishant Sharma beat England at their own game on a pitch tailor-made for the home side's bowlers. And on the final day with England needing 214 runs with six wickets in hand, it took all of the captain's persuasion to force Sharma to keep pitching it short. The batsmen fell for it hook, line and sinker so it was no wonder at the end of a dramatic day, the Man of the Match said, 'I think all these wickets are not for me, it is for the captain. He told me, "you are tall enough, you have to bowl the bouncer," that's what I did and it worked for me.'

So how did things go so horribly wrong in the next three Tests, all won with ridiculous ease by England? For one, India lost their spearhead Sharma for the third and fourth matches through injury. Then the runs scored by opener Murali Vijay and the rest dried up and even useful batting by Dhoni was not enough to paper over the cracks that suddenly opened up. The catching too was atrocious.

The dispute between Jimmy Anderson and Ravindra Jadeja that dragged on and on was certainly an unwanted distraction. But what could possibly account for the dire capitulation in the fourth Test at Old Trafford—losing their first four wickets in the first innings with just eight runs on the board and falling for 152 and 161 in the two innings? This after England drew level, winning the third Test at Southampton by 266 runs.

Could it get any worse? It could and did and the final nail in the coffin was hammered in the fifth and final Test at the Oval as the batting collapsed once again, this time for 148—82 from Dhoni's bat alone!—and 94 all out and now no one, least of all the captain himself had any answers even as he dropped dark hints that his Test career may be coming to an end.

The meek men in white suddenly turned into the bully boys in blue as they easily won the ODI series 3-1 and despite the narrow loss in the lone T20I, these were crumbs of comfort as the side once again returned from a foreign venture with defeat in the Test matches that really count.

Just three months later came the bombshell from the captain. So did he jump before he was pushed? Perhaps we will never know!



CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Lodha Bombshell

IF INDIAN CRICKET was rocked at the end of 2014 by Dhoni's decision to quit Test cricket in the midst of the series Down Under, 2015 saw yet another bombshell being dropped—the banning of Chennai Super Kings (CSK) and Rajasthan Royals (RR) from the IPL for two years (2016 and 2017) due to the illegal activities of two of its team principals.

This verdict was delivered by the Supreme Court-appointed Justice R.M. Lodha Committee—carrying on the fine groundwork done by Justice Mukul Mudgal—in New Delhi in front of one of the largest gatherings I have witnessed at a sports press conference.

There was a smattering of muted applause from the press gang when the announcement came and before it could even sink in, I found myself surrounded by TV reporters asking me for my views for their news channels. Like almost everyone both in the media as well as followers of Indian cricket—save for diehard fans of CSK and RR—I heartily welcomed the verdict, even though I would have preferred life bans.

Unheralded RR had stunned one and all by winning the inaugural IPL title in 2008 due to the inspiring leadership skills of Shane Warne. As for CSK, with Dhoni at the helm, they were by far the most successful team in the IPL mix and barely two months before the news of their banning CSK

had reached the final for the sixth time where they were beaten by Mumbai Indians.

That was the fourth time they had finished runners-up, to go with their two titles in 2010 and 2011, an outstanding record and a great tribute to Dhoni in particular. No wonder he had cemented his place as Chennai's favourite cricketing son. But now they along with RR would be forced to cool their heels for two years.

In on-field action, the focus was on the World Cup where India would be defending their title for only the second time since 1987 as the mega-event returned to Australia/New Zealand after twenty-three years.

The ODI tri-series with hosts Australia and England was handy as a warm-up for the World Cup and although India finished winless—losing twice to England, once to Australia and with just one point from a washed out no-result—it did allow the management to experiment with various team permutations and combinations.

It seemed to work like a charm. In the World Cup, Dhoni astutely used the pace and bounce of his bowlers to huge advantage and India were the only team to bowl out their opponents in every one of their seven matches—till they came up against joint hosts and four-time champions Australia in the semifinals.

India's campaign began with a high-octane match against Pakistan at Adelaide and that winning streak from the 1992 World Cup against their arch-rivals continued for the sixth time. After Virat Kohli's 107, it was opening bowlers Mohammed Shami and Mohit Sharma—replacing the unfit Ishant Sharma in the squad—who rocked the Pakistan batting and helped India canter home by 76 runs.

It was even easier in the next game against South Africa with opener Shikhar Dhawan this time leading the way with 137. The bowling was tight and the fielding was brilliant as South Africa folded for 170, losing by 130 runs.

UAE were brushed aside by nine wickets and by the time India faced West Indies, a certain slackness had crept in. The twice champions were rolled over for 182 and though things looked a bit shaky for India at 134 for 6, Dhoni coolly took his side home by six wickets with 45 not out.

After four wins on the trot in Australia, the Indians crossed the Tasman where Ireland hardly provided a challenge as Dhawan's second

century saw them canter home by eight wickets. The team was now on a roll and looking to be serious challengers to retain their title.

Oddly, the biggest challenge came from lowly Zimbabwe at Auckland. Their captain Brendan Taylor had announced his international retirement at the end of the tournament (he would reverse his decision two years later) and marked his final match with an outstanding century that took his side to a challenging 287. India then stumbled to 92 for four before Suresh Raina (110 not out) and Dhoni (85 not out) saw them to victory by six wickets with eight balls to spare and India had now reached the knockout quarterfinals with the greatest of ease.

The clash of the South Asians at Melbourne saw India take on Bangladesh and for more than half the Indian innings it was the Bangladesh bowlers who kept the stranglehold. When Ajinkya Rahane was third out in the 28th over there were just 115 runs on the board.

The match was plunged into controversy with opener Rohit Sharma receiving two reprieves from the umpires and it was his 137 that finally saw the team post an imposing 302 for 6. It was then left to fast bowler Umesh Yadav and the rest to roll over Bangladesh for 193—and it was now India vs Australia for a place in the final while co-hosts New Zealand were taking on South Africa, neither country having ever made it to the final before.

It turned into a no-contest. Australia opted to bat first and it was once again Steve Smith, who had smashed the Indian bowlers for four centuries in the four Tests in the preceding series who continued his domination with 105. Australia's 328 for 7 was always going to be a bridge too far and the Indians bowed out by 95 runs, captain Dhoni top scoring with a futile 65.

Australia claimed their fifth title and fourth in the last five tournaments when they crushed New Zealand by seven wickets in the final at Melbourne.

So India, the defending champions and the form team leading into the semifinals were left to lick their wounds, losing in the semifinals just as they had in 1987 when they last defended their title.

One would have thought some of the leading players including Dhoni were better left behind at home to rest for the tour of Bangladesh that followed a couple of months after the World Cup. They certainly deserved

the break. In the event it was a full-strength team that drew the rain ruined one-off Test and then received a shock in the ODI series.

There was plenty of needle with the home supporters still sore over what they at least perceived as a controversial World Cup quarter-final. And the surprise package was debutant medium pacer Mustafizur Rahman. The teenager ripped through the Indian batting in both the first and second ODIs with figures of 5 for 50 and 6 for 43 for a world record 11 wickets in his first two internationals.

Dhoni found himself in the news for the wrong reasons in the first match at Mirpur when he barged into Mustafizur as he crossed for a run and found the debutant blocking his path. The result was a fine for both—50 per cent of his match fee for the bowler and 75 per cent for the Indian captain.

The whitewash was avoided with a consolation win by 77 runs in the third and final ODI but despite useful batting by Dhoni, murmurs over his captaincy had begun. Was it time now for one captain—Virat Kohli—to take charge in all three formats?

These murmurs grew louder when South Africa visited India and won a closely contested series 3-2. The visitors also won both the T20I matches (one washed out), though they were outclassed in the Test series that followed.

After losing the first at Kanpur by five runs, Dhoni led from the front with 92 not out from 86 balls at Indore to make it 1-1. South Africa took the lead again at Rajkot and after India made it 2-2 at Chennai, it was down to the decider at Mumbai.

It turned out to be a rout as South Africa piled up a mammoth 438 for four, three batsmen scoring centuries for only the second time in ODI history. The highest ODI total on Indian soil was simply too much for the Indian batsmen who were crushed by 214 runs.

It was an unusual and uncomfortable scenario for the fans to witness their heroes lose both a T20I and ODI series at home. Was Dhoni's crown beginning to wobble just that bit?



CHAPTER NINETEEN

Sorcery and Surrealism

FEW CRICKET MATCHES are decided by a sprint, much less the oldest player on the ground taking on and beating a sprightly 21-year-old.

But Dhoni at 34 proved he was still among the fittest around when he pulled off the spectacular in the 2016 World T20 match against Bangladesh at Bengaluru.

In my over fifty years of watching live sports, starting with the 1966 World Cup football when I lived in England, few matches could have been so heart-stopping as India's one-run victory which kept its hopes alive in the tournament.

How did this last-ball miracle come about? First it was the Bangla bowling that strangled India's batsmen and restricted them to 146 for 7.

The Bangla batsmen kept their nerve and with three wickets in hand and eleven runs to win, came the final over from Hardik Pandya. A single from the first ball, then two boundaries by Mushfiquir Rahim and the fist pumping celebrations had begun. After all it would be a cakewalk from now on—just two runs to win, three wickets and three deliveries in hand.

Then Pandya struck twice—Mushfiquir out for 11, Mahmudallah next ball for 18 and now it had come down to the last ball—one wicket in hand, one run to tie and force a Super Over, two to win.

Captain Dhoni threw off his right glove, knowing full well the batsmen would scramble for a bye, come what may. Pandya bowled outside Shuvagata Hom's reach, the ball was in Dhoni's right hand but instead of taking a chance with a throw, he sprinted fifteen yards and beat last man Mustafizur Rahman by inches.

Three wickets from the last three balls of the final over of the match—it was a Houdini act to beat all Houdini acts! Undoubtedly, the Bangladesh batsmen got ahead of themselves after those two boundaries and thought the match was in the bag. It was a fatal act of over-confidence and Dhoni was not one to let them off the hook. Earlier, two amazing stumpings had kept India in the hunt.

After the match Dhoni spoke of the 'chaos' towards the end. 'What you are trying to do is you're trying to manage chaos', he explained. And who better to do that but 'Captain Cool' himself?!

The Bengaluru miracle was India's get-out-of-jail card. Two defeats out of three would have severely dented their hopes of making it to the semifinals, unthinkable for the hosts and home of the IPL.

That first defeat had come in the opening match at Nagpur where a spin-friendly pitch badly misfired on India as New Zealand stunned the former world champions by 47 runs. The Kiwi spinners picked up nine Indian wickets and unheralded left-arm spinner Mitchell Santner had four as India crumbled to 79 all out. It meant that India had never beaten New Zealand in the five T20Is they had played so far.

Sanity for Indian fans was restored when Pakistan were beaten for the eleventh time in eleven World Cup encounters—both 50-over and 20-over versions—in front of an ecstatic full house at Kolkata's Eden Gardens.

The semifinal slot was sealed as Virat Kohli's sublime form continued with a majestic 82 not out from 51 balls seeing India home by six wickets with five balls to spare, Dhoni playing the rare supporting role.

It was Kohli who had helped paper over the cracks in the Indian batting and these were finally exposed in the semifinal against West Indies at Mumbai. India's challenging total of 192 for 2 was built round Kohli's 89 not out from 47 balls, full of scampered singles and twos. That West Indies got home with two deliveries to spare was due to the fact that they dealt largely in boundaries and this tilted the scales in their favour and helped the once-kings of limited-overs cricket clinch the final too in amazing fashion against England at Kolkata.

For India it was a disappointing end to a disappointing tournament and meant their lone World T20 title remained in the 2007 inaugural edition, the year before the advent of the game-changing IPL.

It would later turn out to be the last time Dhoni would lead India in a World Cup match, starting from that epochal event back in South Africa in 2007 and sadly the India captain hardly covered himself in glory off the field either.

Irrked by the constant questions from the media surrounding his 'future plans' or rather retirement, something snapped at the end of the semifinal and it was a sorry sight to see the normally placid Dhoni publicly humiliate an Australian journalist who dared broach the subject at the post-match press conference.

Dhoni had snapped earlier too when an Indian journalist asked him about the team's poor run-rate and if it would adversely affect their semifinal chances after the close shave at Bengaluru, unnecessarily accusing the reporter of being 'disappointed' at India's victory.

The preparation prior to the World T20 was yet another India/Australia ODI and T20I series, this time Down Under. And it was another run fest with both sides crossing 300 in four of the five ODIs which India lost 1-4. It was a 3-0 clean sweep for India in the T20I series with Dhoni sharp as ever with the big gloves.

The Asia Cup, reduced for the first time from 50 to 20 overs, was the final tune-up and India took the title, romping past Bangladesh, Pakistan, Sri Lanka and UAE with ease before beating hosts Bangladesh again by eight wickets in the final at Dhaka.

That should have warmed them up nicely for the World T20, but it was not to be. India fell flat and their dream of winning a second world title at home in five years under Dhoni were dashed.

The rest of 2016 was somewhat anti-climatic even as the clamour rose for Kohli to take over as captain in all three formats. It was also marked by the release of the biopic *M.S. Dhoni: The Untold Story* with Sushant Singh Rajput in the title role. The movie began and ended with the winning six from the 2011 World Cup final and his life story in between was neatly depicted. The 'untold' part was Dhoni's brief but tragic romance with the late Priyanka Jha whose untimely death almost derailed the Dhoni story before it began and which had not been public knowledge

till it was revealed on screen. I gave it an eight out of ten ranking in my review for a cricket website.

In fact there was a surreal air around the period following the World T20 as Dhoni first found himself in the awkward position of captaining a new franchise, Rising Pune Supergiants (RPS) in the IPL for the first time while CSK served out their two-year ban. He had guided CSK to at least the playoffs in all eight previous seasons. But his new franchise was beset by injury problems and put up a feeble show. Perhaps Dhoni's heart was not in it as he knew the stint with RPS would be for just two years before CSK returned in 2018.

The surreal air continued in Zimbabwe where Dhoni was back for the first time in eleven years, having been rested for all the visits in-between. His only previous trip was in 2005 as a rookie when he was still in his first twelve months of international cricket.

Now he was back as captain and senior member shepherding a team of youngsters. So much more than just his hairstyle had changed over the past eleven years.

Dhoni was not required to bat in the three ODIs which India won barely breaking a sweat. But at practice sessions he was everywhere, encouraging his young bowlers and placing a guiding hand on their shoulders. It was somewhat incongruous to see a rejuvenated Dhoni in one of international cricket's backwaters as even the home fans chanted his name and mobbed him for selfies. But it only went to show that even after all these years of travelling round the world, the fire still burned inside.

That fire however was nearly extinguished in the first of the T20Is. Zimbabwe pulled off a stunning two-run win as the master finisher was unable to hit a boundary off the final ball of the match—his specialty—from pace bowler Neville Madziva. There was fury written over Dhoni's face as he stormed off the ground in disgust.

The second match was a no-contest, India winning by 10 wickets but the third also went down to the wire. This time it was Zimbabwe who had to hit a final ball boundary but failed as young pace bowler Barinder Sran, in only his second international held his nerve, guided all the way by his captain who was struggling with blurred vision after being struck in the eye by a flying bail.

Talk about surreal—the Indian team landed in the United States for the first time in August for two T20Is against newly-crowned world

champions West Indies.

And what a match the first one turned out to be—Windies' massive 245 for 6 was built round a hurricane century by Ewin Lewis. K.L. Rahul replied in kind and his unbroken century stand with Dhoni for the fifth wicket saw India needing eight runs from the last over bowled by Dwayne Bravo—two off the last ball and sure enough Dhoni was caught going for the winning run! The match aggregate of 489 runs was a world record.

Unfortunately, the second match was declared 'no result' under farcical circumstances as the match started 40 minutes late due to a glitch in the satellite feed for the transmission of the match. Windies struggled to 143 for 6 this time and India could only bat two overs before a thunderstorm ended the match. Only three more overs were required for a result and thus what would end up as Dhoni's final T20I in charge fell flat.

New Zealand locked 2-2 with India on our own turf going into the fifth and final ODI at Visakhapatnam? Surreal indeed! But India won the decider by 190 runs and Dhoni ended his final ODI as captain (as would be revealed a couple of months later) in the same city where he first exploded on the international scene with a rousing 148 against Pakistan in only his fifth ODI back in 2005.

The series was notable for the captain promoting himself to No. 4 in the batting order from the third ODI at Mohali and scoring 80, 11 and 41 in those last three matches, the move necessitated as he admitted by his waning powers as a finisher. And what glove work! There were two quicksilver stumpings at Mohali and at Ranchi he pulled off his unique behind-the-back run out flick to send Ross Taylor packing.

In *The Sportstar* (November 12, 2016) in an analysis titled 'He Still has a Lot Left in the Tank', Shreedutta Chidananda wrote correctly: 'Any discussion on Dhoni's exit, however, should first answer the question of not who will replace Dhoni, the batsman, but who will replace Dhoni, the wicket-keeper-batsman. It must not be forgotten that even at 35, Ranchi's favourite son is unspeakably brilliant behind the stumps.' And as the writer further pointed out, 'as decent as Wriddhiman Saha is, he is not in Dhoni's league; and lest we forget, the Bengal keeper is already 32.'

That should have settled the debate as to Dhoni's future in the team. Or would it?



CHAPTER TWENTY

Target: 2019

IF DHONI'S DECISION to step down from the Test captaincy and from Test cricket altogether midway through the series in Australia had come as a shock at the end of 2014, his giving up the ODI and T20I captaincy at the start of 2017 hardly caused ripples.

His record was excellent: Dhoni had captained India in 199 ODIs, winning 110 and losing 74 (Tied: 4; NR: 11). He was captain in 72 T20Is, of which India won 41 and lost 28 (Tied: 1; NR: 2). Victory in the 2011 World Cup and 2013 Champions Trophy and 2007 World T20 were the jewels in the crown, making Dhoni the only captain to win the ICC's coveted triple crown over a golden ten year period for India in white ball cricket.

The announcement came on the eve of England's visit to India to play three ODIs and two T20Is and paved the way for Virat Kohli to captain in all three formats.

A week after the announcement he gave his reasons at a press conference in Pune: 'Right from the start, when I left Test captainship, I knew split captaincy doesn't work in India, doesn't work in our set-up. I was waiting for the right time. I wanted Virat to ease into the Test format. With so many games, I feel he is right there. With this kind of decision, there is no wrong decision in it. It is just the timing. I feel this is the time.'

The India-England ODI series was yet another run feast with all six innings crossing 300 runs and India coming out 2-1 winners. The first at Pune saw Indian overhauling England's huge 350 for 7 with three wickets and eleven balls to spare.

It was vintage batting from two of India's most experienced hands, Dhoni and his old comrade-in-arms Yuvraj Singh that saw India pile up a massive 381 for 6 in the second at Cuttack. And though England fought till the end, they still fell short by fifteen runs.

Their 256-run partnership from 230 balls for the fourth wicket, coming in with India 25 for three, saw Yuvraj smash 150 from 127 balls and Dhoni 134 from 122, his 10th ODI century. The innings also saw him become the first Indian to hit 200 ODI sixes—there were six in this knock.

There was some consolation for England at Kolkata, but Kohli's first full series as official captain was a success as India also won the T20I series 2-1.

India's top players have often been criticised for ignoring the domestic circuit. But with the packed international calendar and especially the advent of the IPL in peak summer since 2008, squeezing in any more matches has been a near-impossibility.

Not for Dhoni though. He surprised one and all, including his Jharkhand teammates by leading the side in the Vijay Hazare 50-overs tournament and proved an inspiration to the youngsters, travelling with them by train. Jharkhand reached the semi-finals largely on the strength of the batting and captaincy of their superstar.

That was just before the 10th season of the IPL where Dhoni faced the ignominy of being replaced as captain of Rising Pune Supergiant (the 's' was dropped apparently for numerology reasons) by Australian skipper Steve Smith. The reasons trotted out were not exactly complimentary to Dhoni and the franchise ownership had to face the ire of his fans on social media right through the tournament.

Having finished second from last in 2016, this was the last season for the stopgap franchise as Chennai Super Kings and Rajasthan Royals would be back from their two-year ban in 2018.

From seventh in 2016 to runners-up in 2017 was indeed a huge improvement. And in the final at Hyderabad they faced the agony of losing to Mumbai Indians by a solitary run! Dhoni, one could sense was just itching to get back into the yellow of CSK in 2018.

A six-week T20 bash may not have been the ideal warm-up for the Champions Trophy in England. But as the defending champions from 2013 when it was also staged in England and as the number one ODI team in the world, the Indians went into the event as the hot favourites to retain their title.

Pakistan were hammered in the opening game at Edgbaston and though there was a shock defeat at the hands of Sri Lanka in the next match, South Africa were then routed by eight wickets and India were in the semi-finals against Bangladesh.

This too turned out to be a no-contest and much against the form book, it was an India-Pakistan final for the first time in an ICC tournament since the inaugural World T20 in South Africa ten years earlier.

Pakistan rode their luck well to reach the semis where they outplayed hosts England and now in the final at the Oval a marginal no-ball by the unfortunate Jasprit Bumrah in the fourth over saw Fakhar Zaman recalled after edging a catch behind to Dhoni.

The opener did not look back after that and his barnstorming 114 took Pakistan to a formidable 338 for four.

Now it was the turn of another left hander, Mohammad Amir to scythe through India's top order batting and leave them gasping with half the side out and with just 54 on the board.

There was no way back after that though Hardik Pandya's sensational 76 gave India faint hope before his bungled run out saw India slide to 158 all out, leaving Pakistan victors by a mammoth 180 runs in one of the biggest upsets in recent years. Pakistan after all were ranked eighth coming into the tournament and just about qualified as the last team in the event.

It was a bitter pill to swallow for skipper Kohli and the Indian cricket fraternity even as Pakistan basked in their newfound glory. And the defeat claimed a major victim when coach Anil Kumble stepped down, apparently due to his fractured relationship with captain Kohli.

However, in the non-stop treadmill of matches that cricketers traverse these days it was just five days after the ignominious defeat that Kohli and Co. were back in the thick of action, this time in West Indies.

India won the ODI series 3-1 but though Dhoni was Man of the Match for his top score of 78 not out in the third match at North Sound,

Antigua which saw India win by 93 runs, it was the very next match at the same venue that saw his batting come under intense scrutiny.

Dhoni initially struggled during his unbeaten 78 and his first 50 took an uncharacteristically slow 66 balls. He stepped up the pace after that with the next 28 runs coming from 13 deliveries.

India had the chance to wrap up the series in the fourth match but instead stumbled to a shock defeat by 11 runs after West Indies had been kept down to a measly total of 189 for 9 from their 50 overs.

That India were shot out for 178 in the 50th over was shocking enough but what raised eyebrows was Dhoni struggling to 54 from 114 balls at the miserable strike rate of 47.36. The 108 deliveries needed to reach 50 made it the slowest ODI half-century by an Indian batsman in 16 years.

The pitch was low and slow and the bowling was spirited. But to see India failing to score 16 runs from the last two overs—Dhoni out to the last ball of the 49th over—was bewildering to all including Dhoni who retreated into a shell after returning to the pavilion. One report described him as ‘a broken man’ and the whispers about him losing his prowess as a finisher were now reaching a crescendo, a tad unfairly and prematurely. But such is in the intense scrutiny Dhoni has found himself under in recent years, something only Sachin Tendulkar faced in the twilight of his illustrious career.

Even chief selector M.S.K. Prasad—himself a wicket-keeper—weighed in on the eve of the tour to Sri Lanka with heavy hints that Dhoni’s place was not guaranteed for the 2019 World Cup in England.

‘We don’t say it is automatic, but we will see. We all want the Indian team to do well. If he [Dhoni] is delivering, why not? If he is not, we will have to look at alternatives.’

The veiled statement was aimed more at Dhoni’s batting rather than his fitness or keeping skills which were still world class.

So how did Dhoni react? Not a word escaped his lips; instead he turned in a brilliant batting performance even as India made it a 5-0 clean sweep in the ODI series in Lanka in which Dhoni reached the landmark of 300 matches (including three for Asia XI in June 2007).

The first match was a cakewalk, India winning by nine wickets. But in the second at Pallekele it was Lanka’s off spinner turned leg spinner Akila Dhananjaya who caught the Indian batsmen unawares.

Replying to the host's 236 for eight, India were cruising as openers Rohit Sharma and Shikhar Dhawan added 109 before the mystery spinner struck—and how.

Seven wickets crumbled for just 22 runs with Dhananjaya grabbing six of these in 20 deliveries and at 131 for 7 it looked like curtains for the Indians.

That set the stage for one of the most amazing rearguard actions in ODI history as Dhoni found an able ally in pace bowler Bhuvneshwar Kumar batting at number nine.

There were plenty of overs in hand as the unlikely pair first sought to keep out Dhananjaya before slowly and steadily wresting control.

The century partnership was the first for India for the eighth wicket in ODIs and what was remarkable was that towards the end it was Bhuvneshwar (53 not out) who took on the attacking role as Dhoni looked on in admiration.

His 45 not out from 68 balls contained just one boundary, every run carved out coolly and calmly even as he initially guided the tail-ender. That he then gladly took a back seat and allowed his junior partner free rein showed that this giant of Indian cricket was even at this late stage of his career able to put ego behind him and prove he had no hang-ups.

Now the tributes poured in with coach Ravi Shastri stating categorically, 'Dhoni is not even half finished yet. If anyone thinks so, they are mistaken and they have another one coming.' In a fitting riposte to Prasad's pre-tour remarks Shastri went on: 'Dhoni is the best limited overs keeper in the country. Just because he has played for so many years, you are thinking about a replacement?' It was a rhetorical question at best!

He was back in the rescue act in the next match as well. This time the score read 61 for four in reply to 217 for 9 and it was Dhoni (67 not out) with opener Sharma (124 not out) who saw them safely home.

The series was in the bag but India did not take their foot off the pedal. 375 for 5 was their total in the fourth match at Colombo, another century from Sharma, captain Kohli scoring one as well and 49 not out by Dhoni as the icing on the cake. Though the fifth match was a mere formality, it marked a personal landmark for Dhoni—the first to achieve 100 stumpings in ODIs (Dhananjaya off Yuzvendra Chahal's bowling), going past Sri Lanka's Kumar Sangakkara's 99.

This brought into focus Dhoni's lightning quick reflexes standing up to the spinners where a batsman gets beaten as he goes forward, steps fractionally outside the crease, and before he can even realise what has happened, the bails are whipped off in a flash and he has to head back a chastened man.

It was now the turn of Prasad to narrate a story while speaking at a function in Chennai shortly before the arrival of the Australians in India for yet another series of limited overs matches that summed up Dhoni's never-say-die spirit.

It was before the crucial match against Pakistan in the Asia Cup in Dhaka in 2016 that Dhoni suffered a mishap while training in the gym and had to be stretchered off.

Despite struggling to walk the night before the match, he declared himself fit, telling Prasad 'even on one leg I will play against Pakistan.' He duly led India to victory in the match.

India completed yet another ODI victory when they beat reigning world champions Australia 4-1. It was Dhoni's opportunity to consolidate his place in the side, not that it should have ever been in doubt and here he added another string to his bow.

When Dhoni at the start of 2017 announced he would be stepping down as captain in white-ball cricket, allowing Kohli to lead in all three formats, the new captain noted how he knew he could rely on his wicket-keeper for sound advice on the field. Dhoni himself noted how the 'keeper is like a vice-captain as he is best suited to analyse the game from his vantage point behind the stumps.

As the senior-most member of the team by a country mile, Dhoni easily slipped into the mentor's role and this came to the fore while he advised the new batch of rookie bowlers who were beginning to make waves for India.

When young 'Chinaman' bowler Kuldeep Yadav became only the third Indian bowler to take an ODI hat-trick in the second match at Kolkata (Dhoni's 300th in India colours), he was quick to credit Dhoni's advice. It helped him grab the wickets of Matthew Wade, Ashton Agar and Pat Cummins off successive deliveries to join Chetan Sharma (1987) and Kapil Dev (1991) in the rarefied hat-trick club. He credited the former captain with keeping up his morale after he had been belted for three sixes by Glenn Maxwell in the previous match at Chennai.

It was at Chennai that Dhoni's incessant stream of advice helped Yuzvendra Chahal dismiss Maxwell just when he appeared to be snatching the match out of India's grasp. No wonder the leg spinner referred to Kohli as his friend and Dhoni as his mentor after the match in which he took three wickets. It was also at Chennai that Dhoni's 79 made him the fourth Indian batsman to reach 100 international half-centuries across all three formats.

India wrapped up the series by winning the third ODI at Indore on September 24. The date was significant as it marked the 10th anniversary of India's victory in the final of the inaugural World T20 against Pakistan at Johannesburg, an event that changed the face of Indian and world cricket.

That was also Dhoni's first stint as captain and his calm and collected demeanour under pressure earned him the sobriquet of 'Captain Cool', something he has lived up to all these years.

Though hardly the talkative type, Dhoni has made it amply clear that he wishes to carry on till the 2019 World Cup in England. There are no guarantees in sport or life of course. But if he maintains his fitness and form till he is 38, his fourth World Cup would be a fitting swan-song for one of the most remarkable sportspersons the world has seen.



CHAPTER TWENTY ONE

Statistics

By Mohandas Menon

Mahendra Singh Dhoni

Born: Ranchi, Bihar; 7 July 1981

Batting style: Right hand middle order batsman

Fielding position: Wicket-keeper

Bowling: Right-arm medium (occasional)

Role: Wicket-keeper batsman

Teams: India, India A, Asia XI, India Seniors, India Blue, Bihar, Jharkhand, East Zone, Chennai Super Kings, Rising Pune Supergiant

Test debut vs Sri Lanka at Chennai, Dec 2-6, 2005

Last Test vs Australia at Melbourne, Dec 26-30, 2014 (retired)

ODI debut vs Bangladesh v India at Chittagong MAA, Dec 23, 2004

Last ODI vs Australia at Nagpur, Oct 1, 2017

T20I debut vs South Africa at Johannesburg, Dec 1, 2006

Last T20I vs Australia at Guwahati BS, Oct 10, 2017

In International matches in all formats											
Format	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Tests	90	144	16	4876	224	38.09	59.11	6	33	256	38
ODIs	306	263	75	9758	183*	51.90	88.57	10	66	286	103
T20Is	80	69	34	1225	56	35.00	112.62	0	1	43	24
Total	476	476	125	15859	224	45.18	78.25	16	100	585	165
International bowling: 132 balls, 98 runs, 1 wkt (Best: 1/14)											
In all first-class games in all formats											
Format	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
First-class	131	210	19	7038	224	36.84	56.64	9	47	364	57
List A (50 ov)	379	330	90	12338	183*	51.41	85.88	17	80	367	121
Twenty20	268	240	93	5358	73*	36.44	134.35	0	20	134	65
Total	778	780	202	24734	224	42.79	88.75	26	147	865	243
All formats bowling: 201 balls, 165 runs, 2 wkts (Best: 1/14)											

Test career records											
Opponents	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Australia	19	33	5	990	224	35.35	60.29	1	5	56	15
Bangladesh	3	4	2	193	89	96.50	70.95	0	2	12	3
England	21	37	2	1157	99	33.05	51.42	0	12	63	4
New Zealand	9	13	2	599	98	54.45	59.36	0	6	28	5
Pakistan	5	6	1	323	148	64.60	73.91	1	2	9	1
South Africa	12	20	1	647	132*	34.05	55.96	1	2	27	1
Sri Lanka	9	12	2	491	110	49.10	65.72	2	2	21	1
West Indies	12	19	1	476	144	26.44	64.67	1	2	40	8

Venue	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Australia	9	18	2	311	57*	19.43	46.34	0	1	31	4
Bangladesh	3	4	2	193	89	96.50	70.95	0	2	12	3
England	12	23	2	778	92	37.04	54.40	0	8	36	0
India	42	61	9	2380	224	45.76	59.55	5	15	102	25
New Zealand	4	6	1	272	68	54.40	60.44	0	3	18	1
Pakistan	3	3	0	179	148	59.66	89.05	1	0	7	1
South Africa	7	13	0	370	90	28.46	63.03	0	1	19	0
Sri Lanka	3	4	0	128	76	32.00	58.18	0	1	6	0
West Indies	7	12	0	265	74	22.08	62.79	0	2	25	4
Home/away	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Home	42	61	9	2380	224	45.76	59.55	5	15	102	25
Away	48	83	7	2496	148	32.84	58.68	1	18	154	13

Year	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
2005	3	5	1	149	51*	37.25	74.87	0	1	5	1
2006	12	19	0	557	148	29.31	71.59	1	2	36	8
2007	8	13	4	468	92	52.00	67.82	0	5	14	3
2008	12	19	1	633	92	35.16	52.48	0	6	26	5
2009	5	6	2	369	110	92.25	59.22	2	2	21	1
2010	13	19	1	749	132*	41.61	55.48	1	4	41	7
2011	12	21	2	511	144	26.89	58.06	1	3	47	3
2012	8	13	2	447	99	40.63	49.22	0	5	13	3
2013	8	12	2	459	224	45.90	72.39	1	0	16	6
2014	9	17	1	534	82	33.37	54.43	0	5	37	1

ODI career records											
Team	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
For India	303	260	74	9584	183*	51.53	88.10	9	66	283	100
For Asia XI	3	3	1	174	139*	87.00	125.17	1	0	3	3
Opponents	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Africa XI	3	3	1	174	139*	87.00	125.17	1	0	3	3
Australia	48	41	8	1355	139*	41.06	81.67	2	7	39	15
Bangladesh	18	14	5	465	101*	51.66	85.32	1	2	20	8
Bermuda	1	1	0	29	29	29.00	116.00	0	0	1	0
England	44	41	10	1425	134	45.96	88.95	1	10	36	16
Hong Kong	1	1	1	109	109*	-	113.54	1	0	1	3
Ireland	2	1	0	34	34	34.00	68.00	0	0	5	0
Netherlands	1	1	1	19	19*	-	47.50	0	0	1	0

New Zealand	21	20	5	773	84*	51.53	81.45	0	6	20	7
Pakistan	33	30	8	1230	148	55.90	90.50	2	9	32	8
Scotland	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	2	0
South Africa	30	27	4	727	92*	31.60	88.76	0	4	26	8
Sri Lanka	63	51	16	2311	183*	66.02	90.52	2	18	64	22
UAE	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	2	0
West Indies	33	29	14	899	95	59.93	90.26	0	7	28	12
Zimbabwe	6	3	2	208	85*	208.00	112.43	0	3	6	1
Venue	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Australia	32	28	7	860	88*	40.95	76.17	0	5	40	6
Bangladesh	20	17	6	610	101*	55.45	89.18	1	3	14	8
England	26	18	2	586	78*	36.62	86.94	0	6	20	10

India	116	105	31	4250	183*	57.43	93.39	8	23	88	46
Ireland	2	2	1	14	14*	14.00	93.33	0	0	2	0
Malaysia	4	3	0	43	23	14.33	75.43	0	0	7	1
New Zealand	12	10	4	541	85*	90.16	96.95	0	6	10	2
Pakistan	11	9	5	546	109*	136.50	105.40	1	5	16	3
Scotland	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	2	0
South Africa	15	12	0	301	65	25.08	78.79	0	2	14	4
Sri Lanka	38	35	11	1240	94	51.66	80.10	0	10	44	11
UAE	2	2	0	62	59	31.00	75.60	0	1	2	0
West Indies	19	17	6	532	95	48.36	80.36	0	3	20	10
Zimbabwe	8	5	2	173	67*	57.66	110.19	0	2	7	2

Home/away	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Home	113	102	30	4076	183*	56.61	92.38	7	23	85	43
Away	129	112	29	4088	101*	49.25	84.49	1	34	118	40
Neutral	64	49	16	1594	139*	48.30	90.20	2	9	83	20
Year	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
2004	3	3	1	19	12	9.50	135.71	0	0	4	2
2005	27	24	6	895	183*	49.72	103.11	2	3	19	6
2006	29	26	6	821	96	41.05	92.97	0	7	33	3
2007	37	33	8	1103	139*	44.12	89.60	1	7	31	18
2008	29	26	7	1097	109*	57.73	82.29	1	8	38	11
2009	29	24	7	1198	124	70.47	85.57	2	9	26	11
2010	18	17	4	600	101*	46.15	78.94	1	3	19	4
2011	24	22	9	764	91*	58.76	89.88	0	6	17	6
2012	16	14	6	524	113*	65.50	87.62	1	3	12	5

2013	26	20	8	753	139*	62.75	96.04	1	5	21	13
2014	12	10	2	418	79*	52.25	92.07	0	5	7	6
2015	20	17	3	640	92*	45.71	86.83	0	4	27	3
2016	13	10	0	278	80	27.80	80.11	0	1	13	4
2017	23	17	8	648	134	72.00	85.49	1	5	19	11
In each match innings	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Batting first	137	133	31	5456	148	53.49	95.12	8	36	114	51
Batting second	169	130	44	4302	183*	50.02	81.46	2	30	172	52
In day/nighters	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Day/night match	197	174	51	6315	139*	51.34	87.19	7	43	172	52
Day match	109	89	24	3443	183*	52.97	91.23	3	23	114	51

In results	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Matches won	173	140	61	5886	183*	74.50	97.28	7	40	192	72
Matches lost	114	114	9	3465	139*	33.00	76.63	3	22	84	29
Matches tied	4	4	2	217	78*	108.50	96.44	0	3	2	0
No result matches	15	5	3	190	88*	95.00	86.36	0	1	8	2
Batting position		Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50		
2nd		2	0	98	96	49.00	86.72	0	1		
3rd		16	4	993	183*	82.75	99.69	2	6		
4th		26	5	1223	109*	58.23	94.80	1	11		
5th		67	17	2693	134	53.86	87.77	4	15		
6th		118	36	3823	139*	46.62	83.93	1	28		

[illegible][illegible]

West Indies	7	5	1	100	43	25.00	128.20	0	0	3	2
Zimbabwe	3	2	1	28	19*	28.00	93.33	0	0	1	0
Venue	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Australia	6	5	3	103	48*	51.50	103.00	0	0	4	3
Bangladesh	11	8	7	92	24	92.00	167.27	0	0	9	4
England	7	7	2	121	30*	24.20	105.21	0	0	2	3
India	25	23	11	462	56	38.50	127.62	0	1	9	10
New Zealand	2	2	1	30	28*	30.00	83.33	0	0	1	0
South Africa	10	8	2	164	45	27.33	123.30	0	0	2	0
Sri Lanka	8	7	4	95	23*	31.66	114.45	0	0	7	2
USA	2	1	0	43	43	43.00	172.00	0	0	1	1
West dies	6	6	3	87	29	29.00	145.00	0	0	7	1
Zimbabwe	3	2	1	28	19*	28.00	93.33	0	0	1	0

Home/away	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Home	25	23	11	462	56	38.50	127.62	0	1	9	10
Away	26	23	13	392	48*	39.20	118.42	0	0	13	6
Neutral	29	23	10	371	43	28.53	121.24	0	0	21	8
Year	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
2006	1	1	0	0	0	0.00	0.00	0	0	1	0
2007	8	7	2	163	45	32.60	130.40	0	0	1	0
2008	1	1	0	9	9	9.00	33.33	0	0	0	0
2009	10	10	2	184	46	23.00	101.09	0	0	3	2
2010	5	5	3	85	29	42.50	149.12	0	0	6	1
2011	3	3	1	39	21	19.50	86.66	0	0	0	1
2012	14	12	7	268	48*	53.60	125.82	0	0	10	4
2013	1	1	1	24	24*	-	114.28	0	0	1	0
2014	7	5	4	77	27*	77.00	132.75	0	0	3	3

2015	2	2	1	25	20*	25.00	125.00	0	0	0	0
2016	21	16	11	238	43	47.60	149.68	0	0	16	11
2017	7	6	2	113	56	28.25	125.55	0	1	2	2
In each match innings		Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Batting first		40	16	683	56	28.45	118.57	0	1	15	12
Batting second		29	18	542	48*	49.27	128.13	0	0	28	12
In day/nighters	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
Day/night match	65	56	28	1000	56	35.71	121.21	0	1	34	22
Day match	15	13	6	225	43	32.14	129.31	0	0	9	2
In results	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St

Matches won	46	38	23	651	56	43.40	142.13	0	1	33	18
Matches lost	31	30	11	541	48*	28.47	106.07	0	0	8	5
Matches tied	1	1	0	33	33	33.00	106.45	0	0	1	0
No result	2	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	1	1
Batting position		Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50		
3rd		4	0	95	46	23.75	128.37	0	0		
4th		10	6	205	56	51.25	147.48	0	1		
5th		21	11	348	43	34.80	121.25	0	0		
6th		26	12	461	48*	32.92	110.02	0	0		
7th		8	5	116	38	38.66	145.00	0	0		
Captaincy	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
As captain	72	62	32	1112	48*	37.06	122.60	0	0	40	22

Not as captain	8	7	2	113	56	22.60	122.82	0	1	3	2
Major tournaments	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
T20 World Cup	33	29	14	529	45	35.26	123.88	0	0	21	11
T20 Asia Cup	5	4	4	42	20*	-	280.00	0	0	6	1
Total	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Cr	St
In T20Is	80	69	34	1225	56	35.00	122.62	0	1	43	24
Indian Premier League											
	Mts	Inns	NO	Runs	HS	Ave	SR	100	50	Ct	St
For Chennai Super Kings	129	116	40	2986	70*	39.29	139.27	0	15	58	23



A young Mahi (with wicket-keeping gloves) and his school team in Ranchi.

Photo by Mahadeo Sen.



Dhoni on his ODI debut vs Bangladesh at Chittagong (23 December, 2004).

Photo by K.R. Deepak. The Hindu Photo Archives.



Dhoni lashes out during his maiden ODI century against Pakistan at Visakhapatnam (5 April 2005).

Photo by V.V. Krishnan. The Hindu Photo Archives.



Back home in Ranchi, Mahi's parents Paan Singh and Devki watch their son in action in Visakhapatnam. His pet dog also appears riveted.
Photo by Mabadeo Sen.



Dhoni exults on guiding India to victory after scoring 183 not out against Sri Lanka at Jaipur (31 October 2005).

Photo by S. Subramaniam. The Hindu Photo Archives.



Drenched by his jubilant teammates at Vadodara at the end of the ODI series against Sri Lanka after being named Man of the Series (12 November 2005).

Photo by S. Subramaniam. The Hindu Photo Archives.



Batting on Test debut against Sri Lanka at Chennai (December 2005).

Photo by S. Subramaniam. The Hindu Photo Archives.



Pulverizing the Pakistani bowlers while scoring 148 at Faisalabad (January 2006).

Photo by S. Subramaniam. The Hindu Photo Archives.



Taking a spin with Suresh Raina on his new bike, reward for Raina being named Man of the Match against England at Faridabad (31 March 2005).
Photo by R.V Moorthy. The Hindu Photo Archives.



The triumphant Indian skipper with the World Twenty20 trophy in Johannesburg (24 September 2007).

Photo by Kamal Sharm.



Dhoni with Delhi Lieutenant-Governor Tejendra Khanna at the Feroze Shah Kotla ground during the felicitation function for the victorious ODI team after their return from Australia.

Photo by Kamal Sharma.



The Indian team after defeating Sri Lanka in December 2009 and gaining the world number one ICC Test ranking *Photo by K.R. Deepak.*
The Hindu Photo Archives



The Chennai Super Kings captain with percussionist Sivamani during the inaugural Indian Premier League.

Photo by Scorp News.



Chennai Super Kings celebrate winning the IPL title for the first time in Mumbai in 2010.

Photo by K.R. Deepak. The Hindu Photo Archives



MS Dhoni and bride Sakshi arrive at Chennai airport shortly after their 4 July, 2010 marriage.

Photo by K. Pichumani. The Hindu Photo Archives



Chennai Super Kings retain their IPL title at Chennai in 2011.

Photo by V. Ganesan.

The Hindu *Photo Archives*



A great moment in Indian cricket: Man of the Tournament Yuvraj Singh embraces Man of the Match MS Dhoni after his captain had hit the winning shot in the 2011 World Cup final against Sri Lanka at Mumbai.
Photo by K.R. Deepak. The Hindu Photo Archives



Dhoni in action during his double century against Australia in the first Test at Chennai in February 2013.

The Hindu Photo Archives



The triumphant Indian team at New Delhi with the Border-Gavaskar Trophy after whitewashing Australia 4-0 in the Test series.
The Hindu Photo Archives



That dramatic last-ball run out against Bangladesh in the ICC World T20 at Bengaluru in March 2016: Dhoni outsprints Mustafizur Rahman and India have won by 1 run.

Photo by K. Bhagya Prakash. The Hindu Photo Archives.